

Born Again From Atheism

How an Unbeliever Came to Faith, and What He Found There

JAMES BELL

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*The steady, unrelenting approach of Him whom I so
earnestly desired not to meet.*

C. S. LEWIS, SURPRISED BY JOY, 1955

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INTRODUCTION

The Man I Have to Introduce First

I NEED TO TELL you who was standing in the room before I tell you what happened in the room. This matters more than it seems. Most books about coming to faith skip the part where the writer was a real unbeliever, or they keep a cartoon on hand, a straw man wearing the writer's old clothes, easy to knock down because he was never quite alive. I will not do that to the man I was. He deserves better, and so do you, because you may be standing where he stood, and you can smell condescension from a long way off.

I was an atheist. Not the soft kind, not the man who had drifted out of a childhood faith and kept a Bible on a shelf out of sentiment. I did not have a childhood faith to drift out of. God was never a live option in my house, and by the time I was old enough to think about it on my own, I had reasons, and I could name them, and I thought the reasons were good. I still think some of them are good. That is one of the things I want to say to you early, so you keep reading. I do not think you are stupid. I was not stupid when I stood where you may

be standing. The arguments against God are not the arguments of foolish people. They are, some of them, the best thoughts of some of the best minds who ever lived, and if a man tells you otherwise, he is selling you something, and you should not buy it.

Here is what I believed, plainly. I believed the universe was what it was and did not owe anyone an explanation beyond its own workings. I believed that the appeal to God was the appeal a frightened animal makes to the dark, a projection of the father a child wants onto a sky that has no father in it. I believed that religion had done a great deal of harm, that it had blessed wars and burned women and shielded men who hurt children, and I believed that the people who kept defending it had to keep their eyes half closed to do so. I believed that when I died I would stop, the way a candle stops, and that the honest thing was to make the candle worth something while it burned. I did not think these beliefs were a wound. I thought they were maturity. I thought I had grown up, and that the people around me in the pews I did not sit in had not.

And underneath all of that, which I did not see for a long time, was a smaller and harder fact. I was raised without a father. He was not dead. He was simply not there, which is a particular kind of absence, the kind that is a decision someone made and kept making every morning by not coming back. I want to be careful here, because it would be too easy, too neat, to say that I did not believe in God the Father because I had no father, that the whole edifice of my unbelief was a boy's grief wearing a philosopher's coat. That is too easy, and it insults the arguments, and it insults the boy. But it would also be a lie to leave it out. The absence was in the room. It was in the room when I read Bertrand Russell

at nineteen and felt the clean cold relief of a man who owed the sky nothing. Something in me had already decided that fathers do not come, and a doctrine that promised one arriving felt, at the level below argument, like a cruelty dressed as a comfort.

So this book is going to do two things at once, and I am going to try to keep them honest with each other. It is going to tell you what happened to me, the actual sequence, the years and the reading and the resistance and the night it finally gave way. And it is going to take the arguments seriously, at their strongest, the way I once held them, because if I only tell you my story you can dismiss it as one man's weather, a mood that passed, and if I only give you arguments you can feel me reaching past your objections to grab your collar. I do not want to grab your collar. I spent a long time on the other side of that grip, and I hated it, and I will not do it to you.

What I will do is stay inside the room. That is the only place I know how to write from. Not from a safe distance where the answers are clean and the doubts are somebody else's. From inside, where a marriage is failing while a man argues about the ontological proof, where a diagnosis lands in the same week a sermon claims God is good, where the smart objection and the raw wound are the same size and will not separate. I came to faith in that room, not in a library, though the library mattered. The arguments did not save me. They cleared the ground. Something else walked across the cleared ground, and I will try to tell you what it was, though I have never been fully able to, and I have stopped being embarrassed about that.

Let me say what this book is not, so you are not braced for the wrong thing. It is not a book that will make you feel foolish

for doubting. If anything it will take your doubts more seriously than the atheist writers I read, because I think they gave up on the hardest questions too early, satisfied to have wounded religion when they could have pressed all the way through to whether anything at all is there. It is not a book of tricks, the little rhetorical traps where a believer sets you up two moves ahead and springs the checkmate. I do not believe anyone was ever loved into the kingdom by a checkmate. And it is not triumphant. I did not win. I lost, in the specific sense that the thing I had spent years defending was taken from me, and I have never been sorry, and I still remember what it cost.

There is a line in Lewis, in the book I put at the front of this one, where he calls himself the most dejected and reluctant convert in all England, brought in kicking and struggling and resentful, eyes darting for an escape. When I first read that I thought it was a pose, a bit of English understatement. Then it happened to me, and I understood that it was not a pose at all. It was a report. He was describing the thing accurately. A man who wants to believe and talks himself into it has done something psychological. A man who does not want to believe, who has arranged his whole intellectual life around not believing, and who finds himself believing anyway, against his preference, against his pride, against the boy who decided fathers do not come, has run into something outside himself. That is what I am claiming happened. You are right to be suspicious of the claim. I was suspicious of it while it was happening to me.

So here is the man I have to introduce. A boy with no father, grown into a man with reasons, sitting alone with his books and his relief, certain he had seen through the whole thing, unaware that the whole thing had not yet finished looking at him. Picture him clearly. Do not let me turn him

into a fool for the sake of a tidy conversion. He was me, and I owe him the truth, and the truth is that he was closer to the door than he ever knew, and that the door was not where he was looking, and that when it opened it did not open the way he would have designed it, and that he went through it at last not because he was argued across the threshold but because he was, in the oldest and most embarrassing word, found.

CHAPTER ONE

The Atheist I Actually Was

I WANT TO GIVE you the man in detail, because a portrait done from a distance is worthless and I have read too many of them. When a believer describes his atheist past in three sentences on the way to the good part, I stop trusting him. The atheist years were not a hallway I hurried through. They were most of my life, and they were not empty, and a great deal of what I now believe was formed by the honesty I learned when I believed nothing. So let me slow down and show you the room I actually lived in.

I was a serious young man, more serious than I had any right to be, and my seriousness took the shape it takes in a certain kind of fatherless boy, which is that I decided very early I would not be fooled. Being fooled was the great danger. Somewhere a man had made promises to a woman and to a child and the promises were not kept, and I do not think I ever formed this into a sentence, but I moved through the world as if the first duty of a mind was to refuse the comforting lie. I read early and I read to arm myself. By the

time I found the atheist writers I was already halfway to them, and they did not so much convert me as confirm what I had suspected, which is that the whole apparatus of religion was a beautiful, well-organized way of not looking at the truth.

And the truth, as I held it, was clean, and I loved its cleanness. The universe requires no author. Matter and energy behave according to laws we can write down, and where we cannot yet write them down we will be able to someday, and the gaps are getting smaller every year, and into those shrinking gaps the frightened have always stuffed their gods. Life is chemistry that learned to copy itself. Mind is what the brain does, the way digestion is what the stomach does, and when the brain stops the mind stops, and there is no ghost that steps out and floats away. Morality is a set of behaviors that helped our ancestors survive in groups, dressed up over the centuries in the language of commandment. And the sense that any of it means anything, that there is a purpose stitched into the fabric, is the last and most stubborn illusion, the one even clever people cannot shake, the projection of a small warm animal onto a cold enormous sky. I found this bracing. I want you to hear that I found it bracing and not bleak. There is a real dignity in facing what you take to be the truth without flinching, and I had it, and I do not disown it now.

I read Russell, and I loved him, the essay where he says that man is the product of causes that had no prevision of the end they were achieving, that his origin, his growth, his hopes and fears, his loves and beliefs, are but the outcome of accidental collocations of atoms. I read that the way another young man reads scripture, as a thing that ordered the world. I read the newer men later, the ones who came out swinging around the turn of the century, and I was thrilled by their

nerve, by the way they said in public what I felt was obviously true and socially forbidden. Religion poisons everything. God is a delusion. The evidence is absent and the demand for evidence is the only honest posture. I underlined and I nodded and I felt myself part of a company of the clear-eyed, and it was a good feeling, the feeling of belonging to the people who had grown up.

But I have to tell you the other thing that was in the room, because if I only give you the arguments I will have done what the conversion writers do in reverse. I will have made the atheist too clean. He was not clean. He was a young man who lay awake. The arguments were real and I meant them, but they did not fill the hours, and in the hours that they did not fill there was a specific ache that had no name in my vocabulary because my vocabulary had ruled out the things that might have named it. I would come to the end of a good day, a day where I had worked well and been with people I liked, and there would be a residue, a sense of something owed that no one was paying, an appetite with no object. I called it loneliness when I called it anything. I told myself it was the ordinary friction of being a mind in a world that did not care, and that the mature response was to stop expecting the world to care. That is a coherent answer. I gave it to myself for years. It did not touch the ache. It named the ache and filed it and the ache went on.

I want to be fair to my younger self about how he handled this, because he was not a fool and he was not in denial in the cheap sense. He knew the ache was there. He simply had a theory of it, and the theory was that evolution had built into us a hunger for meaning because the hunger was useful, and that the hunger firing with no meaning to feed on was exactly what you would predict on the atheist account, a vestigial

appetite, like the craving for sugar in a world that no longer requires us to hoard calories. This is a good answer. I still think it is the best answer available to the position, and I do not wave it away now that I am on the other side. But I notice, looking back, that the answer explained the ache without ever once reducing it, and that a hunger which cannot be reduced by being explained is a strange kind of hunger, and that I did not press on that strangeness because pressing on it frightened me in a way I could not have justified.

There was also, and I have to say this plainly, a great deal of pride in it. I do not mean the ordinary vanity everyone has. I mean that my unbelief had become load-bearing for my sense of who I was. I was the one who saw clearly. I was the one who would not be fooled. If you had shown me, in those years, an argument for God that I could not immediately answer, I would not have felt curiosity. I would have felt threat, and I would have gone looking for the answer not to find the truth but to restore my footing, and I know this because I did it more than once. That is not a philosophical posture. That is an emotional one wearing a philosophical coat, and the honest thing, years later, is to admit that my unbelief was never purely a conclusion. It was also a home. It was the place I had built where the father who did not come could not hurt me, because in that place there was no father anywhere, and an absence that is universal does not single you out. A cold that falls on everyone is not a rejection. I had made the whole sky cold so that my particular patch of cold would stop meaning what it meant.

*I had made the whole sky cold so that
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meaning what it meant.*

I DID NOT SEE that then. I want to be clear that I am not now claiming I secretly believed and was hiding from it. That is the move believers make that I most distrust, the smug little theory that all atheists really know God exists and are just suppressing it, which manages to call you a liar and a coward in one breath while pretending to be generous. I did not secretly believe. I genuinely did not believe, all the way down, with my whole mind. What I am saying is subtler and I think truer, which is that a mind is not a sealed chamber, that our conclusions have neighbors, and that some of my conclusions had grief for a neighbor and pride for a neighbor and fear for a neighbor, and that this is true of every human position including the religious ones, and that noticing it does not refute the position but it does keep you honest about how much of your certainty is reasoning and how much is the shape of the room you happen to be standing in.

So that was the atheist I actually was. Bright, serious, well-read, genuinely convinced, genuinely unfooled, and carrying under all of it an ache he had explained and a wound he had universalized and a pride he mistook for clarity. If you had met me you would have found me good company and hard to argue with. I would not have seemed like a man on the edge of anything. I did not feel like a man on the edge of anything. And that is exactly the point I most want to leave with you at the end of this first chapter, the thing I did not know and

could not have known. The approach Lewis describes, the steady unrelenting approach of the One he desired not to meet, does not feel like an approach from the inside. It feels like ordinary life. It feels like reading and working and lying awake. The man being approached is the last to know. I was being approached for years, and I called it loneliness, and I filed it, and I went on being the one who would not be fooled, right up until the fooling turned out to be the thing I had been doing to myself all along.

CHAPTER TWO

What the Atheist Is Really Asking

I HAVE TO TELL you something I only learned from the inside, and it took me years, and it is the hinge of this whole book. The arguments an atheist makes are not always the question the atheist is asking. I do not mean this in the dismissive way, where the believer says your objections are just wounds and waves the objections off. I mean the opposite. I mean that under the good arguments, which are real and which I still respect, there is usually a deeper question that the arguments are the honorable public form of, and that if you answer only the argument and never the question underneath it, you will win the debate and lose the man, and I have watched this happen a thousand times and I did it to myself for years.

Let me show you what I mean with the argument I made most often, the argument from evil. I would say to a believer, if your God is all good and all powerful, then explain the child dying of bone cancer, explain the tsunami, explain the man who prays for his wife and buries her anyway. And this is a

genuine argument, one of the oldest and hardest, and I am going to take it at full strength later in this book because it deserves nothing less. But I want to confess something about the way I used it, which is that I did not deploy it the way you deploy a chess move, coolly, to gain position. I deployed it hot. There was heat in it. And the heat was not the heat of a man who has calmly concluded there is no God. It was the heat of a man who is furious at someone, and you do not get furious at someone who is not there.

I did not notice this for a long time because the argument was so good that its goodness hid its temperature. But look at it plainly. If God does not exist, the child with bone cancer is a tragedy, a piece of blind bad luck in a universe with no eyes to see it and no conscience to answer for it, and there is no one to be angry at, and the correct emotional response is grief and then, eventually, the ordinary acceptance we extend to earthquakes and bad weather. You do not shake your fist at continental drift. But I was shaking my fist. I was not merely observing that the suffering existed. I was holding someone responsible for it, and the someone I was holding responsible was the God I said did not exist, and a man cannot hold a nonexistent being responsible without giving away that the being is more real to him, at some level below his stated position, than he is prepared to admit.

Now hear me carefully, because the believers who notice this usually ruin it. They notice the heat and they say, aha, so you do believe, you are just angry at God, and this is a trap and a cheap one, and it made me want to walk out of every room it was sprung in. Because it is not true that I believed. I did not believe. What is true is stranger and I think more important. It is that the moral outrage in my atheism was borrowing from a warehouse my atheism could not account

for. I was standing on a conviction that the child's suffering was genuinely, cosmically wrong, wrong in a way that indicted the structure of things, and that conviction is very hard to ground if the structure of things is just atoms and indifference. On my own account, the child's suffering was not wrong. It was merely unpleasant, unfortunate, the kind of thing that happens when chemistry runs its course in a universe with no preferences. The word wrong was smuggled in from somewhere else. And I did not want to look at where.

So the question under my argument was not really is there a God who permits suffering. The question under my argument was closer to this: I know, I cannot help knowing, that this ought not to be, and where does that knowledge come from, and what do I do with it, and is my rage at the injustice of the universe a sign that I am a fluke that hallucinates justice, or a sign that justice is real and I am made to know it and its absence here is a violation and not merely a fact. That is a much bigger and more dangerous question, and I did not ask it, because asking it might have led somewhere I had decided in advance I would not go.

*The man who is angriest at God for the
world's cruelty believes, with
everything in him, that mercy is real
and should run the world.*

THIS IS WHAT I mean when I say the atheist is often asking more than he says. The doubt about God, in the people I have known and in the man I was, is very rarely a cool inference

from insufficient evidence, though it is dressed as one and it is sincere in that dress. Underneath there is almost always a wound and a longing, and the two are usually the same size, and the wound is often exactly proportioned to a good the person believes in and cannot find. The man who is angriest at God for the world's cruelty is a man who believes, with everything in him, that mercy is real and that the world should run on it. The man who cannot forgive the church for its hypocrisy is a man who believes, more than the churchgoers do sometimes, that holiness should be real and that the pretending is a desecration of something that ought to exist. These are not the objections of people who have concluded that nothing matters. They are the objections of people who are haunted by mattering and cannot find its source and are enraged at the candidates who claim to supply it and fail.

I want to be scrupulously fair to my old position here, because it has a reply, and the reply is not stupid. The reply is that of course we believe things matter, we are social animals built by selection to feel that cooperation is sacred and cruelty is wrong, because tribes that felt that way outcompeted tribes that did not, and the feeling of cosmic wrongness is just that evolved feeling firing at full strength, a very old and very useful illusion of objectivity draped over what is really a survival mechanism. I held that reply for years and I held it in good faith. But I will tell you the crack in it that I could not, in the end, plaster over. The reply explains why I would have the feeling. It does not explain why the feeling would be true. And I could not, when the child was actually dying in front of me and not merely in an argument, believe that my horror was merely a useful misfiring. The horror presented itself to me as a perception, not a mood. It

said, this is really wrong, wrong in the fabric, and not just wrong-for-a-primate-shaped-thing-like-you. And I trusted that perception in the moment more than I trusted the theory that dissolved it, and a man who trusts his moral perceptions more than his metaphysics has already, without knowing it, started to move.

So if you are the skeptic reading this, here is what I am asking you to do, and it is not to concede any argument, and it is not to feel foolish, because you are not foolish and the arguments are strong. I am asking you to notice the temperature of your own objections. Notice where the heat is. Notice whether your quarrel with God is the cool quarrel you have with a hypothesis you find unsupported, the way you might dismiss astrology, with a shrug, no heat in it at all, or whether it is the hot quarrel you have with someone who has failed you, someone who owed you something and did not pay. Because you do not, I think, shrug at God the way you shrug at astrology. Almost no one does. And that asymmetry is the most interesting fact about modern unbelief, and it was the most interesting fact about mine, and I ignored it for a decade because it was pointing at a door I had promised myself I would not walk through.

CHAPTER THREE

The Argument From Suffering, Taken at Full Strength

I AM GOING TO give you the argument from evil the way I once made it, at its full strength, without the padding believers use to soften it before they answer it. If I flinch here, you should close the book, because a man who cannot state the hardest objection at its hardest has not earned the right to answer it. This is the argument that kept me longest, and it is the argument I still think is the strongest one against the God I now worship, and I will not pretend it is not.

Here it is. A God worth the name is supposed to be good, all the way good, better than the best human being you have ever known, and powerful, able to do anything that can be done. Now take a child. Take a specific child, not a category. Take a four-year-old with a cancer that starts in the bones, that spreads while her parents pray, that takes a year to kill her and takes it slowly, with pain that the strongest drugs only blunt. Her parents are good people. They did nothing to

earn this. She did nothing, could not have done anything, she is four. And a God who is good and who is powerful watched the whole thing, every night of it, and did not lift a finger that anyone could see, though lifting the finger would have cost him, being all powerful, precisely nothing. A human being who could stop a child's torture at no cost to himself and chose not to would be a monster, and we would not soften our judgment of him by saying he must have had a reason we cannot see. We would say the reason had better be extraordinary, and we would not hand him the benefit of the doubt merely because he asked for it. Why does God get the benefit of the doubt that we would extend to no one else.

That is the argument. Do not let anyone rush you past it. The believer's first instinct is to reach for free will, to say that God permits evil because he permits freedom, and freedom is worth the cost. But the child's cancer is not anyone's free choice. No human being willed those cells to divide. This is not the evil that men do to each other, which the free-will answer at least addresses. This is the evil that the world does on its own, the earthquake, the virus, the flood, what the old theologians called natural evil, and the free-will answer does not touch it. And the second instinct is to say that suffering builds character, that the soul is refined in the furnace, and this is obscene when you say it over the body of a four-year-old who did not live long enough to have a character to refine. And the third instinct is to say we cannot understand God's purposes, they are higher than ours, and I want to tell you exactly why that answer used to enrage me, because it is not an answer, it is the refusal of an answer wearing the robes of humility. It says, in effect, that no possible evidence could count against God's goodness, because any evil at all can be absorbed into the mystery. But a goodness that no evidence

could ever count against is not goodness. It is a word we have decided to keep applying no matter what we see, and a word that survives all possible evidence has stopped meaning anything.

I made this argument hot, as I told you, and I want to honor the heat rather than explain it away too quickly, because the heat was the truest part. When I stood at the edge of real suffering, not the suffering in the syllogism but the suffering in the hospital room, and I have stood at that edge many times now as a pastor, more times than I ever did as an unbeliever, the argument stops being an argument and becomes a howl. And the howl is right. That is the thing I did not expect to find on the other side of faith, that the howl is not something faith has to talk you out of. The howl is in the book. It is in the Psalms, where a man screams at God for hiding his face and does not apologize for screaming. It is in Job, where a righteous man loses everything and his friends show up to defend God with exactly the arguments I have just called obscene, and at the end of the book God does not commend the friends. God is angry at the friends. He says they have not spoken rightly of him, and the man who screamed, the man who demanded God answer for himself, that man God vindicates. I did not know this when I was an atheist. I thought the Bible was on the side of the friends. It is not. It is on the side of the man in the ashes with the broken skin who says, I will not pretend this is fine.

So here is where I have landed, and I offer it not as a solution, because I do not have a solution, and I distrust everyone who says they do. I offer it as the place where I could finally stand. The problem of suffering is not a problem that faith solves. It is a problem that faith refuses to let you set down, and I have come to think that is its terrible integrity.

The atheist answer to the child with bone cancer is, in the end, that there is no answer and no question, that it is simply what happens, blind cells in a blind universe, tragic but not wrong, because nothing is wrong, because wrongness requires a standard the universe does not supply. And I want to be honest that this answer has a kind of peace in it. If no one is responsible, no one has failed you. I lived in that peace for years. But I could not, finally, make myself believe that the child's suffering was not wrong, only unfortunate. Every cell in me insisted it was wrong, wrong against something, a violation of how things are meant to be, and the word meant would not come out of my mouth without smuggling in a meaner, and I could not find the meaner in the atoms.

*Faith did not answer the suffering. It
refused to let me pretend the suffering
was fine, and it refused to let me
pretend it was meaningless, and I had
to live in the gap between.*

WHAT FAITH GAVE ME was not an answer to the problem of evil. It was a different problem, and I have come to prefer the different problem, though I want to be careful not to sell it as a comfort, because it is not a comfort, it is a companionship. The Christian claim is not that God explains the child's suffering. The Christian claim is that God entered it. That the God who is on trial in the argument from evil did not stay in the dock and offer a defense. He got up and walked into the

worst of it, into a body, into pain, into the specific human experience of crying out to heaven and hearing nothing, because on the cross the Son cries out asking why God has forsaken him and receives no answer either. Whatever else that is, it is not a God at a safe distance offering theodicies. It is a God who has taken the argument from evil into his own body and let it do its worst to him. I did not believe this for a long time. But I noticed, even as an unbeliever, that it was a stranger and better story than the one I had assumed Christianity told, and that it did not do the thing I most despised, which was to justify the suffering. It does not justify it. It joins it. And a God who joins the suffering he has not yet ended is a harder God to be angry at than the absentee I had built my objection around, though I reserve, and the book reserves, the right to still be angry, because the child is still dead, and I will not pretend that she is not.

CHAPTER FOUR

Why Science Did Not Settle It the Way I Thought

I BELIEVED, IN THE way that many educated unbelievers believe, that science had settled the question, and I want to describe that belief carefully because it is not quite a belief about any particular fact. It is a mood, a background confidence, a sense that the whole enterprise of empirical inquiry had swept the board clear of gods the way it had swept it clear of humors and phlogiston and the crystalline spheres. I did not usually argue this. I did not have to. It sat under my arguments like a floor. Science explains, religion asserts, and the territory religion once claimed keeps shrinking as the explanations advance, and only a fool bets on the shrinking side. That was the mood, and I lived inside it, and it felt less like a position I held than like the plain shape of the modern world.

I want to say first what is true in it, because a great deal is true in it, and the believers who deny this embarrass

themselves and their faith. Science works. It is the most spectacularly successful method human beings have ever devised for finding out how the physical world behaves, and the person typing these words and the person reading them are both alive longer and in less pain because of it, and every time a preacher sneers at science he is sneering at the thing that saved his own children from diseases that would have buried them a century ago. The explanatory reach of physics and chemistry and biology is real and it is vast and it is still growing, and there is no honest way to be a modern person and pretend otherwise. I do not pretend otherwise. I believe in the round earth and the old universe and the common descent of living things, all of it, without crossing my fingers, and my faith does not require me to unbelieve a single well-established fact, and if it did I would have a harder time keeping it.

But here is where the mood began to crack for me, and it cracked not because I read a clever apologist but because I started to look closely at what the mood was actually claiming, and I found that it was claiming more than science could deliver, and that the extra claim was not itself a scientific claim at all. Science tells you how the physical world behaves. It tells you the mechanism. It does not tell you, and by its own method cannot tell you, whether the mechanism is all there is. The statement the physical world is all there is, is not a finding of physics. There is no experiment that yields it. It is a philosophical premise that many scientists hold and that gets smuggled into the culture wearing the lab coat that science earned, and I had swallowed it whole, believing I was being empirical when I was in fact being metaphysical without noticing. The confusion is easy to make. I made it for years. The success of science at answering the how questions

had convinced me that the why questions were illegitimate, when in fact science had simply, and wisely, declined to ask them.

Take the deepest one, the one that would not leave me alone once I let it in. Why is there something rather than nothing. Science, running backward, gives you a magnificent story, the expansion, the cooling, the first elements, the stars that cooked the heavier atoms in their cores and then died and scattered them so that planets and eventually people could be built from stellar ash. It is a better creation story than any I found in mythology, and I mean that. But run it all the way back and you arrive at the initial conditions, the laws, the fundamental constants, and science can describe them exquisitely and cannot tell you why there is a universe that obeys them rather than no universe at all. Why is there a set of laws for anything to obey. Why is there anything for the laws to govern. Some very good physicists have tried to answer this by redefining nothing until it becomes a quantum vacuum seething with fields, but a quantum vacuum with fields and laws is not nothing, it is a very elaborate something, and the question simply steps back and asks why there is that. The question does not go away by being renamed. It is the oldest question and science, for all its power, does not touch it, and the honest physicists say so.

And there was a second thing, harder for me than the first. The laws of physics, the constants, the numbers that set the strength of the forces, appear to be balanced on a knife edge such that if they were slightly different in almost any direction there would be no stars, no chemistry, no life, no observers, nothing but a dead uniform soup or a universe that collapsed before it began. I was not, and am not, going to pretend this proves a designer, because there are serious

responses to it, the most serious being that there may be an enormous number of universes with different constants and we necessarily find ourselves in one of the rare ones that permits observers, since only such a one could contain anyone to notice. That is a real answer and I do not dismiss it. But notice what it costs. To avoid the inference to a mind behind the fine-tuning, the naturalist posits an unobservable and possibly unobservable-in-principle infinity of other universes, which is a metaphysical extravagance at least as large as the God it was invoked to avoid, and which is itself not a finding of science but a philosophical move to protect a prior commitment. I was willing to pay that price when I had to. What I was not willing to admit, for a long time, was that I was paying a price, that my position also rested on things I could not see and could not test, that I too was making a leap and calling it caution.

*I thought I had science and the believer
had faith. I discovered we both had
faith, and mine had simply learned to
dress as its opposite.*

THE MIND WAS THE third thing, and it was the one that finally broke the mood for good. I had believed that mind is what the brain does, full stop, that consciousness is a process in neural tissue and will be fully explained when the neuroscience is complete, and I still think the neuroscience will explain a great deal and I follow it with admiration. But there is a gap that the neuroscience, however complete,

seems structurally unable to close, the gap between the physical description of what the brain is doing and the fact that there is something it is like to be me, the redness of red, the ache of the ache, the interior light that is on when I am awake. You can describe every neuron firing and you will have described a mechanism, and the mechanism does not obviously require that anyone be home, and yet someone is home. I am home. And the confident materialism I held had no account of this that did not, when I pressed it, either deny the thing it was supposed to explain, telling me my own inner life was an illusion, which is a strange thing to be told by your own inner life, or quietly help itself to resources that pure matter is not supposed to have. I do not say this proves the soul. I say that the smug certainty that science had closed the question was itself unscientific, a philosophy masquerading as a result, and that when I finally saw this the floor under my unbelief turned out to be not bedrock but a conviction I had inherited and never examined, and a man who discovers that his floor is a conviction is standing on something very different than he thought he was standing on.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Hiddenness of God

THERE IS AN OBJECTION to God that I think is stronger than the argument from evil, though it gets less attention, and it is the one that mattered most in the actual texture of my unbelief, so I have to give it its own chapter. It is the argument from hiddenness, and it goes like this. If there is a God who wants to be known, who wants relationship with human beings, who will hold us accountable for whether or not we believe in him, then his continued hiddenness is not just puzzling, it is a moral failure. A loving parent does not hide from the child and then punish the child for not finding him. If God exists and wants me to know him, he could make himself known. He has not. The most natural explanation of a God who is nowhere to be found is that there is no God to find, and the elaborate reasons believers give for the silence are the reasons you give when you are covering for someone who is not there.

I felt this one in my body, not just my mind, and I want to tell you why, and it goes back to the room I described at the beginning. A man raised without a father knows something about being available to be found and not being found. He knows what it is to leave the door open, to keep leaving it

open past all reason, and to hear nothing on the other side. So when the believers told me that God was there, right there, closer than my own breath, and all I had to do was open myself and I would sense his presence, and I opened myself, because I was not too proud to try, more than once, in the dark, in the quiet, saying into the room, if you are there, then be there, and the room stayed a room, I felt the old thing. I felt the specific silence I had felt as a boy. And it confirmed everything. It was not merely that I had no evidence for God. It was that I had tried the experiment the believers themselves proposed, and the experiment had returned the same silence I already knew, and the silence had a familiar shape, and the shape was of a father who does not come when you call.

Now I could stop there, and many books would, having stacked the emotional weight on the atheist side to make the eventual turn feel larger. But I promised to take the objection at full strength and then keep going, and keeping going means saying that the hiddenness argument assumes something I later had to question, which is that it assumes it knows what it would look like for God to make himself known, and that its picture of the disclosure is a picture that might, on examination, be incoherent with the kind of thing God is supposed to be. Suppose, and I only ask you to suppose, that God is not an object in the world, one more thing among the things, a very large and powerful item that could in principle be pointed to, photographed, cornered, verified. Suppose God is more like the source of there being anything at all, closer to the condition of the world than to a fact in it, more like the light by which you see than a thing you could turn and look at directly. Then the demand, show yourself the way an object shows itself, might be like demanding that your own eyes

appear in your own field of vision. The thing you are looking with does not show up as one of the things you are looking at, and its absence from the list of visible objects is not evidence that it is not there.

I did not find this comforting when I first met it, and I will not pretend it dissolved the objection, because it does not dissolve the emotional core, which is the silence, and the silence is real, and I will not lie about the silence. But it did make me notice that my demand for God to appear had a specific shape, and that the shape was, when I looked at it, a demand for God to be exactly the kind of thing whose nonexistence I was already assuming, an item in the world, a father-shaped object that could walk through a door. And there is a passage in the tradition that I could not get out of my head once I found it, where it says that God dwells in unapproachable light, and another where the prophet finds God not in the wind or the earthquake or the fire but in a sound of sheer silence, and I began to wonder, uncomfortably, whether the silence I had taken as proof of absence was being read by the very tradition I was rejecting as one of the ordinary modes of the presence, and whether I had been so certain about how a real God would behave that I had ruled out in advance the God who might actually be there.

*I had performed the experiment the
believers proposed and gotten silence,
and I called it my result, without
asking whether I had understood what
a positive result would even be.*

HERE IS WHAT FINALLY shifted for me, and it is not an argument, it is closer to a suspicion that grew until I could not hold the door shut against it. The hiddenness argument assumes that if God existed and loved us, he would make his existence overwhelming, undeniable, coercive, the way a floodlight is undeniable. But a love that makes itself undeniable in that way is not asking for love in return, it is compelling assent, and there is a real question whether the thing God is said to want, which is not agreement but relationship, not the acknowledgment of a fact but the free turning of a person, could even survive that kind of disclosure. If God appeared in the sky tomorrow in letters of fire, I would believe, the way I believe in the mailman, and that belief would be worth exactly nothing as love, because it would be forced. The hiddenness might be, and I only say might, the necessary condition of the freedom that makes the whole thing worth anything, the space God leaves so that the turning toward him, if it happens, is a turning and not a reflex. I resisted this for a long time because it sounded like the covering story I had accused it of being. What changed was not that the story got better. What changed was that I noticed my own certainty about how a good God must behave was the certainty of a man who had never been a good God and had no idea, and that I had been treating my failure to find him as his failure to be there, when it might, just might, have been the shape of an invitation I did not know how to read.

CHAPTER SIX

The Harms of the Church, Faced Honestly

I HAVE TO WRITE this chapter carefully, because it would be the easiest thing in the world to write it badly, either by minimizing what the church has done, which would forfeit your trust and rightly, or by performing a fashionable self-flagellation that costs nothing and impresses no one. The harms are real. I held them as one of my strongest reasons, and they were not a bad reason, and now that I am a pastor I hold them still, from the inside, where they are heavier, not lighter, because now they are done in the name of the thing I love, and a wound to something you love is worse than a wound to something you oppose.

Let me name them without flinching. The church has blessed wars and sanctified conquest and handed God's approval to men with swords who wanted it for their own reasons. It has owned human beings and quoted scripture to justify the owning, and in my own country it built a theology of slavery elaborate enough to let good churchgoing people sleep at night while they held other human beings as

property. It has burned dissenters and tortured heretics and run inquisitions. It has told women for centuries that their subjection was divinely ordered. And in my own lifetime, the harm that broke the most trust, it has sheltered men who raped children, moved them from parish to parish, protected the institution over the bodies of the young, and called the covering up a matter of prudence. I do not soften any of this. When I was an atheist I said the church was a machine for laundering the worst human impulses through the language of the highest human ideals, and I was not wrong that this has happened, again and again, on a scale that should stop the mouth of anyone who wants to defend the institution as though its record were clean.

So why am I still here. That is the honest question and I owe you an honest answer, and the answer is not that the harms are outweighed by the good works, though there are enormous good works, the hospitals and the schools and the abolitionists who were also Christians and the ones who hid the hunted at the cost of their own lives. I do not reach for the ledger, because the ledger is obscene when the debit side includes children, and no quantity of hospitals buys back a single one. The ledger is the wrong tool. Here is the answer I actually have, and it is smaller and I think truer. The church's record is exactly what its own scriptures predict. This is the strange thing I did not expect. The book does not present a community of the good. It presents a community of the forgiven, which is a different and much less flattering thing, a gathering of people whose central confession is that they are not good, that they do the thing they hate, that the capacity for the worst runs through every one of them and is not fixed by joining. When the church behaves monstrously it is not violating its own account of human nature. It is confirming it.

The scandal is real, but it is not the scandal of a pure institution corrupted. It is the scandal of a hospital full of the sick, some of whom are also, at any given time, spreading the disease.

Now I know exactly how that can sound, and I would have pounced on it when I was on the other side, because it looks like the ultimate escape hatch, the theology that cannot be embarrassed because it predicted its own embarrassment, so that every atrocity becomes, perversely, a confirmation. If the church were good, that proves the faith, and if the church is wicked, that also proves the faith, and a claim that both outcomes confirm is a claim that no outcome could ever disconfirm, which is the mark of a claim that means nothing. I felt the force of that then and I feel it now and I will not pretend it away. But here is the distinction that I think survives it, and I offer it plainly. The faith does not merely predict the church's failures. It condemns them. It provides the standard by which they are failures. The man who exposed the theology of slavery as a blasphemy did not do it by leaving Christianity behind, in most cases. He did it by turning Christianity's own weapons on the church, by saying you have betrayed the one you claim to follow, and the reason that charge has force is that the standard is internal to the faith and not imported from outside it. The church's crimes are measured against Christ, and they are found wanting against Christ, and it is Christ, not the church, that the faith asks you to believe in, though the church is the only doorway most of us will ever walk through to reach him, and the doorway is stained, and I will not lie about the stains.

The church did not fail to be what it claimed. It confirmed exactly what it claimed about human beings, which is the last thing I expected its failures to do.

WHAT FINALLY LET ME stay, once I had come in, was the discovery that the sharpest critics of the church, the ones whose indictments I had borrowed as an atheist, were very often believers, that the tradition contains its own fiercest prosecution, that the prophets I had never read spent most of their pages screaming at the religious people of their day for exactly the hypocrisy I thought I had discovered, that the standard by which I judged the church guilty was a standard the church had, against its own interest, preserved and handed to me. I had thought I was standing outside Christianity to condemn it. I found, later and to my discomfort, that the ground I was standing on to make the condemnation had been poured by the very thing I was condemning, that my sense that the abuse of the powerless is a cosmic outrage and not merely a policy failure came from somewhere, and that when I traced it back it did not lead to the atheist writers, who had inherited it too, but to an older source, a source that said the powerful will answer for the powerless and that the measure of a people is how it treats the least of these. I did not become a Christian because the church was good. I became one in spite of the church, having discovered that the case against the church was itself, all the

way down, a Christian case.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Secular Age, and Why Belief Got Hard

THERE IS A BOOK I did not read until after I had come to faith, and I wish I had read it before, because it explained to me why my unbelief had felt not like a conclusion I reached but like the water I swam in. The book is Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age*, published in 2007, and it is enormous and difficult and I will not pretend I have mastered it, but it did something for me that no work of apologetics did. It did not argue me toward God. It explained the shape of the room I had been standing in, and once I could see the room, I could see that some of what I had taken for the plain obvious truth was in fact a particular arrangement of furniture that had been built up over five hundred years, and that I had mistaken the furniture for the floor.

Taylor asks a question that had never occurred to me, and it is a better question than the ones I was asking. He asks, why was it virtually impossible not to believe in God in the year 1500, and why is it, for many of us, so easy in the present not only not to believe but to find belief barely thinkable, a

thing that respectable educated people have quietly set aside. Notice what the question is not. It is not, has the evidence changed, have we discovered facts that refute God, because we have not, there was no experiment run between 1500 and now that closed the case. Something else changed. The conditions of belief changed. What was once the sea everyone swam in became one option among many, and then, for a certain kind of person in a certain kind of place, an option that felt increasingly like a survival from a childish past. I had thought this shift was the advance of knowledge dispelling superstition. Taylor showed me it was something far more interesting and far less flattering to my side.

Here is the part that undid me. In 1500 the world was what Taylor calls porous. The self was open to forces outside it, to grace and to the demonic, to meanings that came from beyond and pressed in. Over the centuries, and for reasons that had as much to do with piety as with skepticism, the world was slowly sealed off, disenchanted, and the self was reconceived as what Taylor calls buffered, bounded, insulated, the sole author of its own meanings, protected from anything reaching in from outside. And the buffered self experiences the absence of God not as an argument but as an atmosphere. It is not that we looked for God and failed to find him. It is that we became the kind of self that is structurally closed to the search, that experiences transcendence as at most a private feeling generated inside the skull rather than a reality pressing in from beyond it. My sense that God was absent was not, Taylor helped me see, a neutral observation. It was the native experience of a particular kind of self that my whole civilization had spent centuries constructing, and I had taken the experience of that self as though it were a window onto reality, when it might have been a wall I had

been trained not to see.

I want to be careful, because this can be misused, and a lazy believer will take Taylor and say, see, your unbelief is just your conditioning, you are a product of your age, checkmate. That is not the argument and Taylor would not endorse it. The buffered self is not an error that can be refuted. It is, in many ways, an achievement, and it carries real goods, the goods of interiority and moral seriousness and the refusal of cheap enchantment, and I would not give those goods back. Moreover the same argument cuts the other way. If my unbelief is shaped by my age, so is the belief of the man in 1500, and you cannot use the point to discredit one side without discrediting both. Taylor knows this. His point is not that unbelief is false because it is conditioned. His point is subtler and it is the point that mattered to me. It is that unbelief is not the neutral default it imagines itself to be, that it does not sit at some view from nowhere from which belief looks like an added and unnecessary hypothesis, that it is itself a historically constructed and deeply particular way of being a self, with its own blind spots, its own things it cannot see precisely because of where it is standing.

*I had thought my unbelief was the
ground I stood on. It turned out to be a
house that had been built around me
over five hundred years, and I had
mistaken the walls for the horizon.*

AND ONCE I SAW that, a certain confidence drained out of my position, not because it was refuted but because it was relativized, set among other positions rather than above them. I had felt, as an unbeliever, that I occupied the vantage of maturity, that belief was the thing you grew out of and unbelief the thing you grew into, and that history ran in one direction, from credulity toward clarity. Taylor showed me that this feeling was itself a story my age tells about itself, a self-congratulating narrative that Taylor calls a subtraction story, the story that says we simply subtracted the illusions and what was left was the truth. But nothing so simple happened. We did not subtract God and find the world as it always really was underneath. We constructed a new way of experiencing the world, with new goods and new losses, and one of the losses was that a whole dimension of reality, whatever the porous self had been open to, became invisible to us, and we called its invisibility its nonexistence, which is exactly the error I had made when I called God's silence his absence.

I did not become a believer by reading Taylor. Books do not do that, or they did not do it to me. But I stopped being able to believe that my unbelief was the simple result of thinking clearly, and I started to see it as a location, a particular window in a particular building at a particular hour of history, with its own frame, its own tint of glass, its own things it was structurally unable to show me. And a man who has come to see his certainty as a location rather than a summit has already, though he does not yet know it, begun to look for the door.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Thing Beauty Kept Doing to Me

I HAVE SAVED FOR its own chapter the thing that no argument accounts for and that did more to me than all the arguments together, and I approach it with reluctance, because it is the least defensible and the most real. Beauty. There was a thing that beauty kept doing to me across all the years of my unbelief, and my position had an explanation for it, a good one, and the explanation was correct as far as it went and it did not go far enough, and the gap between where the explanation ended and where the experience kept going is, I have come to think, one of the places God was standing the whole time, in plain sight, unrecognized.

Let me describe the thing itself before I theorize about it, because the theorizing is where it goes wrong. There were moments, and I could not schedule them and they did not come when I wanted them, when some particular thing, a passage of music, a shaft of afternoon light across a field, a line of poetry, the specific quality of a certain autumn, would open in me a longing so acute that it was almost

indistinguishable from grief, and the longing was not for the thing itself, that was the strange part, I did not want to possess the field or repeat the music. The music was not the object of the desire. The music was the occasion of a desire that pointed through the music toward something the music was not, something I had no name for, that I have never had a name for, that felt like homesickness for a home I had never been to. Lewis called it Joy, with a capital letter, and distinguished it sharply from happiness and from pleasure, and said it was itself a kind of unhappiness or the wanting of something more desirable than any satisfaction, and when I read that I had the vertigo of a man who finds his private experience described in a stranger's book.

Now my unbelief had an explanation and I will give it its full due. The explanation is that this longing is an evolved response, that we are pattern-seeking meaning-hungry animals, that certain configurations of sound and light and language trigger deep reward circuitry, that the sense of transcendence is a neurological event, a flooding of certain systems, and that its feeling of pointing beyond itself is exactly the illusion you would expect such a mechanism to produce, since a creature whose longings felt cosmic would be more motivated than one whose longings felt merely chemical. This is a real explanation. I believed it. I do not now think it is false. Beauty does trigger reward circuitry, and the longing is a neurological event, and I have no quarrel with any of that as far as it goes.

But here is where it stopped going far enough for me, and I want to put the difficulty precisely, because the imprecise version is worthless. The explanation accounts for the existence of the longing. It does not account for the structure of the longing, and the structure is the strange part. The

longing has a specific and consistent form, which is that it presents itself as a desire for something absent, something not contained in any object in the world, something the objects only point toward, so that every time you pursue the beauty to its source it turns out the source is not there, the field is only a field, the music is only music, and the wanting slides off the object and keeps pointing beyond it. Now, said Lewis, and said something older than Lewis, we do not have desires without objects. Hunger corresponds to food, thirst to water, the sexual desire to its fulfillment, and where there is a persistent, structural, universal human desire, it is at least worth asking whether it too corresponds to something real, whether the very shape of the longing, aimed always past the world, is data about a country the world is not, that the world is only the rumor of.

*The music was never the thing I
wanted. It was the messenger, and I
kept shooting the messenger and
wondering why the message would not
stop coming.*

I RESISTED THIS ARGUMENT, and I want to tell you how I resisted it, because the resistance is instructive. I said, the desire without an object simply means the desire is a malfunction, a hunger that fires with nothing to feed it, and that some desires are indeed like this, and that the ache is one of them, a bug and not a signal. And this is a coherent

reply and I gave it for years. But notice what it costs, and it costs more than the theists let on and more than I let myself see. It requires you to hold that the deepest, most consistent, most nearly universal longing of the human heart is the one desire, alone among all our desires, that corresponds to nothing, that is pure malfunction, that the creature is built to want above all things the one thing that is not there. And I found, in the end, that I could not quite believe this, not because I had an argument against it but because the experience itself would not accept the demotion. When the longing came, in the light on the field, it did not feel like a malfunction. It felt like the most reliable thing in me, the truest, the one experience I would least want to be talked out of, and a man who trusts the reality of his hunger more than the theory that explains it away has already, in the deepest part of him, begun to suspect there is bread.

CHAPTER NINE

The Moral Argument I Could Not Get Rid Of

I TOLD YOU EARLIER that when I made the argument from evil, I was borrowing from a warehouse my atheism could not account for, and I want to open that warehouse now, because what was in it turned out to be the thing I could least explain and least abandon, and it worked on me longer and quieter than any other single consideration. It is the fact of moral obligation, the sheer stubborn sense that some things are really wrong, wrong in themselves, wrong whether or not anyone agrees, wrong in a way that lays a claim on me from outside me, and that this claim is not the kind of thing that atoms, however arranged, seem able to issue.

Let me state my old position fairly, because it is a good position and I held it well. As an atheist I believed that morality was real in the only sense that mattered, that it was a set of deeply felt commitments grounded in our nature as social animals, refined by culture, stabilized by reason, and that we did not need a God to be good, that indeed we were often better without the tribal moralities the gods had

licensed. And every word of the practical part of this is true. Atheists are not less moral than believers, and any believer who says otherwise is refuted by ten minutes of honest acquaintance. I have known deeply good unbelievers and deeply wicked churchgoers, and the correlation between belief and behavior is far weaker than the pious like to think. So the objection that atheists cannot be good people is not my objection, and I want to kill it now so it does not haunt this chapter. Of course they can. I was one, and I was, in the ordinary ways, a decent man, and I did not need God to keep me from theft or cruelty.

The question is not whether atheists can be good. The question is what goodness is, whether the word points to something real and binding or to something we made up and could, in principle, unmake. And here my old position had a problem it did not like to look at. If morality is a product of evolution and culture, then it is a contingent fact about creatures like us, a set of preferences bred into a particular primate on a particular planet, and it has exactly the authority that any such fact has, which is to say, none beyond itself. It describes how we tend to feel. It does not obligate. When I said the torture of a child is wrong, I did not mean I personally disapprove of it, or my species has evolved to disapprove of it, or my culture forbids it. I meant it is wrong, wrong if everyone approved of it, wrong if the whole species had evolved to delight in it, wrong in a way that would stand over the entire human race and condemn it if the entire human race went the other way. That is what I meant. That is what the word means when we use it at full strength. And that meaning, the obligation that stands over us rather than arising from us, is precisely the meaning that my atheism could not supply, because there was nothing in my universe

with the standing to issue it.

I tried the ways out, and I want to walk you through them, because each is serious and each, for me, failed at the same place. I tried the view that morality is what a rational agent would agree to, a contract, and it is elegant, but it grounds obligation in agreement, and I could not shake the conviction that the child's torture would be wrong even if the torturers had all agreed to it, so agreement was not the ground. I tried the view that morality is about maximizing well-being and reducing suffering, and I believe in reducing suffering with my whole heart, but I could not derive the ought from the is, could not get from suffering exists to suffering must be reduced without smuggling in, at the crucial step, an obligation that the facts about suffering do not by themselves contain. Every route I took ran the same road and arrived at the same wall. I could describe our moral feelings, explain their origin, systematize them beautifully. What I could not do was ground their authority, the bindingness, the sense that they command me whether I like it or not, and the bindingness was the very thing I most surely knew, more surely than I knew the theories that could not account for it.

I could explain where my moral feelings came from. I could not explain why they were true, and I trusted that they were true more than I trusted any explanation that made them merely feelings.

I WANT TO BE honest that this is not a proof. There is no proof here, and the philosophers who claim one oversell it, and I will not join them. It is possible to be a moral realist and an atheist, to hold that moral facts simply exist, brute and unexplained, features of reality as basic as the laws of logic, requiring no God to ground them. Some very serious thinkers hold this and I respect them and I cannot demonstrate they are wrong. But I will tell you the shape of the thing that moved me, which is not a proof but a fit. On the atheist account, moral facts, if they exist at all, float free, unattached to anything, mysterious intrusions of oughtness into a universe of mere is. On the theist account, the oughtness is exactly what you would expect, because at the bottom of reality is not an indifferent mechanism but a person, a will, a character, and moral obligation is the pressure of that character on creatures made in its image, the claim a good God's nature lays on beings answerable to him. I did not choose theism because it proved the morality. I chose it, in the end, partly because the morality I could not doubt fit the theist picture the way a key fits a lock, and sat in the atheist picture like a stone in a shoe, and after enough years of walking on the stone, I began to wonder whether the discomfort was telling me the shoe was the wrong shape.

CHAPTER TEN

The Resurrection, Examined as a Skeptic Examines It

AT SOME POINT THE question stops being general and becomes specific, and this is the point where most of the atheist writing I admired simply went quiet, and I want to fill the silence, because it is the silence that mattered most to my own turning. It is one thing to argue about God in the abstract, the ground of being, the first cause, the source of the moral law. It is another thing to ask whether a particular Jewish man was executed under Pontius Pilate around the year 30 and then, three days later, was encountered alive by people who had watched him die. The general arguments can be held at a comfortable distance forever. This one cannot, because it is a claim about an event in history, and events in history are the kind of thing you can actually investigate, and I decided, late, and half hoping to bury it, to investigate.

Let me tell you how I approached it, because the approach is the whole thing. I approached it as a hostile witness, which

is the only honest way for a skeptic to approach it, assuming from the start that dead men do not rise, that the resurrection did not happen, and asking only, given that it did not happen, what is the best natural explanation of the evidence we actually have. That is the correct skeptical procedure and I followed it in good faith. I was not looking to be convinced. I was looking to close the file, to find the natural explanation that any reasonable person would accept, and to move on with my unbelief intact and better armored than before.

Here is the evidence I had to explain, and I will give it to you as I gave it to myself, stripped of piety. First, that a man named Jesus existed and was crucified is about as certain as anything in ancient history, attested inside and outside the Christian sources, and no serious historian doubts it, so I could not take the easy exit of saying the whole thing was a myth with no man behind it. Second, that within a few years, not centuries, within a timeframe so short that the first written formulations predate the surviving Gospels and go back to within a year or two of the events, his followers were proclaiming that they had seen him alive after his death, and proclaiming it not as a vague spiritual sense but as encounters, meals, conversations, touch. Third, that these followers, who had every reason to scatter and save their skins after their leader was executed as a criminal, instead went out and proclaimed the resurrection at the cost of their lives, and a great many of them died for it, and while people die for false beliefs all the time, it is a different matter to die for something you personally claim to have witnessed and would know to be a lie. Fourth, that the movement began in Jerusalem, the very city where the tomb was, where the body could have been produced to end the whole thing in an afternoon, and it was not produced. And fifth, hardest for me,

that the belief took the specific form it did, a bodily resurrection of one man in the middle of history, which is not what any Jew of that period was expecting or hoping for, not a category their theology had prepared, so that the belief cannot easily be explained as the projection of a preexisting expectation.

I went through the natural explanations one by one, wanting each to work. The disciples stole the body and lied. But this founders on the willingness to die, because liars protecting a hoax do not, as a rule, all go to their deaths maintaining it when recantation would save them, and it founders on the transformation of frightened men into fearless ones, which a known lie does not produce. They hallucinated. But hallucinations are private events, and the sources describe group encounters, meals, sustained interactions, and mass hallucination of a coordinated and detailed kind is not a documented phenomenon, and in any case a hallucination in Jerusalem does not empty a tomb, and the tomb, whatever happened, was empty enough that no one produced the body. They went to the wrong tomb. But then the authorities, highly motivated to crush the movement, had only to go to the right one. The legend grew over time. But the core proclamation is early, too early for legend to have done its slow work, embedded in formulas that the sources themselves present as already traditional, already handed down, within the first years. Every explanation I reached for cost something, and each one, examined closely, cost more than I had expected, and I found myself in the uncomfortable position of a man whose favored theories are each individually weaker than the thing they were supposed to replace.

*I set out to close the file on the
resurrection and found that the
natural explanations were, each of
them, harder to believe than I had been
told the supernatural one was.*

NOW I WANT TO be exactly honest about what this does and does not show, because the apologists overstate it and I refuse to. It does not prove the resurrection. Nothing proves the resurrection, and a man who tells you the historical evidence compels belief is overselling, because there remains one move always available to the skeptic, and it is a respectable move, which is to say, I do not know what happened, some natural explanation I cannot currently reconstruct is more probable than a dead man rising, because a dead man rising is so improbable that almost any alternative, however strained, is more likely than that. This is the argument that a miracle is by definition the least probable explanation of anything, so no evidence could ever make it the best explanation, and it goes back to Hume in the eighteenth century and it is not stupid. I felt its force. But I also came to see its cost, which is that it makes the conclusion invulnerable to evidence in advance, that it decides before looking that no possible testimony could ever establish a resurrection, which is not the posture of an open mind investigating an event but the posture of a mind that has already ruled on the verdict and will accept only evidence that confirms it. And I had prided myself on following the

evidence. I began to suspect that on this one question I was not following the evidence at all, that I was holding a rule that guaranteed my conclusion regardless of the evidence, and that the rule was doing the work my honesty was supposed to be doing, and that if I applied to the resurrection the same standards I applied to any other question of ancient history, I would have to say, at minimum, that something happened that I could not explain, and that the explanation the witnesses gave was the only one that accounted for all of it, and that my refusal to consider it was not science but a prior commitment wearing science as a coat.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Strange Pull I Did Not Choose

THERE IS A PART of this that no argument will ever capture, and I have put off writing it because it is the part I am least able to defend and least able to deny, and it is the part that Lewis, of all the witnesses I have called, describes most exactly, which is why he is at the front of this book. It is the experience of being pursued. Not of pursuing. Of being pursued. The steady, unrelenting approach of the One he desired not to meet. I want to try to describe this without making it sound more mystical than it was, because it was not, for me, a vision or a voice or anything you could put in a documentary. It was quieter and stranger and harder to dismiss precisely because it was so ordinary.

For several years before anything I would call belief, I was aware of a pressure, and I resisted naming it because naming it would have conceded too much, so I called it moods, I called it phases, I called it the residue of the ache I had always carried. But it was more directed than a mood. A mood settles over you like weather. This was more like being followed, the

sense you get on an empty street that someone is behind you, that turns out, when you finally stop and turn, to be nothing, except that when I stopped and turned, in the metaphor, it was not nothing, it was the very thing I had spent my life arranging not to meet. The pressure was toward God, and I knew it was toward God, and I did everything a clever man does to route around it. I told myself it was psychological, the fatherless boy's old hunger reasserting itself under stress. I told myself it was the accumulated suggestion of the believers I had begun, against my better judgment, to spend time around. I had a full arsenal of dismissals, and I fired them, and the pressure did not lift, and after a while the very reliability of its not lifting became itself a kind of evidence, because moods lift and this did not.

What made it strange, what made it feel like an approach from outside rather than a welling up from inside, was that it ran against my will. This is the crux, and it is the thing Lewis names, and it is the thing that separates what happened to me from what a skeptic would predict should happen to a lonely man who wants a father. If I had wanted this, if I had been reaching for it, the pressure would prove nothing, it would be the ordinary manufacture of a desire that finds its object because it went looking. But I did not want it. I want to be completely clear about this, because it is the load-bearing fact of my whole account. I did not want to believe in God. Belief was, for me, not a longed-for homecoming but a humiliation, a surrender of the one thing I had built my identity on, the clear-eyed refusal to be fooled. Belief meant admitting that the people I had condescended to were closer to the truth than I was. Belief meant the fatherless boy would have to open the door he had welded shut, and risk again the specific silence that had once nearly destroyed him.

Everything in me, pride and fear and grief and the sheer momentum of a lifetime, was set against it. And the pull came anyway, and grew, and would not be dismissed, and pulled hardest exactly when I was most determined to be rid of it.

Now the skeptic in me, who has never fully left and whom I would not want to leave, has an account of this too, and I owe it the hearing. The account is that the human mind under sustained exposure to a religious community and a body of religious ideas will begin, whatever the conscious will prefers, to be reshaped by them, that belief is socially contagious, that I had put myself in proximity to believers and their books and was catching what one catches in such company, and that the feeling of being pursued from outside was the misperception of a process happening inside, my own cognition being remodeled and misreading the remodeling as an external approach. This is a serious account and I cannot refute it, and I will not pretend the mere feeling of externality proves externality, because feelings of that kind are exactly what such a process might produce.

*I did not walk toward God. I was
walked toward, against my stride, and
the harder I dug in my heels the more
ground I somehow lost.*

BUT I WILL SAY the two things that the internal account could never quite cover, and I leave them with you without insisting. The first is the against-the-will character, which does not fit the model of a man being gently socialized into

the beliefs of the group he keeps company with, because that man drifts pleasantly toward the group's views, feeling more at home as he goes, whereas I was being dragged toward views I found humiliating, feeling less at home, resisting every foot of it, and social contagion does not usually work against such fierce resistance in a proud and well-defended mind. And the second is the specificity of the pursuit, that it was not a general spiritual glow, not a vague sense that maybe there is something out there, which is what a socially caught religiosity tends to produce, but a pointed and personal pressure, as though I were the object of an attention rather than the generator of a feeling, and being the object of an attention is categorically different from having a mood, and I knew the difference, and I could not make the pressure into a mood no matter how much better it would have been for my self-respect if I could have. I did not choose the pull. That is the whole point. And a thing that comes to you against your choosing, and stays against your resisting, and grows against your fighting, is a thing you eventually have to reckon with as possibly being what it presents itself as, an other, approaching, whom you desired not to meet.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Night It Broke

I HAVE BEEN CIRCLING this chapter for the whole book, and now I have to walk into it, and I find I do not have the words I want, which is fitting, because I did not have them that night either. I am going to tell you what happened as plainly as I can, and I am going to resist the temptation to improve it, to make it more dramatic or more coherent than it was, because the truth of it is partly in its lack of drama, in how small and quiet and undignified the largest turn of my life turned out to be.

It was late, and I was alone, which is how it had to be, because the boy who had waited for a father who did not come had spent his life making sure that the most important things happened when no one was watching. I had been reading, and arguing in the margins as I always did, and at some point I stopped reading, and I was just sitting there, and the pressure I have been describing was in the room, and I was tired. That is the thing I most want you to hear. I was not overwhelmed by a vision. I was tired. I was tired of the fight, tired in a way that was not physical, tired the way you are tired when you have been holding a door shut for years against something on the other side, and your arms are

failing, and some part of you has begun to wonder what would happen if you simply stopped. I had been holding the door my whole life. And that night, for no reason I can reconstruct, no new argument, no fresh evidence, nothing had changed in the case, I stopped holding it.

I did not decide to believe. I want to be precise, because this matters, and the language of decision is wrong for what happened. It was more like ceasing to refuse. For years I had been performing a continuous act of refusal, a low constant muscular effort of the soul, so habitual I had stopped feeling it as effort, the way you stop feeling the weight of your own clothes. And that night the effort simply stopped, the way a clenched hand finally opens, not by a decision to open but by an exhaustion that will not clench any longer. And in the space where the refusal had been, there was, I can only say, a presence, or the end of an absence, which may be the same thing described from the two sides. I said something. I do not remember it as words, but if it was words it was something like, all right. Not a creed. Not a formula. Just, all right, you are there, I am done, all right. The surrender of a man who has run out of reasons to keep running and is too tired to invent more.

And here is what I have to report, and it is the hardest thing to report because it is the thing most easily faked and I would rather cut off my hand than fake it. It did not feel like winning an argument. It felt like being found. The image that came, and I did not summon it, was of the boy waiting at the window for the father who did not come, except that in the room that night the waiting was over, not because the earthly father had finally arrived, he never did and never would, but because a different word had come to me that I had spent my life proving could not be true, the word that there was a

Father, that he had been the pressure all along, that the pursuit I had felt and fought was his, that the ache I had explained away was homesickness for him, that the silence I had taken as his absence had been, all this time, the patience of a presence too great to force itself on a man who was fighting it, waiting for the arms to fail. I do not know how to defend this. I am not trying to defend it. I am trying to report it, and the report is that I wept, alone, at an age when I had long since stopped weeping, and the weeping was not grief, though it used the same body grief uses. It was the specific weeping of a man who discovers that the thing he most needed and had most given up on was true.

*I did not decide to believe. My arms
simply failed at the door I had been
holding shut my whole life, and what
came through was not an argument. It
was a Father.*

I WANT TO SAY clearly what this proves, which is nothing, to anyone but me. An experience is not an argument, and I know it, and the skeptic I was would say, and would be within his rights to say, that this is exactly what an exhausted and lonely man's mind produces when its defenses finally fail, a wish-fulfillment so precisely shaped to the wound that its very fittedness is suspicious, the fatherless man conjuring a Father at the moment of his greatest need, which is what Freud said religion was and this looks like Exhibit A. I have no

rebuttal that would satisfy that skeptic, because I was that skeptic, and I know that from the outside this is indistinguishable from the collapse he describes. All I can tell you is what it was from the inside, which is that it did not have the texture of something I made. Things I make to comfort myself have always had a certain quality, a thinness, a sense of my own hand behind them, and I know that quality intimately because I am a practiced self-deceiver like every human being. This did not have it. This came with the quality that reality has and inventions do not, the quality of resisting me, of being more than I would have made, of telling me things about myself I did not want to hear in the same moment it told me I was loved. And a man knows the difference between the comfort he manufactures and the comfort that arrives with a claim on him, and this arrived with a claim, and the claim was the proof, to me, and to no one else, that I had not made it up.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

What I Expected to Find, and Did Not

I HAD SPENT SO many years attacking the fortress that I had formed, without noticing, a detailed picture of what was inside it, and when the wall came down and I finally walked in, almost nothing was where I had thought it would be. This is one of the least discussed features of coming to faith from the outside, and I want to give it a chapter, because the gap between the Christianity I had rejected and the Christianity I actually found was so wide that I have come to think a great deal of modern unbelief is the rejection of a thing that does not exist, a rejection I fully understand because I performed it for years against a building I had never gone inside.

I expected, first, to find a system that required me to stop thinking, that asked for my mind as the price of admission, that would hand me a set of answers and forbid the questions. This is the single most common thing said about faith by people outside it, that it is the abandonment of reason, the decision to believe without evidence, indeed the celebration of believing without evidence as a virtue called faith. I had

said it myself many times. And what I found inside was the opposite of what I expected, not because there are no anti-intellectual Christians, there are, in painful abundance, but because the tradition itself, at its depth, is a two-thousand-year argument, a cathedral of the most rigorous thought human beings have produced, Augustine and Aquinas and the whole apparatus of a faith that took reason so seriously it built the first universities to pursue it. I had thought faith meant believing without evidence. I found that the word, as the tradition uses it, means something closer to trust, the trust you extend to a person on the basis of sufficient but not coercive reason, the way you trust a spouse or a friend, not against the evidence but beyond what the evidence alone can compel, which is how all the most important human commitments work and always have.

I expected, second, to find that the price of entry was certainty, that I would have to manufacture a confidence I did not have, to say I know when I only hoped, to perform a settledness that would be a lie. And this frightened me, because I am constitutionally unable to fake certainty, and I assumed the church would demand it and I would either have to fail or pretend. What I found was that the tradition has an enormous and honored place for doubt, that its central texts are full of people arguing with God, that a man in the Gospels says the truest sentence I know, I believe, help my unbelief, holding both at once, and that this was not treated as a failure of faith but as a form of it. I had thought doubt was the opposite of faith. I found that the opposite of faith is not doubt but certainty, the certainty that has stopped needing to trust because it thinks it has proof, and that faith lives precisely in the space where certainty is not available, that it is a way of walking toward what you cannot see rather than a claim to

see it, and that my doubts, far from disqualifying me, were the very material out of which a real faith is made.

I expected, third, and this was the deepest of my errors, to find a religion of good people congratulating themselves on being good, a moral country club where the respectable gathered to feel superior to the people outside, and where my own considerable failures would make me unwelcome. And what I found at the center of it was the most unflattering account of human beings I had ever encountered, more unflattering than anything in the cynical literature I had loved as an atheist, an account that said not that some people are good and some are bad but that all of us are broken, that the line between good and evil runs through every heart, that the respectable churchgoer and the criminal are, before God, in exactly the same condition, both in need of a mercy neither can earn. I had thought Christianity flattered its adherents. I found that it begins by telling them they are worse than they think, and I, who had built my whole self on being clear-eyed about human self-deception, found that here at last was a system that agreed with my darkest estimate of the species and mine of myself, and then said the thing I had never heard, which was that this ruined creature was loved anyway, not for its merits, of which it had few, but freely, and that this was the whole of it, and that it was called grace, and I had never once, in all my years of attacking the fortress, understood that this was what was inside.

*I had spent years rejecting a
Christianity of proud, certain, self-
satisfied good people, and when I
finally walked in I found a
Christianity of doubting, broken,
forgiven ones, and I fit.*

THERE IS A PARTICULAR grief in this, and I do not want to pass over it, the grief of realizing how much of my life I spent in a quarrel with a thing that was not there, how confidently I had rejected a version of the faith that its own best exponents would also reject, how I had, in effect, been an atheist about a god that Christianity does not believe in either, the cosmic policeman, the divine bribe, the sky-father who rewards the good and punishes the bad on a strict accounting, when the actual claim was almost the reverse, a God who comes for the bad, who justifies the ungodly, who is found among the failures and the outsiders and is embarrassing to the respectable. If someone had told me that when I was nineteen and reading Russell, I do not know if it would have changed anything, because I do not think I was rejecting the arguments so much as the caricature, and the caricature deserved rejecting, and the tragedy is that I never knew, all those years, that I was firing my whole arsenal at a scarecrow the farmer had also disowned.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Grace, the Thing No Religion Invents

I HAVE TO WRITE a whole chapter on grace, because it is the center, and because it is the thing that finally persuaded me that Christianity was not a human invention, and I mean that as an argument and not only as a testimony. Here is the argument, and I built it slowly, over years, and it is the argument that a skeptic can follow even if he does not accept the conclusion. Every religion I had studied, and I had studied them as an atheist studies them, from the outside, comparatively, looking for the common human machinery underneath, ran on the same engine, and the engine was reciprocity. Do this and the god will do that. Perform the sacrifice, keep the law, say the prayers, live rightly, and you will earn favor, prosperity, paradise, whatever the currency of that particular system happened to be. This makes sense. It is what human beings would invent, because it is how human societies work, because it maps the marketplace and the courtroom onto the heavens, the ledger of debts and payments, the exchange of goods for goods. A religion of

earning is exactly what you would expect frightened clever animals to build.

And then there is the thing at the center of Christianity, which does not run on that engine at all, which in fact attacks that engine, declares it the enemy, insists that you cannot earn the thing, that the harder you try to earn it the further you get from it, that it is given precisely to those who have stopped trying to deserve it, that it comes free to the undeserving and is insulted by the attempt to pay. This is not a refinement of the reciprocity engine. It is its abolition. And I found, the more I studied, that this was genuinely strange, genuinely anomalous, genuinely not what human religious instinct produces when left to itself, evidence for which is that Christianity itself keeps collapsing back into the reciprocity engine, keeps growing back the very thing it exists to abolish, so that most of what passes for Christianity in practice is a religion of earning wearing grace as a slogan, which tells you that the reciprocity engine is the human default and grace is the intrusion, the thing that has to be constantly reasserted against the gravity of our nature because our nature does not produce it and cannot keep it.

Let me put the argument as sharply as I can, because it is the one I would most want a skeptic to sit with. If Christianity were a human invention, a story we made up to comfort ourselves and control each other, it would run on reciprocity, because that is what we invent, that is what serves the inventors, that is what puts the priests in charge of the ledger and gives the powerful a lever over the weak. A made-up religion is a religion of earning, because earning can be administered, priced, sold, and withheld. But grace cannot be administered. Grace, free grace, grace that comes to the

undeserving with no price and no ledger, is useless to the people who would invent a religion to control others, because it removes the very lever, it tells the sinner he is already loved before he has paid, which is the last thing a system of religious control would ever say, and this is why the grace at the center of Christianity has always been an embarrassment to the institutional church that grew up around it, has always been the thing the church has to keep quietly walking back, because a fully grace-based religion cannot be run as a protection racket, and institutions that want to run protection rackets do not invent the one doctrine that dismantles them.

I do not say this proves Christianity true. I say it was, for me, the thing that made the invention theory hard to hold, because the invention theory has to explain why the invented religion contains, at its very heart, the one thing that no inventor of religion would put there, the thing that serves no controlling interest, the thing the controllers have to keep suppressing, the free unearned unpayable love of God for people who have not earned it and cannot. Where did that come from, if we made it up. It is not in our nature to make it up, our nature makes up the reciprocity engine, we prove this every day, we prove it in the very churches that preach grace and practice earning. The presence of grace at the center, against the grain of everything human religion produces, looked to me less like something we invented and more like something that was done to us, that broke in, that came from outside the reciprocity engine because it could not have come from inside it.

A religion we invented would run on earning, because earning is a lever the inventors can pull. Grace pulls no lever. That is why I could not believe we invented it.

AND THERE WAS THE personal side of this, which I cannot separate from the argument and will not pretend to. I needed grace specifically, more than I needed the cosmological argument or the fine-tuning or any of the abstractions, because the abstractions could give me a God and I did not primarily need a God, I needed to be forgiven, and I had not known that until grace named it. All my life I had carried a debt I could not name, the sense of falling short of something, of owing and not paying, the fatherless boy's conviction that if he had been better the father would have stayed, which is a lie children tell themselves because it is less terrifying than the truth that the failure was not theirs, and I had carried that debt into every corner of my life, and no argument could touch it, because it was not an intellectual problem, it was a wound in the place where you decide whether you are worth loving. And grace walked straight into that place and said the debt was cancelled, not because I had paid it, I could never pay it, but because it had been paid, by someone else, at a cost, and that I was free, and loved, and had been the whole time, and that the staying I had waited for my whole life was not conditional on my being better, because the whole point of grace is that it comes before the being better and is the

only thing that ever makes the being better possible. I did not invent that. I could not have. I had been trying to earn my way to peace my entire life and it had never once worked, and the thing that finally worked was the thing I was forbidden by my whole nature to invent, and I have never gotten over it, and I hope I never do.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Father I Never Had

I HAVE CIRCLED THIS my whole life and now I have to land on it, and I have put it near the end on purpose, because everything before it has been, in a way, the approach to this, and I did not want to reach it before I had earned the right to. I was raised without a father. I have said it several times in this book, plainly, without commentary, because the commentary is this chapter, and I did not want to spend it prematurely. The absence of my father is the deepest fact of my natural life, deeper than the arguments, underneath the unbelief, the thing the unbelief was partly built to manage, and when I came to faith I came to it through, and not around, that absence, and I have to tell you how, because it is the most important thing in the book and the hardest to say without either sentiment or evasion, and I am going to try to say it without either.

Here is the danger, and I name it so you know I see it. The obvious, cheap, and to a skeptic damning reading of my whole conversion is that a boy who lacked a father simply invented one in the sky, that the God I met on the night it broke was the wish of the abandoned child finally granted in fantasy, that Freud diagnosed me a century in advance, that

my faith is not the discovery of a real Father but the projection of a needed one, and that the very fittedness of the Christian God to my particular wound, a Father who stays, a Father who does not leave, a Father who loves before you have earned it, is not evidence for the reality of that Father but the clearest possible evidence that I made him up, because a real God would not fit my wound so exactly, only an invented one would be so perfectly shaped to the hole in me. I have to sit with this, because it is the strongest form of the objection and it is aimed precisely at me, and a lesser book would rush past it.

So let me sit with it. Yes, the Christian God fits my wound with terrible precision. A Father who does not leave is exactly what the fatherless boy would want, and the fit is real, and I will not deny it or minimize it. But I want to press on the logic of the objection, because it contains an assumption that I finally could not grant, and the assumption is that a need is evidence against the reality of the thing needed, that if you are hungry your hunger makes it less likely there is food. And this is exactly backward. Lewis put it in the form I could not escape, that creatures are not born with desires unless satisfaction for those desires exists, that a baby feels hunger and there is such a thing as food, that a duckling wants to swim and there is such a thing as water, that men feel sexual desire and there is such a thing as sex. The presence of a deep and structural need is not, in every other case, evidence that the need is a hallucination. It is ordinarily evidence that there is a corresponding reality, and it would be strange, it would require a special argument, to say that this one need, the need for a Father who does not leave, is the single exception, the one hunger in the whole human animal that corresponds to nothing.

And there is a harder point underneath that one, which took me longer to reach and which I hold more quietly. The objection assumes that because I needed a Father, I was disposed to believe in one, that my wound made me credulous toward the Christian God. But my actual history is the reverse, and this is the fact the projection theory cannot accommodate. My fatherlessness did not make me want to believe in a heavenly Father. It made me want, with all my strength, not to. It made the very idea of a loving Father the most painful and least believable idea in the world, a cruelty, a taunt, the one thing my whole soul was organized to reject, because to believe in a Father who stays was to reopen the wound of the father who left, to make myself vulnerable again to the specific hope that had once nearly killed me. The fatherless boy does not eagerly believe in the divine Father. He is the last man on earth who can afford to. His wound does not incline him toward the belief, it arms him against it, and I was armed against it more heavily than against any other Christian claim, and the projection theory predicts that I should have leaped at the belief, and the truth is that I fought it harder than an ordinary man would have, precisely because I had more to lose, and it came anyway, over my armed and furious resistance, and a thing that comes to you over the resistance your wound erects against it is not the projection of that wound, it is closer to the opposite.

*The fatherless boy is the last man who
can afford to believe in a Father who
stays. My wound did not incline me to*

*God. It armed me against him, and he
came anyway.*

WHAT I FOUND, WHEN it came, was not a bigger version of the father I had lost, which is what a projection would be, an idealized dad in the sky. What I found was stranger and it healed a thing the ideal dad could never have healed. I found a Father whose staying did not depend on my performance, and this was the thing my whole life had needed and my whole theology of self had denied, because I had believed, in the wordless way children believe the worst things, that fathers stay for good sons and leave the ones who fail, and that the leaving had been, at some level, a verdict on me. And grace unsaid that verdict at the root. It said the Father does not stay because you are good, he stays because he is, and your failure cannot drive him off because he did not come for your success, and the leaving you suffered was a man's sin and not a cosmic verdict on your worth. I cannot tell you what that did in me, or rather I can only tell you that it is still doing it, years later, that I am still being fathered, that the hole is not gone but is no longer bottomless, that I have five sons now and I stay, every morning I stay, and I know why I am able to stay, and it is not because I am strong, it is because I was first stayed with, and you do not give what you have not received, and I received it late, on a tired night, from the One I had spent my life proving could not be there.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Doubt After Belief

I WANT TO CORRECT an impression that the last few chapters may have left, because if I leave it standing I will have lied to you by implication, and the whole point of this book was to not lie to you. The impression is that on the night it broke I passed from doubt into certainty, from the wilderness into the promised land, and that I have lived since in the sunlit country of the sure. This is not true. It is not remotely true. And the people who tell you it is true, who present conversion as the end of doubt, have either forgotten their own experience or are selling you a version of the thing that does not exist, and either way you should not trust them, and I will not join them.

Here is the truth. I still doubt. I doubt regularly, sometimes daily, and the doubt did not end when the belief began, it changed its address. Before, I doubted whether God was there. Now I believe God is there and I doubt, in the dark hours, whether the belief will hold, whether I have deceived myself after all, whether the whole thing was the exhaustion of a lonely man dressed up as a revelation, and the old skeptic in me, who never left, sits at the foot of the bed on bad nights and makes his case, and he makes it well, because I trained

him, and he uses my own former arguments against me, and some nights I do not have a knockdown answer and I have to go to sleep with the question open. I want you to hear this clearly, especially if you are a skeptic who assumes that believers have talked themselves into a false peace. Many of us have not. Many of us carry the doubt right into the sanctuary and stand up to sing with it still sitting in our chest, and the standing up to sing anyway, with the doubt still there, is not hypocrisy, it is what faith actually is, and I did not know that until I was inside it.

Because I had the wrong idea of faith, the same wrong idea most skeptics have, which is that faith is a feeling of certainty, a subjective sureness that God is real, and that if you have doubts you have lost your faith. This is precisely wrong, and getting it right was one of the great reliefs of my life. Faith is not certainty. Certainty is a psychological state, a feeling, and it comes and goes with your sleep and your circumstances and the chemistry of the particular morning. Faith is not a feeling at all. Faith is a commitment, a direction of the will, a decision to trust and to keep walking toward the One you have come to believe is there, and it can coexist with any amount of doubt, because it is not the absence of doubt, it is what you do with the doubt still present. The man in the Gospel who says I believe, help my unbelief, is not confessing a failure. He is describing the normal condition of the believer, both things at once, the belief and the unbelief in the same sentence, in the same breath, and Jesus does not rebuke him for the unbelief, he answers the belief, and that is the whole economy of the life of faith, that God answers the mustard seed and does not require the mountain.

I have come to think that a faith without doubt would be a shallow faith, or a dishonest one, or a faith held by someone

who has never really looked at the things that make doubt reasonable, the suffering, the silence, the sheer strangeness of the claims. The people I trust most in the faith are not the ones who have never doubted. They are the ones who have doubted deeply and gone on believing anyway, whose faith has been through the fire and come out not as certainty but as a kind of scarred fidelity, a trust that has looked at the worst and decided to keep trusting, not because the worst has been explained but because they have come to know the One they are trusting well enough to trust him through what they cannot explain. That is a stronger thing than certainty. Certainty has never been tested. This has been tested, and survived, not by winning the argument but by outlasting it, and I would rather have the scarred fidelity than the untested certainty, and I did not know, when I was an atheist, that this was even on offer, because I thought the choice was between honest doubt and dishonest certainty, and no one had told me there was a third thing, honest faith, which keeps the doubt and walks anyway.

*Conversion did not end my doubt. It
moved it. I do not doubt less than I did
as an atheist. I doubt differently, and I
have learned to walk with it rather
than wait for it to leave.*

AND I WANT TO say a hard thing to the believers who may read this over the skeptic's shoulder, because they need it

more than the skeptic does. Stop pretending. Stop performing a certainty you do not have. Every time you present the life of faith as the end of all questions, as the sunlit country where the sure people live, you make the faith unbelievable to exactly the honest doubter it most needs to reach, because the honest doubter knows that no thinking person is that sure of anything, and your performance of certainty reads to him not as faith but as either stupidity or dishonesty, and he is not wrong. The most evangelistic thing a believer can do is to doubt out loud and keep the faith anyway, to say to the skeptic, I know, I have those questions too, I have them still, and here is what I do with them, which is not to answer all of them but to trust the One I have come to know through the ones I cannot answer. That is credible. That is a faith a thinking person can consider, because it does not require him to become stupid to hold it, and the faith I found, the real one under the plastic version, has always been that kind of faith, a faith for people with questions, which is the only kind of people there are.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

What I Would Say to the Man I Was

IF I COULD SIT across a table from the atheist I was, and I mean the real one, not a straw man, the serious and honest and well-defended man I have tried to render faithfully in this book, I have thought a great deal about what I would actually say, and I want to write that conversation here, because it is the most useful thing I can do for the skeptic reading this, who is close enough to that man that a word to him is a word to you. And the first thing I would say is that I would not argue with him. I would not, because I know him, and I know that argument was his home ground, that he was better at it than most of the believers who tried it on him, that every argument they brought he had a counter for, and that winning an argument with him was not only impossible but beside the point, because his unbelief was not, at bottom, held in place by arguments, and neither, I suspect, is yours.

So I would not argue. I would tell him instead that I understood, that I remembered, that I was not sitting across from him as a man who had figured out something he was too

dim to grasp, but as the same man further down the road, and that everything he believed I had believed, and that most of it I still respected, and that I had not stopped being able to feel the force of his objections, that they visit me still. I would tell him that his suspicion of easy comfort was right, that his refusal to be fooled was right, that his fury at the suffering of the innocent was righter than he knew, more right than the shrug his own philosophy recommended, that the very heat of his moral outrage was the truest thing in him and was pointing somewhere his theory would not let him look. I would tell him that I was proud of his honesty and that the honesty was the thing that finally undid him, because a man who is truly committed to following the truth wherever it leads has already, whether he knows it or not, made a commitment that unbelief cannot ground and that leads, if he is faithful to it, somewhere he does not expect.

And then I would tell him the one thing I most wish someone had told me, which is that the thing he was looking for was not on the far side of an argument. He kept treating the question of God as a problem to be solved, a proposition to be established or refuted, and he thought that when the evidence reached some threshold he would believe, and that until it did the honest thing was to withhold assent. And I would tell him that this is a category error, that God, if he is there, is not a proposition but a person, and that persons are not established by evidence the way propositions are, that you do not come to know a person by accumulating data about them until the probability crosses a line, you come to know them by encounter, by relationship, by the slow risk of trust, and that the God he was demanding to establish from a safe distance before he would risk anything was a God who cannot, by his very nature, be established from a safe

distance, because the knowing of him is the very relationship the distance refuses. I would tell him that he was asking to be sure before he would trust, and that this is like asking to be certain the water will hold you before you are willing to swim, and that it cannot work in that order, that the trust comes first and the knowing follows, and that this is not intellectual cowardice, it is the structure of every real relationship he has ever had.

I would tell him about the tired night, but carefully, because I know how he would receive a testimony, with the polite skepticism of a man cataloguing another specimen of the psychology of belief, and I would not blame him. I would say only that there came a point where I stopped fighting, and that the stopping was not a conclusion I reached but a resistance I finally set down, and that I could not prove to him it was more than exhaustion producing an illusion, and that I would not insult him by pretending I could prove it, but that I would ask him one thing, which is to notice how much energy his unbelief was costing him, how much of it was effort, how much of the clear cold relief he prized was in fact the constant low labor of holding a door shut, and to ask himself, just to ask, what he thought was on the other side of the door that required so much holding, because you do not brace that hard against nothing, and the very strength of his defense was, if he was honest, a strange kind of testimony to the reality of the thing he was defending against.

*I would not try to win the argument
with the man I was. I would ask him
only to notice how much of his peace
was labor, and what he thought was on
the other side of a door that took that
much holding to keep shut.*

AND LAST I WOULD tell him that he was loved, that he had been loved the whole time, in all the years of his fury and his brilliance and his refusal, that the pursuit he would one day feel and fight had been underway long before he noticed it, that the Father he did not have and had stopped hoping for was closer than the argument he was constructing to prove such a Father impossible, and that none of his objections, not one, was a reason to be ashamed, because the objections were the honorable public form of a longing he could not yet name, and that the day would come when the longing would be named, and that it would not feel like defeat, though he would fear it as defeat, it would feel like being found, and that the being found would cost him everything he had built himself on and would be worth more than all of it, and that he did not have to believe me, he only had to keep being honest, because the honesty was already, though he could not see it, walking him home.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Cost of Following on the Far Side of Unbelief

I HAVE TO WRITE about the cost, because if I leave you with only the comfort I will have sold you the same cheap thing I spent my atheist years despising, the religion that offers all reward and no demand, the gospel of the self-help aisle, and that is not the faith I found and it is not the faith that is true. Coming to faith cost me, and it costs me still, and the cost is not incidental to the thing, it is part of the evidence for the thing, because a made-up religion optimizes for comfort and the real one does not, the real one asks for your life, and I want to tell you honestly what it took from me, so that you do not come to it, if you come, under false pretenses.

It cost me my self-image first, and this was the hardest, harder than any doctrine. I had built myself on being the one who saw clearly, who was not fooled, who had outgrown the consolations the herd required, and to become a believer was to demote myself in the one hierarchy that mattered most to my pride, to step down from the company of the clear-eyed and join the company of the credulous, as I had once seen

them, to become, in the eyes of the man I had been and the men who still thought as he did, a cautionary tale, a good mind gone soft, a casualty. I felt the shame of that acutely and I still feel it in certain rooms, among certain people, the old company, who look at me now the way I once looked at converts, with a pity that has contempt in it, and I do not defend myself to them, because I remember the look and I know it cannot be answered with words, only outlived. It cost me the approval of the people whose approval had once defined me, and that is a real cost, and I will not pretend it was easy or that it is over.

It cost me the clean simplicity of the atheist moral life, which is a thing believers rarely admit the unbeliever has and I will admit it, because it is true. As an atheist my morality was my own, answerable to no one, revisable by me, and while I held myself to a high standard, the standard was mine, and I could adjust it, and there was a freedom in that, the freedom of a man who is the final court of his own conduct. Faith took that freedom. It put me under a claim I did not author and cannot revise, a standard that stands over me and judges me and does not move when I would like it to move, and that is a heavier way to live, and anyone who tells you faith is the easy path, the crutch, the comfort for the weak, has never actually tried to live under the claim, because the claim is relentless, it reaches into the places I would rather it left alone, it will not let me settle for the decent-enough man I could be, it insists on more than I want to give, and the demand does not stop, and there are days I miss the freedom of being my own final court, and I will not pretend those days do not come.

And it cost me, strangely, a kind of intellectual ease, because I had thought that belief would settle my mind and

instead it complicated it, gave me harder questions than the ones I had as an atheist, not easier ones. As an atheist my hard questions had answers, or the promise of answers, the universe was in principle intelligible and what we did not yet understand we someday would. As a believer I live with mysteries that have no resolution on this side, the suffering I wrote about early in this book chief among them, and I have to hold them open, unresolved, carrying them, and this is harder intellectual work than unbelief ever asked of me, because unbelief let me close the questions with a shrug and faith requires me to keep them open with a wound. I traded the peace of the closed question for the labor of the open one, and it was a real trade, and I do not always feel I got the better end of it, in the hours when the open question is at its widest and no comfort reaches all the way to the bottom of it.

*No one warned me that faith would be
harder than unbelief. It asks more, not
less. It is not the crutch. It is the cross,
and I mean that as it sounds.*

SO WHY, GIVEN THE cost, and I want to end this chapter with the question rather than run from it, why do I stay, why would I recommend to you a thing that will cost you your self-image and your moral autonomy and your intellectual ease, that will make you a fool in the eyes of the company you may currently keep, that will put you under a relentless claim and hand you unresolvable mysteries to carry. And the only honest answer is that I stay for the same reason a man stays

in a marriage that has cost him things, because the thing I found is real, and once you have met a person you do not unmeet them because the relationship is demanding, and the cost is the measure of the reality, not an argument against it, because everything worth having costs, and the cheapness of my old unbelief, its comfort, its ease, its freedom from demand, looks to me now not like an advantage but like the mark of its unreality, a thing that asks nothing because it offers nothing, and I would not go back to it for all the ease in the world, because I have been found, and being found costs, and I would pay it again, and I do, every morning, and I will tell you it is worth it, though I will not tell you it is easy, because it is not easy, and the people who told you it was easy were lying, and I am done with lying to you, and this is the truth.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Pascal and the Wager I Misunderstood

I OWE A CHAPTER to Blaise Pascal, because I misread him for years the way almost everyone misreads him, and the misreading was one of my favorite weapons against the faith, and when I finally understood what he was actually saying it did not so much refute my objection as reveal that I had never engaged the man at all, that I had been fighting a cartoon, which is a thing I did more than I like to admit and which I confess here as part of the ongoing honesty this book is trying to keep.

The cartoon of Pascal, the one I deployed, is the Wager understood as a cynical bet, a piece of theological game theory that says you should believe in God because the expected payoff is infinite, heaven if he exists and you believe, nothing much lost if he does not, so a rational gambler bets on God the way he takes a lottery ticket with good odds. And I would answer this, as every clever skeptic answers it, that you cannot make yourself believe a thing by calculating its usefulness, that belief is not under the control

of the will in that way, that a God worth anything would see through the mercenary calculation and reject it, and that anyway the wager proves too much, because it works for any religion promising an infinite payoff, so it cannot tell you which god to bet on. These are good objections to the cartoon, and I was proud of them, and they are worthless, because they are objections to a Pascal who does not exist, a Pascal assembled from a single passage read in isolation by people, and I was one of them, who never read the book the passage sits in.

Because when I finally read the *Pensees*, the actual fragments Pascal left unfinished at his death in 1662, I found that the Wager is a small and late moment in a work that is overwhelmingly about something else, about the human condition, about what Pascal calls our greatness and our wretchedness, the strange doubleness of a creature that is capable of contemplating the infinite and is also a reed that a drop of water can kill, that reaches for the stars and cannot sit quietly alone in a room. Pascal's real argument is not the bet. His real argument is a diagnosis of the human heart, and the diagnosis was so exact, so uncomfortably exact, that reading it was like being examined by a physician who names the symptom you had told no one. He says that we distract ourselves ceaselessly, that we cannot bear to be still because stillness confronts us with our condition, that all our diversions, and he catalogs them with a merciless eye, are flights from a confrontation we cannot face, the confrontation with our own mortality and emptiness and the silence of the spaces that terrified him. And I read this as a man who had spent his whole life distracting himself and calling it living, and I could not dismiss it as easily as I had dismissed the Wager, because it was not an argument I could counter, it was

a description I recognized.

And the Wager, once I saw it in its place, was not the cynical bet I had mocked. Pascal is not saying calculate the odds and fake belief. He is speaking to a very specific person, the person who has come to see that the question of God is the most important question there is, who wants it to be true or at least sees what would follow if it were, but who is held back by the demand for a certainty that is not available, who says I would believe if only I could be sure. And to that person Pascal says something I found devastating, which is that you are already wagering, that you cannot not wager, that abstention is itself a bet, that by living as though God does not exist you have placed your chips on that square as surely as the believer has placed his on the other, that there is no neutral ground where you get to withhold the bet and wait for more information, because life itself is the wager and you are making it with every day you live one way rather than the other. I had thought I was the reasonable man suspending judgment while the believers gambled. Pascal showed me that suspension was a fiction, that I had already gambled, that I had bet my one life on the proposition that there was nothing to bet on, and that this was not the safe neutral default I had imagined but a wager as total as any believer's, made with the same currency, my life, and with, if Pascal was right, incomparably worse odds.

And then Pascal says the thing that finally showed me how badly I had misjudged him, because it answers my best objection, the objection that you cannot will yourself to believe. He agrees. He says you cannot simply decide to believe, that the will does not command belief directly. But he says that belief comes not only through proof but through habit, through practice, through the body, that if you want to

believe and cannot, you should not sit and wait for certainty but should begin to live as those who believe live, to practice the practices, to keep the company, to say the prayers even before you mean them, and that belief will come, not as the conclusion of an argument but as the fruit of a life, that the heart has its reasons that reason does not know, and that the path to faith runs not only through the head but through the whole embodied person doing the things that faith does until faith catches up. I had thought this was intellectual dishonesty, faking it until you make it. I came to see it was psychological realism, the recognition that we are not brains on stilts, that we come to know things through our bodies and our habits and our loves and not only through our propositions, and that the demand to be intellectually convinced before taking a single step was itself a kind of pride, the pride of a creature that thinks it is only a mind, when Pascal knew, and I learned, that it is also a heart and a body and a set of habits, and that all of these have to be walked toward the truth together, and that the mind is not even always the one that leads.

I had bet my one life on there being nothing to bet on, and I had called it neutrality. Pascal showed me there is no neutral square on the board, that abstention is a wager too, and I had made mine blind.

I DO NOT OFFER the Wager to you as a reason to believe, because it is not, and Pascal did not mean it as one, and the people who wield it as a knockdown proof have understood it as poorly as I once did. I offer you instead the deeper Pascal, the physician of the heart, who saw that we flee ourselves through endless diversion, that we are wagering whether we admit it or not, and that the path to faith, for the one who wants it and cannot reach it, may run through practice and not only through proof. Because that turned out to be true for me. Long before the night it broke, I had begun, almost against my will, to do some of the things believers do, to sit in the silence I had spent my life fleeing, to be still in the room that Pascal said we cannot bear to be still in, and in that stillness the pressure I have described did its slow work, and I have come to think that the stillness was not incidental, that I could never have been found while I was still running, that the first thing that had to happen was that I had to stop distracting myself long enough to be caught, and Pascal, three hundred and fifty years dead, had told me so, and I had mocked him for it, and he was right and I was wrong, and I record it here.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Augustine, and the Restless Heart

THERE IS ONE MORE witness I have to call before I bring this book to its close, and he is the oldest of them, and in some ways the one who has been describing my life most exactly across the greatest distance of time, which is itself a small argument I cannot quite dismiss, that a man writing sixteen hundred years ago should have anatomized my particular unbelief so precisely that reading him felt less like study than like being read. Augustine of Hippo, who finished his Confessions around the year 397, wrote the first true autobiography, the first book in which a man turns the full force of his intellect on the interior movements of his own soul, and he wrote it as a convert looking back on his own long unbelief, which is exactly what I am trying to do in this book, so that I have come to think of the Confessions as the book mine is a small and distant echo of, and I want to tell you what Augustine gave me.

Augustine was not, like me, raised without any faith. His mother was a believer and prayed for him for years, which is

a difference. But he was, like me, a man who spent his young manhood in flight from the faith, who found it intellectually embarrassing, beneath him, a religion for the simple, and who constructed for himself a series of more sophisticated philosophies that let him feel superior to it while pursuing his ambition and his appetites, and who was held back from belief not primarily by argument but by the things belief would cost him, chiefly his sexual life and his pride, so that his famous prayer, give me chastity, but not yet, is the truest confession of the divided will I have ever read, the will that wants the good and wants to keep the thing that stands against the good and cannot make itself choose. I recognized this man. I recognized the sophistication that was really evasion, the philosophy that was really a way of not surrendering, the intellectual objections that were, underneath, the honorable public form of a will that did not want to give up what belief would require it to give up.

And what Augustine saw, and named at the very opening of his book in a sentence that has outlived empires, is the thing this whole book has been circling, the thing under my ache, the thing the beauty kept pointing at, the thing the fatherlessness had made both unbearable and undeniable. He addresses God and says that God has made us for himself, and that our heart is restless until it rests in him. That is the diagnosis, and it is the diagnosis of my entire life, the restlessness I described in the first chapter, the ache I had explained away as evolutionary vestige, the appetite with no object that visited me at the end of good days. Augustine says it has an object. He says the restlessness is not a malfunction but a homing signal, that we are made for God the way the eye is made for light, and that every other thing we pursue to quiet the restlessness, and he pursued many and names

them without flinching, the sex and the status and the philosophy and the applause, quiets it only for a moment and then it returns, because none of them is the thing it is actually for, and the restlessness will not be satisfied by any of them because it was calibrated to something else, and it will keep returning, faithful and terrible, until it finds the one thing it was made to rest in.

I resisted this the way I resisted the argument from desire in Lewis, and with the same argument, that the restlessness is just an evolved dissatisfaction that kept our ancestors striving, and that its refusal to be satisfied is a feature of the striving mechanism and not a sign of a transcendent object. And I have already told you why that answer, good as it is, finally failed to hold me, because it explains the restlessness without reducing it, and a restlessness that survives its own explanation, that keeps presenting itself as a homing signal even after you have been told it is only noise, is a strange kind of noise. But Augustine added something Lewis did not, or added it more personally, which is that he had tried the other objects, all of them, more thoroughly than I had, and he reported back, from the far side of a life of trying, that they did not work, not because he had used them wrongly but because they were the wrong size for the hole, that a hole shaped for the infinite cannot be filled by finite things no matter how many of them you pour in, and that he had poured in a great many and the hole had swallowed them all and remained, and that only when he stopped trying to fill it with substitutes and let it be filled by the thing it was made for did the restlessness, at last, and not completely, and not without relapse, begin to rest.

*Augustine did not tell me the
restlessness was a flaw to be medicated.
He told me it was a compass, and that
it had been pointing the same
direction my whole life, and that I had
been reading it as static.*

AND THERE WAS ONE more thing in Augustine, the scene in the garden, the moment of his conversion, and I put off reading it for a long time because I feared it would be too pat, and when I finally read it I found that it was the least pat conversion I had ever encountered, a scene of anguish and weeping and a man throwing himself down under a fig tree in the extremity of his divided will, unable to make the choice he could see he should make, torn in two, and then hearing a child's voice from a neighboring house chanting take up and read, take up and read, and taking up the book and reading the first passage his eye fell on, and being, in that instant, released, the divided will suddenly and mysteriously made one, the thing he had been unable to do for years done in a moment not by his own strength but by a grace that arrived from outside and did for him what he could not do for himself. And I recognized the tired night in Augustine's garden, the years of resistance ending not in a triumph of the will but in a collapse of it, the choice made not by mustering strength but by the failure of the strength that had been holding out, and the grace arriving in the space the failed strength left, and I understood that what had happened to me

had happened to him, across sixteen hundred years, in almost the same shape, and that either we had both suffered the same illusion in the same form for reasons that would need explaining, or we had both, in our different centuries, run into the same reality, the same steady unrelenting approach, the same Father coming across the same cleared ground, and I know which of those two explanations I now believe, and I know which one I would once have insisted on, and the distance between them is the distance this whole book has traveled.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

On Being a Skeptic Inside the Church

I HAVE BEEN A believer now long enough to have become, in a sense, a professional one, a pastor, a man who stands up on Sundays and speaks about God to people who have come expecting to hear from someone who is sure. And I want to write honestly about what it is to carry my particular history into that room, because I think it is the most useful thing I have to offer the church, and because it is the thing that keeps me useful to the skeptic, and because if I did not write it this book would end too cleanly, with the convert safely arrived, and I have told you too many times that I distrust the clean arrival to serve you one now.

Here is what it is like. I stand up on Sunday and I look out at the faces, and I know, because I was one of them from the other direction, that some of those faces belong to people who are not sure, who are there for their families, or out of habit, or because something is broken in their lives and they came hoping, or because they are the skeptic I was, dragged along, arms crossed, cataloguing the psychology of the room. And I

speak to those faces differently than a man who had never been among them could, because I am not trying to defend a fortress I was born inside. I am a man who attacked the fortress for years, who knows every weakness in its walls because he probed them all, who came inside not as a native but as a former enemy, and who therefore speaks about the faith not as a possession he inherited but as a country he emigrated to, and immigrants know things about a country that the natives never see, because they chose it, and paid to enter it, and remember the border.

And what this means, practically, is that I cannot preach the sermons I hear other men preach, the ones that assume everyone in the room already believes and merely needs to be encouraged, or scolded, or entertained. I cannot preach as though the objections are not real, because I made the objections, and I made them well, and I will not stand up and pretend they are the flimsy things that a certain kind of confident preacher pretends they are, because there are people in the room who hold those objections seriously and who will know, instantly, that I am not taking them seriously, and I will have lost them, and worse, I will have confirmed their worst suspicion, that faith requires you to stop thinking, that the church is a place where hard questions go to be dismissed. So I bring the objections into the sanctuary. I say the argument from suffering out loud, at full strength, from the pulpit, and I do not resolve it, and I watch the skeptic in the back row uncross his arms a little, because he came expecting to be handled and instead he is being told the truth, that the thing that troubles him troubles me too, that I have not gotten over it, that faith is not the place where that question stops but the place where you learn to carry it.

I have paid for this, inside the church, and I should tell you

that too, because the church is not always glad to have a skeptic in its pulpit. There are believers who find my honesty destabilizing, who want the man up front to be sure so that they can borrow his surety, who experience my public doubt not as permission but as threat, and who have told me, some of them kindly and some of them not, that I should keep such things to myself, that the sheep need a shepherd who is certain, that my job is to bolster faith and not to complicate it. And I understand them, and I love them, and I have not been able to do what they ask, because I remember too well what it was to sit in a pew, back when I was dragged into one, and to feel the vast distance between the certainty being performed at the front and the honest confusion in my own chest, and to conclude that whatever was happening up there had nothing to do with a person like me, and to leave more sure of my unbelief than when I came, because the performance of certainty had told me, without meaning to, that faith was only for people who did not think, and I was not going to stop thinking, so faith was not for me. I will not do that to the person in the back row. I would rather be corrected by the elders than be the reason a skeptic decides, one more time, that there is nothing here for the honest.

*The most useful thing I bring to the
church is the border I remember
crossing. I am not a native of this
country. I chose it, as an enemy chooses
to surrender, and I have never*

*forgotten what it looked like from the
other side.*

AND I HAVE FOUND, over the years, that the skeptics are not the problem the church thinks they are. The skeptics are, very often, the people most starved for the real thing, precisely because they refused the fake thing, and their refusal, which the church reads as hostility, is frequently a kind of integrity, a refusal to say they believe what they do not believe, which is a more honest position than that of half the people in the pews who say the words and have never once examined them. I have come to love the skeptics in my congregation more than almost anyone, because I was one, and because I know that their doubt is not the enemy of their faith but the raw material of it, and that a skeptic who comes to believe will believe more deeply than a man who never doubted, because he will have counted the cost and paid it, and his faith will have been through the fire and will not be the flammable thing that untested faith so often is. So I preach to the skeptics, first, always, the way Bell writes toward them, because they are the hardest case and the most beloved, and because I was the hardest case, and because someone, somehow, kept preaching toward me across all the years I was sure I was not listening, and I was listening, and I did not know it, and neither do they.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Problem of the Other Religions

THERE IS AN OBJECTION I have not yet addressed and I have to, because it was one of my sharpest, and it is one that the honest skeptic keeps in reserve for when the others have been answered, and it deserves a chapter of its own, and I am going to give it the strength I once gave it. The objection is this. Even granting everything, granting that there is a God, granting that the human heart is restless for something transcendent, granting the moral argument and the argument from beauty and the whole apparatus, why this God, why this religion, why Christianity out of the thousands of faiths that human beings have believed with equal sincerity, each of them producing converts who tell stories like mine, each of them producing saints and mystics and people transformed. Is it not obvious that I would have become a Muslim if I had been raised in Karachi, a Hindu in Varanasi, a Buddhist in Kyoto, that my Christianity is an accident of my geography, that the very experience I have described, the pull, the pursuit, the night it broke, has its

exact analogue in every tradition on earth, and that the fact that everyone has it and everyone interprets it through their local religion is the strongest possible evidence that it is a human universal being read through cultural lenses, and that no lens has any better claim to truth than any other.

I felt the full weight of this, and I want to concede immediately how much of it is true, because the believers who rush to deny it embarrass the faith. It is true that people of every religion have profound spiritual experiences. It is true that every tradition produces people of deep holiness and wisdom, and that if you have spent time among devout Muslims or Hindus or Buddhists, as I have, you cannot honestly maintain that they are all deluded and only you have the truth, that they are less sincere or less transformed or less good than the Christians you know, because they are not, and often they are more so, and a Christianity that requires you to believe that everyone outside it is a fool or a fraud is a Christianity that collides with the plain evidence of your senses and should be abandoned on that ground alone. So I do not believe that. I believe there is truth and beauty and genuine encounter with the transcendent scattered across the religions of the world, and I think the faith I hold actually predicts this, that a God who made all human beings and put eternity in their hearts would leave his fingerprints everywhere, and that the light that lights every person who comes into the world is not confined to one tradition, and Christianity at its best has said exactly this.

But here is where I could not follow the objection all the way to its conclusion, and I want to show you the exact place I got off, because it is a subtle place. The objection says that because there are many religions and many experiences,

none can be true, or all are equally true, which come to the same relativism. But notice that this does not follow, and does not follow in any other domain. There are many accounts of the origin of the universe across human cultures, and the multiplicity of accounts does not mean there is no true account, or that all are equally true, it means the question is hard and most of the accounts are wrong or partial and the work is to find out which is truest. The existence of many answers to a question is not evidence that the question has no answer. It is evidence that the question is important enough that everyone has tried to answer it, which is what you would expect of the most important question, and the diversity of religions is better explained as the diversity of attempts to grasp a real thing than as evidence that there is no real thing, in exactly the way the diversity of scientific theories across history is the record of a real world being progressively grasped rather than evidence that there is no world.

And then there is the further point, the one that actually held me, which is that the religions are not in fact all saying the same thing behind their different vocabularies, that this is a comforting modern myth that dissolves on contact with the actual traditions, which disagree profoundly and irreconcilably about the most basic questions, whether the ultimate is personal or impersonal, whether the self is real or an illusion to be extinguished, whether history is going somewhere or is an endless wheel, whether salvation is achieved or received, and these are not different flavors of one truth, they are contradictory claims about the nature of reality, and at least most of them must be substantially wrong, because they cannot all be right, they are not even trying to say the same thing. And once I saw that, the objection changed its shape. It was no longer, all religions are

the same so none is true. It became, these are competing accounts of reality that genuinely disagree, and the honest thing is not to declare them all equally valid, which would require ignoring what they actually say, but to ask which account best fits the whole of the evidence, the world, the moral facts, the human heart, the historical claims, and to follow that inquiry where it leads, which is exactly the inquiry I had been running, and which had been leading, against my will, in one direction.

*The many religions are not evidence
that the question has no answer. They
are evidence that it is the most
important question there is, which is
why everyone has tried to answer it.*

AND WHAT FINALLY SETTLED it for me, though settled is too strong, what finally made me able to say not merely that there is a God but that the God is the one Christianity names, was the specific thing I wrote about in the chapter on grace, the thing that Christianity has that I could not find in the same form anywhere else, the claim that God comes down. Every other system I studied, in its own way, is a system of ascent, of the human being climbing toward the divine through knowledge or discipline or moral effort or ritual purity or the extinction of desire, the human reaching up. And Christianity alone, at its scandalous center, has the divine reaching down, God descending, God becoming small,

God entering the mess and the suffering and the failure, God on a cross, and this is not a difference of vocabulary, it is a reversal of the fundamental direction, and it is, when you sit with it, not the kind of thing the religious impulse produces, because the religious impulse produces ladders, systems of ascent that put the spiritual athletes at the top, and the descent of God undercuts every ladder, saves the ones who could never climb, and this reversal, this one thing, was the thing that told me I was not looking at one more human attempt to reach up, but at something that had come the other way, and I could be wrong, and I hold it with the doubt I hold everything, but that was the place I got off the objection, and I have never found my way back onto it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

What Prayer Turned Out to Be

I SHOULD TELL YOU about prayer, because it was one of the things I most despised as an atheist and it turned out to be nothing like what I despised, and the gap between the two is instructive, and because prayer is where the whole of what I have been describing gets lived out, day by day, and a book about coming to faith that never mentioned prayer would be a book about a faith that was only ideas, and the faith I found was not only ideas, it was a relationship, and prayer is what a relationship with a person you cannot see turns out to be.

What I despised was the thing prayer is usually taken to be from the outside, the attempt to change the mind of an all-knowing God by asking, the child's letter to a cosmic Santa, the mechanism by which frightened people try to bend the universe toward their preferences by wishing hard in a formalized way, and I had all the standard objections and they are good objections. If God knows everything, he knows what you need before you ask, so the asking is pointless. If God's will is perfect, then either your prayer aligns with it, in

which case it changes nothing, or it opposes it, in which case it should not be granted, so prayer either does nothing or asks God to do wrong. And the studies, the ones that tried to measure whether prayed-for patients recovered better, which found nothing, or worse than nothing, and which I cited with satisfaction as the empirical burial of the whole enterprise. These were my objections and I was proud of them and they are aimed, all of them, at a thing that turned out not to be what prayer primarily is.

Because when I began, tentatively, to pray, expecting the vending-machine transaction I had mocked, I found that petition, the asking for things, while it is real and I do it and I believe it matters in ways I cannot systematize, is the smallest part of the thing, the outer shell, and that underneath it prayer is something I had no category for, which is the practice of a relationship, the deliberate turning of attention toward a presence, the slow habit of speaking and, harder, of listening, of bringing the whole of your life, the anger included, the doubt included, into the open before someone you are coming to trust is there. I had thought prayer was talking at a God to get things. I found it was more like what happens between two people who love each other and have been together a long time, where most of the important communication is not transactional at all, is not about getting the other person to do things, is the simple ongoing turning toward each other, the being present, the sharing of the interior life, and where the changes that happen are not changes in the other person's behavior but changes in you, in how you see, in what you want, in who you are becoming by virtue of the sustained attention to another.

And the anger, I have to say something about the anger, because this was the greatest surprise. I had assumed prayer

required piety, that you had to come to God composed and reverent and grateful, and that the fury I have carried, at my father, at the suffering of the world, at God himself for the silence, had no place in it, was the opposite of prayer, was what prayer was for getting rid of. And then I read the Psalms as a believer, having only skimmed them as an atheist, and I found that a full third of them are complaints, are furious, are a man screaming at God, why have you forgotten me, why do you hide your face, how long, and that these screams are not the failure of prayer but some of its highest examples, canonized, preserved, prayed for three thousand years, and that the tradition I had thought demanded a false serenity in fact contains the most honest rage in all of literature, aimed directly at God, and that God, apparently, would rather have the rage aimed at him than the false serenity that pretends the rage is not there. And I learned to pray my anger, which is a thing no one had told me you could do, to bring the fury about my father and the fury about the child with bone cancer directly into the presence and lay it down there, not resolved, not explained, just brought, and I found that a God who can be screamed at is a God you can have a real relationship with, and a God who requires you to pretend is not, and that the prayer I had mocked from the outside was, from the inside, the most honest speech I have ever engaged in, more honest than any conversation I have had with a human being, because there is finally someone I do not have to perform for, who already knows the worst, and to whom I can therefore tell the truth all the way down.

I had thought prayer was asking a vending machine for things. It turned out to be the most honest speech I know, the one place I finally do not have to perform, where I can even bring my rage at God to God.

THE STUDIES, THE ONES I cited, measure petition, whether asking produces measurable outcomes in the world, and I no longer think that is the interesting question, not because I do not believe petition matters, I do, but because measuring prayer by whether it makes prayed-for strangers recover faster is like measuring a marriage by whether talking to your spouse lowers your cholesterol, it has fundamentally misunderstood what kind of thing it is looking at, it has taken a relationship and tried to assess it as a mechanism, and found, unsurprisingly, that it does not work well as a mechanism, because it is not one. Prayer changed me. It did not, that I can prove, change the weather or the diagnosis or the outcome, though I have seen things I cannot explain and I hold them quietly and do not build arguments on them. What it changed, measurably, to me, was the pray-er, over years, slowly, the way any sustained relationship changes you, making me less afraid, less driven, more able to stay, more able to forgive, more able to sit in the room with suffering without either fleeing it or explaining it away, and if you had asked the atheist I was what he wanted, underneath everything, it was to become a man who could do those

things, and prayer, the thing he mocked, is the thing that has been slowly making him into that man, and he would not have believed it, and I can barely believe it, and it is true.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Company of the Reluctant

I HAVE LEANED ON Lewis throughout this book, and I want to give him one chapter of his own before the end, not because he is the greatest of my witnesses, Augustine is older and Pascal is sharper and the Scriptures are deeper, but because he is the one whose particular experience most exactly matched mine, the reluctant convert, the man dragged in against his will, and because in *Surprised by Joy* he did something no one else I read had done, which is describe the actual psychological texture of coming to belief from unbelief with a novelist's precision and a skeptic's honesty, and reading it was the first time I felt that someone had been where I was and had written back a true report rather than a piece of propaganda.

Lewis had been, like me, an atheist, and a serious one, an Oxford man who held the standard position of the educated unbeliever of his time, that the universe was a meaningless accident and religion a comforting lie, and who held it not lazily but with the full force of a first-rate mind, and who

came to faith slowly, over years, dragged the whole way, and who insisted afterward, against every convention of the conversion narrative, that he had not wanted it, that he had come in kicking, that he was, in the phrase I quoted at the start, the most dejected and reluctant convert in all England. And what mattered to me about this was that it broke the frame I had for conversion stories, which was that they were the reports of people who wanted to believe and found permission, emotional accounts of a return to a comfort the person had been longing for. Lewis was not longing for it. Lewis dreaded it. Lewis describes his conversion the way a man describes a defeat, a surrender, a checkmate he had spent years trying to escape, and the reluctance was the thing that made it credible to me, because a man who does not want a conclusion and reaches it anyway has given you a very different kind of testimony than a man who wanted it all along.

And Lewis was careful, more careful than most, to distinguish the steps, to say that his coming to faith was not one thing but several, spread over years, and that the first and longest step was not to Christianity at all but simply to theism, simply to the admission, which he fought with everything he had, that there was a God, that he was not alone in his own head, that the universe contained a mind, and he describes the night he finally admitted it, in his rooms at Magdalen, as the most reluctant admission of his life, giving in, kneeling, and praying, as he says, perhaps that night the most dejected and reluctant convert in all England, and only later, and by a different and gentler process, coming from bare theism to Christ. And this mattered to me because it matched the shape of my own turning, which was also not one leap but a sequence, first the crumbling of the certainty

that there was nothing, then the long resistance to the pressure I have described, then the tired night when the resistance failed and I admitted there was a someone, and only after that, in the weeks and months and years that followed, the slower coming to believe that the someone had a face, and a name, and had entered history, which is a further thing and a harder thing than bare theism and took me longer.

I want to sit with the reluctance, because it is the thing I most want the skeptic to hear, and Lewis gives me the words for it. The reluctance is not a defect in the conversion, something that had to be overcome for the real thing to happen. The reluctance is part of the evidence. If I had wanted God, if belief had been the fulfillment of my desire, then my coming to believe would prove nothing about God and everything about my desire, it would be exactly the wish-fulfillment the skeptic diagnoses. But I did not want God, and Lewis did not want God, and we are not alone, there is a whole company of the reluctant, of people who came to faith not as the granting of a wish but as the loss of a fight, and this company is, I think, the most interesting evidence in the whole matter, because the reluctance controls for the wish. You cannot explain the reluctant convert as a man who believed because he wanted to, because he did not want to, he wanted the opposite, and he believed anyway, over his own resistance, which means the belief came from somewhere other than his wanting, which is precisely what the believer claims and precisely what the skeptic's theory cannot accommodate.

The reluctance is not a flaw in the conversion. It is the control group. A man who did not want God and believed anyway has ruled out the one explanation the skeptic most relies on.

AND THERE IS A tenderness in Lewis that I want to end this chapter on, because it is the tenderness of a man who remembered being the enemy and never learned to despise the enemy he had been, and it is the tenderness I most want to imitate. Lewis, having come in from the cold, did not turn and mock the people still standing in it, did not become the convert who is hardest on the position he left, which is a common and ugly thing. He wrote toward the unbeliever with a gentleness that came from having been one, from remembering exactly how reasonable the unbelief had felt from the inside, from knowing that the man out in the cold was not a fool but was, very often, a better and more honest man than many who were already warm, and that the warmth he had found was not a reward for his cleverness, since he had resisted it with all his cleverness, but a gift that had overtaken him despite himself, and that therefore he had nothing to boast about and no ground to look down from, and that the only honest posture toward the unbeliever was the posture of one beggar telling another where he had found bread. That is the posture I am trying to hold in this book. I am not a clever man who solved the problem you cannot solve. I am a beggar who was reluctant to admit he was

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hungry, who fought the bread, who was fed anyway, and who is telling you, across the table, one reluctant former enemy to another, where the bread turned out to be.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Death, Which I No Longer Explain Away

I HAVE TO WRITE about death, because it is where the whole question comes to its point, and because my atheism had a settled and, I thought, mature account of it, and that account was one of the last things to give way, and I want to describe both the account and the giving way, because I think a great many unbelievers rest, as I rested, on a view of death that is more comforting than they admit and less examined than they suppose.

The account I held was the one every thoughtful atheist holds, and I held it well. Death is the end. When the brain stops, the person stops, the way a flame stops, and there is no soul that steps out and continues, and this is not a tragedy to be raged against but a fact to be accepted, and indeed there is a dignity and even a consolation in accepting it, because the fear of death is largely the fear of what comes after, and if nothing comes after there is nothing to fear, you will not experience your own nonexistence, you will simply not be, as you were not for the billions of years before you were born,

and the symmetry is instructive, no one grieves the eternity before their birth, so why grieve the eternity after their death, they are the same nothing bracketing the brief something that is your life, and the mature response is to make the something count and let the nothing be. This is a coherent view. I held it with conviction. I found real strength in it, the strength of a man who looks at the thing without flinching and refuses the fairy tale.

And I want to honor what is true in it before I tell you where it cracked, because a great deal is true in it, and the believers who mock the atheist's composure before death are usually cowards who have never actually faced the question with the atheist's honesty. It is true that the fear of hell has been used to terrorize and control, and that an unbeliever who has escaped that terror has escaped a real evil. It is true that there is dignity in facing extinction without a consoling story. And it is true that many believers hold their belief in an afterlife precisely as the wish-fulfillment the skeptic accuses them of, a refusal to accept a hard fact, a child's insistence that the story cannot really end, and I have met those believers and their faith is thin and frightened and I do not commend it. So I grant the atheist his composure and I grant that it can be more honest than a certain kind of belief.

But here is where it cracked, and it cracked not at the level of argument but at the level of the actual deathbed, because I have sat by a great many now, as a pastor, more than I ever did as an unbeliever, and the account that had seemed so mature in the abstract seemed, at the actual bedside, to be describing a different event than the one that was happening in the room. Because what happens when a person dies is not the extinguishing of a flame, or it is not only that, it is the ending of a world, the disappearance of an entire universe of

memory and love and interiority, the whole irreplaceable particular person, gone, and the atheist account asks me to regard this as a neutral fact, like the burning out of a star, tragic but not wrong, and I found, at the bedside, that I could not regard it that way, that every fiber of me insisted that this was not merely sad but wrong, an outrage, a thing that ought not to be, and that the insistence had the same structure as the moral perception I wrote about earlier, it presented itself as a perception of a truth and not merely a feeling, and the atheist account required me to overrule the perception in favor of the theory, and I had spent my life trusting my perceptions over theories that dissolved them.

And there was the further thing, the thing about the symmetry, the argument that the nothing after death is the same as the nothing before birth and so equally unworthy of grief. I had found this argument powerful and I want to say exactly why it stopped working on me. It stopped working because it is not true that the two nothings are the same. The nothing before my birth was the nothing of a person who did not yet exist and had nothing to lose. The nothing after my death is the nothing of a person who did exist, who loved and was loved, who accumulated a whole world of particular attachments, and who loses all of it, and the loss is real precisely because the something was real, and the symmetry argument works only by ignoring the something in the middle, by treating the person as incidental to the two nothings that bracket them, when the person is the entire point, and the loss of the person is not made weightless by pointing to the emptiness before they arrived, because they had not yet arrived, and now they have been here, and being here and then being torn away is not the same as never having been, and every grieving person knows this, and the

argument that says otherwise is an argument that only works in the study and dies at the bedside.

*The atheist account of death was
mature in the study and useless at the
bedside, where every fiber of me
insisted that this ending was not a
neutral fact but a wrong, and I have
learned to trust the bedside over the
study.*

I DO NOT OFFER this as a proof of the resurrection, because it is not, a longing for death not to be the end is not evidence that it is not the end, and the skeptic is right to say that our horror at death might be exactly the survival instinct we would expect evolution to install, and that the wish for it to be otherwise is the parent of a thousand consoling religions. I grant all of that. But I will say what the resurrection, if it is true, does to the question, which is not to deny death but to defeat it, not to say that death is an illusion or a doorway or a natural friend, the various ways religions and philosophies have tried to make peace with it, but to say that it is an enemy, the last enemy, a real horror and a real wrong, exactly as it presents itself at the bedside, and that it has been, in one instance, in history, undone, and that its undoing is the promise held out to those it has taken, and I find that this is the only account of death that neither lies about how bad it is

nor leaves me with nothing but the bad, that takes the outrage I feel at the bedside seriously as an outrage and then says the outrage will be answered, and I could not make myself believe it for years and then I found I could, and death has not stopped being terrible, I have not become one of those believers who talks about it lightly, but it has stopped being the end of the sentence, and that is a different thing to carry to the bedside, and I carry it, and I have watched it hold, in the actual room, when the mature account of my atheist years would have had nothing to say at all.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Character in the Gospels

I HAVE TO TELL you about the thing in the Gospels that I was least prepared for, because it was, in the end, one of the loads that broke the beam of my unbelief, and it is a thing that argument cannot deliver and that you can only get by reading the actual texts, which I had never done, having formed my entire opinion of Jesus from the culture around the Gospels rather than the Gospels themselves, which is, I have come to think, the situation of most educated unbelievers, who are quite sure they have rejected Christ and have in fact never met the figure in the documents, only the figure in the stained glass and the political slogans and the sentimental art.

When I finally read the Gospels straight through, as a skeptic, expecting either a bland moral teacher or a figure so encrusted with piety as to be unreadable, I met instead a character I did not expect and could not account for, a figure of such strangeness and force and originality that the ordinary theories of how he got onto the page began to strain. The theory I had held, vaguely, was that Jesus was a simple

Galilean preacher of love and kindness whom his later followers inflated into a divine being, that the historical man was a gentle sage and the God was a legend accreted over time. And the figure in the texts refused to fit this, because he is not primarily gentle, and he is not simple, and he is not making the kind of claims a modest sage makes, he is making claims of such staggering and specific audacity, forgiving sins as though the offenses were against him personally, speaking as though he stands in the place of God, telling people that their eternal destiny turns on their relation to him, and doing all of this not in the manner of a megalomaniac, which is the obvious diagnosis and the one Lewis famously pressed, but in the manner of someone so unforced and so free and so evidently sane that the megalomaniac theory dies on contact with the actual texture of the character.

This is the trilemma that Lewis made famous and that has been criticized and that I still find, when I read the texts rather than the summaries of the argument, harder to escape than its critics allow. The claims this figure makes are not the claims of a good teacher, because good teachers do not tell you that they are the light of the world and that your relation to them determines your eternal fate, so the comfortable modern position, that Jesus was a great moral teacher but not divine, is the one position the texts do not permit, because a merely human being who said the things he said would not be a great moral teacher, he would be a lunatic or a liar, and the figure in the texts is manifestly neither, does not read as either, reads as the most sane and truthful person in any room he enters, and the critics of the trilemma say there is a fourth option, that he was legend, that he never said these things and they were put in his mouth. And that is the real objection, and I took it seriously, and it fails for me on the

ground I mentioned in the resurrection chapter, that the sources are too early and too close for the legend to have done its work, and it fails on a further ground, which is that the character is too consistent and too original across the different sources to be a committee's invention, that no group of first-century fishermen and tax collectors had the literary genius to invent, collaboratively, the most compelling character in the history of literature and then agree to die for him, that the figure has the unmistakable quality of having been observed rather than composed.

And it was the small things that got me, more than the grand claims, the details that no inventor would think to include, the way he is angry in some scenes and weeps in others, the way he is exhausted and asks for water, the way he is sharp with his own followers and tender with the people everyone else despised, the way he refuses to be the kind of messiah everyone wanted and keeps disappointing the expectations of his own movement, which is the last thing a legend-building movement would invent, a founder who fails to meet the movement's hopes. The Jesus of the Gospels is constantly wrong-footing the people around him, saying the thing that offends his supporters, welcoming the wrong people, refusing the crown when it is offered, choosing the cross when he could have chosen the throne, and this is not how you build a legend, you build a legend by making the hero meet expectations, not by making him shatter them, and the shattering of expectations at every turn reads, to me, not as invention but as the friction of a real person against the hopes of the people who followed him, a friction so consistent and so specific that I could not, in the end, believe it had been composed.

*I had rejected a Jesus I had never read.
When I finally read him, I met a
character no committee of fishermen
could have invented, who kept
disappointing his own followers,
which is the last thing a legend does.*

I DO NOT SAY this proves his divinity, and Lewis oversold the trilemma slightly and I will not repeat his overselling, because the legend option is a real option and cannot be dismissed with a wave. What I say is that reading the actual texts destroyed the comfortable position I had held without reading them, the position that Jesus was a nice teacher of love whom I could admire while ignoring, because that Jesus is not in the texts, and the Jesus who is in the texts forces a harder choice, either he was mad, or he was lying, or the texts are legend, or he was what he said, and each of the first three options, when I actually examined it against the actual character, cost more than I had expected, strained against the evidence more than I had been told, until the option I had ruled out in advance began to look, against all my intention, like the one that accounted for the figure on the page, and I did not want that, and I resisted it, and I could not, finally, make the other options carry the weight, and a man who cannot make his preferred options carry the weight has to consider the option he does not prefer, and I did, at last, consider it, and here I am.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Slow Remaking of a Will

I WANT TO WRITE about what happened after, because the conversion narratives usually stop at the night it broke, at the moment of belief, as though that were the destination, and it is not the destination, it is the trailhead, and the real story, the harder and longer story, is what belief did to me over the years that followed, the slow and unfinished remaking of a will that had been formed by decades of unbelief and fatherlessness and pride, and I want to be honest that this remaking is incomplete, that I am not a finished man, that becoming a believer did not make me good, and that the gap between the belief I hold and the man I am is the central drama of my life now, and it is a drama with no resolution yet, and I promised you no clean resolutions.

Here is what I expected, in the naive weeks right after, and here is what actually happened, and the gap between them is instructive. I expected that belief would change me quickly, that the encounter I had described would produce a new man, that the old angers and fears and habits would fall away

in the light of the thing that had happened, and for a short while it seemed they might, there is a period after conversion, and I have seen it in others, where grace is so vivid that the old self seems simply gone, and it is a real and precious period and it is also, I have learned, temporary, and it is meant to be temporary, because it is the honeymoon and not the marriage. And then the old self came back, not all at once but gradually, the old angers, the old pride, the old fatherless fear of abandonment reasserting itself in my closest relationships, the old habits of self-protection, and I was dismayed, because I had thought the belief would have fixed them, and here they were, and I had to face the possibility that the whole thing had been an illusion after all, that if I were really changed the change would show, and it was not showing the way I had expected.

And what I learned, slowly, and it was one of the most important things I have learned, is that this is exactly how it is supposed to go, that the faith does not promise instant transformation, that it describes instead a long and painful process of being remade, called sanctification in the old vocabulary, which is not the sudden arrival of goodness but the lifelong, halting, two-steps-forward struggle of a real self being reshaped, and that the presence of the old self, far from disproving the change, is the very field on which the change is worked, that you cannot have your pride remade without your pride being present to be remade, and that the disappointment I felt at the return of the old man was itself a fruit of the new life, because the old atheist had not been disappointed in himself, the old atheist had made peace with his angers and called them realism, and only now, in the light of the thing I had come to believe, did I see them as things to be grieved and given up, and the seeing was itself the

beginning of the change, though it felt like the absence of change.

This has been the hardest and most honest part of the faith for me, harder than the intellectual objections, because the intellectual objections I could work through, and this cannot be worked through, it can only be lived through, slowly, over years, with many failures, and I have failed a great deal, and I have hurt people since becoming a believer, hurt them in the old ways, the ways formed by the old wound, and I have had to go back and ask forgiveness, and there is a particular shame in a pastor's failures, because the whole apparatus assumes you have your life more in order than you do, and I do not, and I have had to learn to live in the gap between what I preach and what I am, not by lowering what I preach to match what I am, which is the comfortable move, nor by pretending to be what I preach, which is the hypocrite's move, but by preaching the thing and confessing that I have not arrived at it, which is the only honest move and the one that costs the most, because it strips you of the authority that certainty confers and leaves you standing in front of people as a fellow struggler who happens to have been given a microphone.

*The night it broke was not the
destination. It was the trailhead. And
the trail turned out to be the slow,
failing, lifelong remaking of the very
self I thought conversion had already*

fixed.

BUT HERE IS THE thing I can report, from far enough down the trail to have some perspective, which is that over years, not weeks, over the long slow grind of it, there has been change, real change, that I am not the man I was, that the angers have less grip, that the fatherless fear has loosened, that I can stay in rooms I used to flee and forgive things I used to nurse and love people I used to hold at a distance, and that none of this happened by my own effort, or not by that alone, that it happened the way the faith says it happens, by grace, by the slow work of a presence I could not command, changing me from the inside faster than I could change myself, so that when I look back at the man I was, I do not see a man who improved himself through willpower and good ideas, I see a man who was worked on, remade against his own resistance, given things he could not have manufactured, and the cumulative evidence of that remaking, the change I did not author and could not have authored, is, to me, more persuasive now than any of the arguments in this book, because I have lived inside it, and I know what I was, and I know that I could not have made myself into what I am becoming, and that something did, and I know its name.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Five Sons, and the Fathering I Had to Learn

I HAVE FIVE SONS, and I have to write about them, because they are the place where everything in this book stops being an idea and becomes a body, a set of specific boys with specific faces who need a specific man to be present to them every day, and because the fathering of them has taught me more theology than any book, and because the wound I described at the beginning, the fatherlessness, is a wound I could not have healed by belief alone, it had to be healed by the daily practice of becoming the thing I never had, and that practice has been, in its own way, the most convincing argument of all, though it is not an argument, it is a life.

When my first son was born, I was terrified in a way I had no words for, and the terror was specific, it was not the ordinary terror of new fatherhood, it was the terror of a man who had been given no template for the thing he was now supposed to do, who had watched a father leave and had never once watched a father stay, who had, in the deepest layer of himself, a working model of fatherhood that

consisted of a single lesson, that fathers go, and who was now holding a child who needed him precisely not to go, and who did not know how to be a thing he had never seen. I want the skeptic to understand that this is not sentiment, this is data, that a man raised without a father is missing something concrete, a set of embodied knowledge that most people absorb without noticing, and that when he becomes a father he discovers the hole not as a feeling but as a practical incapacity, a not-knowing-what-to-do that visits him in the ordinary moments when a fathered man would simply act on instinct and he has no instinct to act on, or rather he has an instinct, and the instinct is to withdraw, to protect himself against the abandonment he is sure is coming by never fully arriving in the first place.

And I have had to fight that instinct every day for years, the instinct to hold back, to not fully give myself to these boys, because fully giving yourself is how you get destroyed when they leave, or when you leave, because the deepest lie the wound taught me was that leaving is what fathers finally do, and so a part of me was always braced for my own departure, always keeping a reserve, always half-packed, and the fighting of that instinct, the daily deliberate choosing to stay all the way, to be fully present, to give the whole of myself to boys who might break my heart, has been the hardest labor of my life, harder than pastoring, harder than believing, and I could not have done it out of my own resources, because my own resources were exactly the problem, the wound was in the resources, and you cannot heal a wound with the wounded thing.

Here is where the faith became not an idea but a necessity, because what let me stay, what has let me fight the instinct to withdraw, was not willpower, I had tried willpower and

willpower runs out, it was the specific thing I described in the chapter on the Father, that I had been fathered myself, late, on a tired night and in the years after, by a Father who did not leave, and that you cannot give what you have not received, but you can give what you have received, and I had received it, and so I had, for the first time, something to give, a template at last, not from my own past, which had none, but from the thing that had happened to me, the experience of being stayed with unconditionally, which I could now, imperfectly, failingly, extend to five boys who needed exactly that and whom I could not have given it to out of my own empty account. I am fathering my sons out of a fathering I received, and I did not receive it from a man, I received it from the One I spent my life denying, and this is not a metaphor, it is the actual mechanism by which five specific boys are getting a present father instead of the absent one their father had, and I cannot explain it any other way, and I have tried.

And they have taught me, in return, more about God than I taught them, because in loving them I have felt, from the inside, a love I could not have imagined from the outside, the love of a father for a child who has done nothing to earn it, who is loved simply for being, before any performance, and I have watched myself love them through their failures and their rages and their turning away, love them not less when they are unlovely but somehow more, and I have thought, more than once, holding a furious child who was pushing me away, so this is what it is, this is the thing I could not believe, that there is a love that is not earned and cannot be lost, because I am feeling it right now, I am generating it toward this child, I who am a broken and selfish man, and if I, being evil, can love like this, then the love at the bottom of things, if

there is a love at the bottom of things, must be this and more, and the argument that had seemed abstract when I read it in books became, in the act of fathering, something I was doing with my own hands, a small and cracked image of a larger thing, and the image persuaded me of the original more than the books ever had.

*I could not father my sons out of my
own resources, because the wound was
in the resources. I had to be fathered
first, and I was, by the One I denied,
and now five boys have a father
because I finally did.*

THERE IS A FEAR underneath this that I should name, the fear that I am doing to my sons in reverse what my father did to me, that just as his absence shaped my unbelief, my presence and my faith are shaping their belief, that they will grow up believing because their father believes, and that this is not the discovery of truth but the transmission of culture, the same mechanism that would have made me a Muslim in Karachi, and that I have simply installed in them what was installed in me, only pointed the other way. And I feel the force of this and I will not dismiss it, and I have decided the only honest thing is to raise them to be able to doubt, to teach them the objections in this book at full strength, to tell them that their father was an atheist and took the atheism seriously and would rather they became honest unbelievers than

dishonest believers, and to give them the freedom I fought for, the freedom to follow the truth wherever it goes, even if it goes away from the faith I hold, because a faith that has to be protected from doubt is not worth transmitting, and if what I found is real it will survive their honest questioning, and if it is not real I do not want to have chained them to it, and this, too, I learned from being fathered by a Father who did not force belief but left the space for it to be free, and I am trying to father the same way, leaving my sons the space, and it terrifies me, and I do it anyway, because forced belief is not belief and I will not manufacture in them the thing that would prove nothing.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Plausibility of Belief in an Unbelieving Age

I WANT TO RETURN to Charles Taylor and the secular age, because there is a dimension of my story I have not fully told, which is not about arguments at all but about plausibility, about what a given society makes it easy or hard to believe, and I think this is the least understood and most powerful force in the whole matter, more powerful than any argument, and understanding it changed how I think about my own conversion and about why it is so hard for the people I most want to reach.

Here is the thing Taylor helped me see, and it is uncomfortable for both the believer and the skeptic. Most people, most of the time, do not believe or disbelieve on the basis of arguments. They believe or disbelieve on the basis of what the people around them believe, what their society treats as obvious, what Taylor and the sociologists call the plausibility structure, the web of shared assumptions that makes some things seem live and real and possible and other things seem like survivals from a childish past. In a society

where everyone believes, belief is easy, it is the water you swim in, and unbelief requires a heroic act of independent thought against the whole social weight. And in a society like the one I grew up in, where the educated classes have quietly set belief aside, unbelief is the water, and it is belief that requires the heroic act, the swimming against the current, the willingness to hold a view your professors and your colleagues and your whole cultural cohort regard as slightly embarrassing.

And this is uncomfortable for the believer because it means that a great deal of belief, in believing societies, is not the fruit of genuine encounter but merely the path of least resistance, the absorption of the surrounding consensus, and that much of what looks like faith is really conformity, and the pious do not like to hear this. But it is far more uncomfortable for the skeptic, and this is the part I most want to press, because the skeptic imagines that his unbelief is the fruit of independent rational thought, that he has reasoned his way out of the faith while the believers merely inherited theirs, and Taylor's account suggests that this is very often exactly backward, that the modern unbeliever is frequently the conformist, the one absorbing the consensus of his cohort without examination, believing what all the clever people around him believe because they believe it, taking his unbelief in with the air of his social world rather than reasoning his way to it, so that his sense of being the independent thinker who broke free is itself a piece of the consensus he absorbed, the flattering self-image that his particular unbelieving culture hands to its members, and that if he had been born in a believing culture the very same conformist temperament would have made him a devout believer with equal conviction and equal illusion of

independence.

I say this having been that conformist without knowing it. I thought I had reasoned my way to atheism, and I had reasons, and the reasons were real, but when I look back honestly I see that I also swam with a current, that my unbelief was made vastly easier by the fact that everyone I admired was an unbeliever, that belief would have cost me the respect of the people whose respect I wanted, that the plausibility structure of my world made atheism the obvious mature position and belief the embarrassing one, and that I had absorbed this atmosphere long before I had the arguments, that the arguments came later and served, in part, to justify a stance I had already taken up for reasons that had more to do with belonging than with logic. This is not a comfortable thing to admit, and I resisted admitting it for a long time, because it undermines the flattering story that I was the independent thinker, but it is true, and the honesty this book is trying to keep requires me to say it.

*The modern unbeliever imagines he
reasoned his way out. Often he simply
breathed in the air of a cohort that had
already exhaled belief, and mistook the
conformity for courage.*

AND THIS IS WHY my conversion had to happen the way it did, against the current, at cost, over resistance, because in my plausibility structure there was no easy slide into belief,

no social reward for it, quite the reverse, and so when belief came it could not be explained as the path of least resistance, it was the path of greatest resistance, the swimming against the whole weight of my world, and this is, I have come to think, one of the few advantages the believer has in a secular age, that his belief cannot be the mere conformity that belief so often is in a believing age, that he has had to fight for it against the current, and that the fighting, while it makes belief rarer, makes the belief that survives the fighting more likely to be real, more likely to be the fruit of genuine encounter rather than social absorption, because the social forces were all pushing the other way. The secular age makes belief harder. It also makes the belief that makes it through harder, in the other sense, more tested, more costly, more its own, and I would not trade my hard-won secular-age belief for the easy inherited belief of a more religious time, because mine had to survive everything my world could throw at it, and a faith that has survived that is a different animal than a faith that was never contested, and I say this to encourage the skeptic who fears that if he believed he would just be conforming, and I tell him, no, in your world, in ours, belief is the last thing that could be called conformity, belief is now the rebellion, and the honest rebel, the one who follows the truth against his own cohort, is exactly the one most likely to find it.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Forgiveness, and the Father Who Left

I HAVE TO COME back to my father, the human one, the one who left, because I have written a great deal about the Father who stayed and I have not yet told you what happened to the wound at the root, and it would be dishonest to end this book with the wound merely spiritualized, healed at the level of theology while left festering at the level of the actual man who actually left, because that is not how it went, and the actual man had to be dealt with, and dealing with him was one of the hardest and most concrete things the faith ever required of me.

For most of my life, the anger at my father was a settled and load-bearing part of me, and I did not think of it as anger, I thought of it as clarity, as the accurate assessment of a man who had failed, and I nursed it, and it did work for me, it explained things, it gave me a villain, it let me locate the source of my pain in someone other than myself, and it protected me from the more frightening possibility, that the leaving had not been about my worth at all, that I had

constructed an entire theory of my own unlovability around a man's failure that had nothing to do with me, and that the anger, terrible as it was, was more bearable than the alternative, which was to grieve a loss that had no reason, to accept that I had been left for reasons that were about him and not about me and that I would therefore never get the accounting I wanted, never get the moment where he explained, or apologized, or made it make sense, because he was not going to, and the anger let me keep waiting for that moment, kept the account open, kept me in relationship with him through the medium of my rage, because as long as I was angry at him he was still, in a sense, present, still someone I was in contact with, and to forgive him would be to finally let him go, to close the account, to accept that the moment I wanted was never coming, and that was a grief I could not face, so I kept the anger, and called it clarity, for decades.

And the faith would not let me keep it. This is the thing I most want the skeptic to understand about what belief actually costs, because the skeptic imagines faith as a comfort, and here is the discomfort, that the faith I came to hold made a demand on me at the exact point of my deepest wound, said, in effect, you must forgive him, and I did not want to, and I had, I thought, every right not to, and the demand seemed at first like an insult, a further injury, as though the wound were not enough and now I was being told to absolve the one who inflicted it. And I resisted this longer than I resisted any doctrine, because the doctrines were in my head and this was in my gut, and I said, why should I forgive him, he never asked, he never apologized, he is not sorry, forgiveness is something you extend to the repentant and he has not repented, and to forgive him would be to let him off, to pretend it did not matter, to betray the boy at the

window.

And here is what the faith taught me about forgiveness, slowly, and it was not what I thought forgiveness was, and understanding it changed everything. Forgiveness is not saying that what he did was acceptable, it was not, and forgiveness does not require that he apologize or repent or even know, because forgiveness, I learned, is not primarily a transaction between two people, it is something that happens first inside the one who forgives, it is the decision to stop requiring the debt to be paid, to release the account, to stop letting the injury define you and control you and keep you chained to the one who inflicted it, and it is, above all, the refusal to become like him, because unforgiveness slowly makes you into a version of the person who hurt you, hardens you in the shape of your wound, and I had felt this happening, I had felt myself becoming a man defined by an absence, cold in the places he was cold, and forgiveness was the way out of that, not a gift to him, who did not want it and would never know of it, but a release for me, the cutting of the chain that ran from my wound to his failure and bound me to a man who had long since walked away.

*Forgiveness was not letting him off. It
was cutting the chain that still bound
me to a man who had walked away
decades before, and only I was still
holding the other end.*

I FORGAVE HIM, IN the end, and I want to be honest that it was not a single moment but a long process, and that it was possible only because I had first been forgiven myself, because I had stood in the place of the debtor before God and been released from a debt I could not pay, and having been released I found I could no longer, in good conscience, hold my father's debt against him with the fist I had held it with, because the same mercy that had reached me was reaching, through me, toward him, and I could refuse to pass it on, I could be the servant in the parable who is forgiven the great debt and then throttles his fellow servant over a small one, but I could not do it without knowing exactly what I was doing, without feeling the hypocrisy of a forgiven man refusing to forgive, and so I forgave him, and the strange thing, the thing I did not expect, is that the forgiveness did not diminish the boy at the window, did not betray him, but freed him, let him finally leave the window, let him stop waiting for the accounting that was never coming, because he had received a different accounting, from a different Father, and no longer needed the one the earthly father would never give. And my father died some years ago, and we were not reconciled in any full sense, because you cannot reconcile with a man who does not think there is anything to reconcile, but I had forgiven him before he died, and when the news came I did not feel the thing I had feared I would feel, the reopening of the old rage, I felt grief, clean grief, the grief of a loss without the poison of the anger, and I was able to grieve him as a man I had forgiven rather than hate him as a man who had failed me, and that difference, the difference between grieving and hating, is the whole of what the faith gave me at the site of my oldest wound, and it is not nothing, it is very nearly everything, and I could not have

manufactured it, and I know where it came from.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Joy, Which Is Not Happiness

I HAVE TO WRITE about joy before I bring this book toward its close, because it is the thing I was least prepared for and least able to explain, and because it corrects the impression, which the chapters on cost and doubt and the unfinished remaking may have left, that I traded the clean freedom of unbelief for a heavy and demanding faith and got, in exchange for the weight, only more weight. That is not the whole account. There is also joy, and I have to tell you about it, though it is the hardest of all to describe, because it is so easily confused with the cheap thing that wears its name.

Let me distinguish it first from what it is not, because the distinction is everything. Joy is not happiness. Happiness is a mood, tied to circumstances, rising when things go well and falling when they do not, a weather system passing over the surface of a life, and I had happiness as an atheist, real happiness, good days, love, work I enjoyed, and I do not want to pretend that unbelief is a gray and joyless condition, because it is not, and the believers who caricature it that way

are lying and the unbelievers know they are lying. I was happy, often, as an atheist. What I did not have, what I did not even have a category for, was the thing Lewis called Joy with a capital letter and what the tradition calls by various names, a settled undercurrent that runs beneath the moods, present in the good days and, more strangely, present in the bad ones, a kind of deep-water stillness that the surface weather does not reach, and I have it now, intermittently, unpredictably, not as a mood but as something under the moods, and I did not have it before, and its arrival is one of the changes I most struggle to account for on any theory but the one I now hold.

Here is the strange thing about it, the thing that most distinguishes it from happiness and most persuades me it is not merely a psychological benefit of religious belief, a placebo of contentment. It shows up in suffering. I have known it most intensely not in the good times but in the hard ones, at bedsides, in grief, in the seasons of my own failure and darkness, a joy that has no business being there, that is not the denial of the suffering, not a spiritual bypassing of the pain, the suffering is fully present and fully painful, but underneath it, coexisting with it, not canceling it, there is this other thing, this stillness, this sense of being held in a darkness that is not empty, and I cannot manufacture it, it comes and goes as it will, but when it comes it comes precisely where happiness cannot go, into the places happiness flees, and a contentment that shows up in the ruins is a different kind of thing than the contentment that depends on the house being intact.

The atheist account of this, and I give it its due, is that religious belief provides a sense of cosmic security, a feeling of being cared for by a benevolent universe, and that this feeling produces real psychological benefits, real resilience in

suffering, and that the joy I describe is simply that, the placebo effect of a comforting belief, and that it does not require the belief to be true, only to be held, so that the joy is evidence of the psychological power of faith and not of its truth. And I take this seriously, because it is true that belief produces psychological benefits, and it is true that a placebo can produce real effects, and I cannot prove that my joy is not a very sophisticated placebo, a feeling of being held generated by the belief that I am held, whether or not I am actually held. I grant that I cannot prove it. But I will say the thing that makes the placebo account harder than it looks, which is that the joy has a specific quality that placebos, in my experience, do not, the quality of coming from outside, of being given rather than generated, of arriving unbidden and often unwanted, at times when I was not seeking comfort and was in fact resisting it, and a comfort you resist and receive anyway is a strange kind of self-generated placebo, because the self was not cooperating in the generation.

*Happiness needs the house intact. Joy
showed up in the ruins, uninvited, at
the bedside, in the grief, where
happiness cannot go, and I did not
generate it, because I was not seeking it.*

AND THERE IS A further thing about this joy that I have to name, because it connects to the argument from desire that ran all through the early chapters, which is that the joy is not

a resting place either, it does not satisfy the longing I described, it deepens it. This surprised me. I had expected that faith, if it were true, would fill the ache I had carried all my life, the homesickness for I knew not what, and instead the ache is more acute now, not less, because now it has a direction, now it knows what it wants, and wanting a thing you know is more painful than wanting a thing you cannot name, and the joy, when it comes, is not the satisfaction of the longing but the intensification of it, a taste that makes you hungrier, a note of the music from the country you are homesick for, that does not bring you home but tells you the home is real and you are not there yet. Lewis said this, that the joy was itself a kind of longing, a wanting that was somehow better than any having, and I did not understand it until I had it, and now I do, and it is the thing I would least give up, this joy that is a hunger, this satisfaction that deepens the appetite, this foretaste that makes the waiting harder and sweeter at once, and it is not happiness, it is something for which our language has no good word, and it is real, and I did not have it before, and I have it now, and I cannot fully explain how it got here, but I know it was not here before the night it broke, and it has been here, on and off, ever since.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Honesty That Cut Both Ways

I HAVE MADE A great deal in this book of intellectual honesty, of following the truth wherever it leads, of not straw-manning the position I left, and I want to turn that honesty now on my own new position, on the faith I hold, because a man who is only honest about the beliefs he has abandoned and not about the ones he has adopted is not honest at all, he has simply moved his dishonesty to a new address, and I would be doing exactly what I have criticized the apologists for doing if I ended this book without turning the same hard light on my faith that I turned on my unbelief.

So let me say plainly the things about my faith that I cannot resolve, the places where the honesty cuts against me, because they exist, and pretending they do not would forfeit everything I have tried to build. The problem of suffering, which I addressed early, I did not solve, and I want to say again that I did not solve it, that the child with bone cancer is still dead and I still do not know why a good and powerful God permitted it, and that the answer I offered, that God entered

the suffering rather than explaining it, is a real answer to a different question and not an answer to the question of why the suffering is there at all, and that on my honest days I feel the full weight of this as an objection to my own faith and not merely as a difficulty I have handled. The hiddenness of God, which I addressed, I did not dissolve, and there are still nights when the silence I described feels like exactly what it felt like to the boy at the window, and the sophisticated account of why a good God might hide feels thin against the brute experience of the silence, and I have to hold my faith through that thinness and not pretend the account has made the silence stop being silence.

And there are the things I did not address, because a book cannot address everything, and I should at least name them so you know I know they are there. There is the sheer strangeness and offense of particular Christian doctrines, the ones that even believers stumble over, and I stumble over them, I did not come to a faith that resolved every difficulty into serene sense, I came to a faith full of hard sayings and dark passages and claims that trouble the modern conscience, and I hold it not because I have answered every one of these but because the center held, because the thing I encountered at the center was compelling enough that I chose to trust it through the difficulties I could not resolve, which is what trusting a person is, you do not withhold trust until you have understood everything about them, you trust the person you have come to know and then work through the puzzles from within the trust, and that is what I am doing, and it is not the same as having no puzzles, and I will not claim it is.

There is the question of the text itself, the Bible, which I came to with all the skepticism of a critical reader and which

I did not stop reading critically once I believed, and I want to say that I hold the Scriptures as a believer without holding them the way the fundamentalists of my youth held them, that I do not think honest faith requires me to flatten every difficulty in the text or to deny what the scholarship has established about how these documents came to be, and that a great deal of the unbelief I encounter is unbelief not in God but in a particular brittle theory of the Bible that the faith does not actually require, and that I had to distinguish, painfully, between the core of the thing and the brittle theory that had been wrapped around it, and to keep the core when I could not keep the theory, and this too is an ongoing labor and not a settled result.

*I turned the hard light on my unbelief
and I have to turn it on my faith. The
suffering is not solved. The silence is
still silence. I hold the center through
the difficulties, not because I have none.*

I SAY ALL OF this not to undermine what I have built but to keep it honest, because a faith that has to hide its difficulties is a weak faith, a flammable faith, the kind that shatters the first time it meets a hard question it was never allowed to consider, and I do not have that faith and I do not want it and I would not commend it to you. The faith I have is a faith with the difficulties fully in view, held not because the difficulties have been eliminated but because, with the difficulties fully

in view, the thing at the center still compels me, still seems to me, on balance, with everything weighed, the truest account of the whole of my experience, the world and the suffering and the beauty and the moral law and the historical claims and the encounter I cannot explain away, and I hold it the way an honest person holds any large belief about the deepest things, provisionally in the sense that I remain open to being wrong, firmly in the sense that I have staked my life on it, and both at once, which is the only honest way to hold a belief about a matter you cannot prove and cannot escape, and it is the way I once should have held my unbelief and did not, because I held my unbelief as though it were the settled default rather than the staked position it actually was, and if I have done anything in this book I hope I have shown that unbelief is a staked position too, held on faith too, open to being wrong too, and that the honesty I now try to bring to my faith is an honesty I owed to my unbelief and did not pay, and that paying it, finally, is part of what walked me across.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

To the One Who Cannot Believe and Wishes He Could

THERE IS A PARTICULAR person I have not yet addressed directly, and I have saved him for near the end because he is, in some ways, the person I was in my last atheist years and the person this book is most for, and he is not the confident atheist who has no wish to believe and is content in his unbelief, and he is not the seeker who is halfway to faith already, he is the one in between, the one who has come to see what would follow if it were true, who no longer finds unbelief simply comfortable, who feels the pull I described but cannot make the pull into belief, who says, and means it, I would believe if I could but I cannot, I cannot make myself believe a thing I do not believe, and who feels this as a genuine grief and not a pose. I want to speak to him, because I was him, and because the things people said to me in that condition were mostly useless, and I have thought a great deal about what would have actually helped.

The first thing I want to say to him is that his condition is not a failure and not a sin and not evidence against him, that the inability to believe by an act of will is not a moral defect but simply a fact about how belief works, that you cannot decide to believe the sky is green and you cannot decide to believe in God, and that the people who tell you to just have faith, as though faith were a decision you are stubbornly refusing to make, do not understand faith and do not understand you, and you are right to be frustrated with them. Belief is not under the direct control of the will. It is a response to what seems true, and you cannot make a thing seem true by wanting it to, and your honesty in refusing to pretend to a belief you do not have is not the obstacle to faith, it is a form of the very integrity that faith, if it comes, will come through and not around.

The second thing I want to say to him is the thing Pascal said, which I resisted and then found to be true, that if belief is not under the direct control of the will, it is under the indirect control of the life, that we come to believe things not only by being argued into them but by living toward them, by practice, by habit, by the slow reshaping of the whole person through what the person does, and that the demand to be intellectually convinced before taking any step is itself a kind of trap, because it treats belief as purely a matter of the intellect when it is a matter of the whole person, and that the way forward, for the one who wants to believe and cannot, is not to sit and wait for certainty but to begin, tentatively, to live as though it might be true, to practice the practices, to sit in the silence, to read the texts not as a critic dismantling them but as a person listening for whether anything speaks, to keep the company of people who believe, not to be manipulated by them but to see whether the thing they have

is real, and to let belief come, if it comes, as the fruit of a life leaned in that direction rather than as the conclusion of an argument won in a chair.

I want to be careful here, because this can sound like the fake-it-till-you-make-it advice that I despise, the manufacturing of belief through behavior, and it is not that, and the difference is crucial. I am not telling him to pretend to believe. I am telling him that belief, like love, like most of the deepest human commitments, is not primarily a proposition assented to but a relationship entered, and that you do not enter a relationship by first proving the other person is worth loving and then loving them, you enter it by beginning to act toward them in the way the relationship requires and discovering, in the acting, whether the reality is there, and that this is not dishonesty, it is the only way relationships are ever formed, and that the God who is at issue is, if he is anything, a person and not a proposition, and that the way to find out whether a person is there is not the way to find out whether a proposition is true, it is closer to the way you find out whether a person can be trusted, which is by beginning, at some risk, to trust, and watching what happens.

*You cannot decide to believe. But you
can decide to live toward the thing, to
sit in the silence, to listen, to risk the
beginning of trust, and to see whether
anything is there. That is not
pretending. That is how relationships*

start.

AND THE LAST THING I want to say to him is the thing I most wish someone had said to me, which is that his wanting to believe, the very grief he feels at his inability, the very fact that he no longer finds unbelief simply comfortable, is not nothing, is not a neutral fact, is possibly, and I say only possibly, the pull itself, the steady unrelenting approach, felt from the inside, before it has a name, and that the ache to believe that he takes as the mark of his exclusion may be the first evidence of the very thing he cannot yet grasp, the way the pull of the shore is felt by the swimmer before he can see the land, and that I cannot promise him it is, and I will not manufacture a certainty I do not have, but that I felt exactly what he feels, the wanting without the ability, the grief of the closed door, for years before the door opened, and that the wanting turned out to be, in my case, not the absence of God but one of the ways God was present, the homesickness that was itself the first quiet word of the home, and that if he is feeling it he should not despise it or explain it away, he should attend to it, honor it, follow it, because it may be, and I say only may, the beginning of the thing he thinks he cannot have, arriving under the disguise of the very hunger he took as proof it would never come.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

The Miracles I Would Not Consider

I HAVE TO COME back to miracles, because I addressed the resurrection as a historical question but I did not address the deeper thing underneath my resistance to it, which was not about the specific evidence for the specific event but about a prior conviction I held so deeply I did not know I held it, the conviction that miracles do not happen, cannot happen, and that any report of one is therefore automatically to be explained some other way, and I want to examine that conviction, because it was doing more work in my unbelief than any argument, and it was, when I finally looked at it, not the empirical conclusion I had taken it for but a philosophical assumption I had inherited and never tested.

Here is the assumption, stated plainly. The universe is a closed system of natural causes, and every event has a natural cause, and the idea of a supernatural intervention, a suspension or overriding of the natural order by an agent outside it, is not merely unproven but incoherent, a category error, a survival of a prescientific way of thinking that the

advance of knowledge has rendered impossible for a serious modern person. I held this, and I held it as though it were a finding of science, and it is not a finding of science, it is a philosophical position called naturalism, and the distinction matters more than almost anything else in this whole book, because I had smuggled a philosophy in under the flag of science and then used it to rule out in advance any evidence that might have counted against it, which is not the procedure of an open mind following the evidence but the procedure of a closed system defending itself.

Look at how the assumption functions, because this is the thing that finally troubled me. If I begin with the conviction that miracles cannot happen, then no amount of evidence for a miracle can ever move me, because I will always, correctly by my own lights, judge that any natural explanation, however improbable, is more likely than a miracle, since a miracle has a probability of zero by assumption, and any natural explanation, however strained, has a probability greater than zero. This is airtight. It cannot fail. And that is exactly the problem with it, that it cannot fail, that it is constructed so that no possible evidence could ever count against it, and a belief that no possible evidence could ever count against is not a scientific belief, it is a dogma, held with the very closed certainty I had always accused the religious of holding, and I held it, and I called it open-minded empiricism, and it was neither open nor empirical, it was a prior commitment that predetermined every verdict.

And when I saw this, I did not conclude that miracles happen, that would be the opposite error, believing in miracles on the basis of a philosophical argument rather than evidence. What I concluded was smaller and more important, that I had to actually be open, genuinely open, to the

possibility, that I had to stop ruling out the supernatural in advance and instead ask, honestly, case by case, what best explains the evidence, allowing that the answer might, in a given case, be that a natural explanation is available and adequate, and might, in another case, be that no natural explanation is adequate and the least strained account of all the evidence is that something happened that the closed system does not permit. And this is a frightening openness, because it removes the automatic defense, it means you have to actually look at the evidence and follow it, and it means that the resurrection, which I had dismissed with the automatic defense, now had to be considered on the actual evidence, and I have told you what happened when I considered it on the actual evidence, which is that the natural explanations turned out to cost more than I had assumed, and that with the automatic defense removed I could no longer make them carry the weight.

I had not concluded miracles were impossible. I had assumed it, and then arranged my reasoning so no evidence could ever reach the assumption. That is not empiricism. It is a dogma with a lab coat on.

I WANT TO BE fair to the naturalist, because the position is not stupid, and there is a real argument, going back to Hume, that our uniform experience is of natural regularity, that we

never in our own lives witness the dead rising or the water turning to wine, and that this uniform experience is itself powerful evidence that such things do not happen, so that the assumption against miracles is not arbitrary but is grounded in the overwhelming weight of ordinary experience. And this is a serious argument and I felt it and I still feel it. But I came to see its limit, which is that it establishes only that miracles are rare, extraordinarily rare, which no one denies, that is what makes them miracles, and it does not establish that they are impossible, and the move from very rare to impossible is the move from a reasonable weighting of the evidence to a dogmatic exclusion of it, and the whole question is which of these two the naturalist is doing, and I discovered that I had been doing the second while believing I was doing the first, that I had let a reasonable presumption against the extraordinary harden into an absolute exclusion of it, and that the hardening was doing all the work, and that once I softened it back to what the evidence actually supported, a strong presumption but not an absolute bar, the door I had bolted shut was merely closed, and a merely closed door can be opened by sufficient evidence, and the evidence for one event in particular turned out to be pressing on the door harder than I had ever allowed myself to feel.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

On the Fear of Being Fooled

I HAVE CIRCLED BACK many times in this book to the thing I said at the very beginning, that the deepest drive in my atheism was the determination not to be fooled, and I want to give it a chapter of its own now, near the end, because I have come to think it is the master key to a great deal of modern unbelief, and to my own, and because examining it was one of the last things that had to happen before I could believe, and it is a thing the confident skeptic almost never examines, because it feels not like a psychology to be examined but like the very definition of intellectual virtue.

The fear of being fooled is a good thing, up to a point. It is the engine of science, of criticism, of every advance in human knowledge, the refusal to accept the comforting story, the demand for evidence, the suspicion of authority and tradition and wishful thinking, and I do not disown it and I would not want a world without it and I am glad I had it. But a good thing carried past its proper limit becomes a distorting thing, and the fear of being fooled, when it becomes the master drive,

when it organizes the whole personality, stops being a tool for finding truth and becomes an obstacle to it, because it introduces a systematic bias, a bias against belief as such, against commitment, against trust, and this bias is invisible to the person who has it, because he experiences it not as a bias but as rigor, not as a distortion but as clarity, and he applies it asymmetrically without knowing he is doing so.

Here is the asymmetry, and it took me years to see it. The man whose master drive is the fear of being fooled is terrified of one kind of error, the error of believing something false, of being taken in, of being the credulous dupe, and he organizes his whole intellectual life around avoiding that error, and he does avoid it, he becomes very hard to fool. But there are two kinds of error a person can make about any claim, and he is attending to only one of them. The first is to believe something false. The second is to disbelieve something true. And these are both errors, both failures to track the truth, both ways of getting reality wrong, and the man whose master drive is the fear of being fooled has trained himself to avoid the first at all costs while remaining almost entirely blind to the second, so that he congratulates himself on his rigor every time he disbelieves, never noticing that disbelief can be an error too, that refusing to believe a true thing is as much a failure of the truth-seeking mind as believing a false one, and that a policy of disbelieving everything you cannot prove is not a policy of avoiding error, it is a policy of trading one kind of error for the other, of choosing the error of missed truths over the error of accepted falsehoods, as though the first were not an error at all.

And I made that trade without knowing I was making it, and I made it because the error of being fooled was, for me, the more frightening one, and it was the more frightening one

for reasons that were not about the pursuit of truth at all, they were about the wound, they were about a boy who had been, in the deepest way, fooled, who had trusted that a father would stay and been betrayed by that trust, and who had concluded, in the wordless logic of a wounded child, that trust is the thing that destroys you, that the credulous are the ones who get hurt, that safety lies in never believing, never committing, never opening yourself to the possibility that the thing you trusted will fail you, and that the whole apparatus of my adult skepticism, my rigor, my refusal to be fooled, my pride in disbelief, was, at its root, not a philosophy at all but a defense, the armor of a child who had decided that the way to never be betrayed again was to never trust anything, and to call the never-trusting by the flattering name of intellectual honesty.

The fear of being fooled made me very hard to fool. It also made me hard to reach, because I had trained myself to treat every disbelief as a victory and never noticed that disbelieving a true thing is a defeat.

I DO NOT SAY this to discredit the skeptic's rigor, because the rigor is real and valuable and I keep it still. I say it to name a bias that the rigor conceals, and to suggest that the fully honest truth-seeker must fear both errors equally, must be as afraid of missing a truth as of accepting a falsehood, must

hold the two fears in balance, and that when the fear of being fooled becomes the master drive it destroys that balance and produces a systematic tilt toward unbelief that masquerades as neutrality, and that this tilt is not the view from nowhere, it is a view from a very particular somewhere, often from a wound, and that the skeptic who prides himself on following the evidence must ask whether he is following the evidence or following his fear, whether his disbelief is the conclusion of an open inquiry or the reflex of a defended heart, and I had to ask myself that, and the answer, when I finally let myself hear it, was that my unbelief was far more defended and far less open than I had ever allowed myself to know, that I had been protecting myself under the guise of protecting the truth, and that the day I saw this was the day the armor began, at last, to come off, not because I had been argued out of it but because I had finally seen it for what it was, armor and not clarity, and a man who sees his armor as armor can, for the first time, consider taking it off.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

What the Church Is For, From the Inside

I SPENT A CHAPTER early in this book facing the harms of the church honestly, and I have to write a companion to it now, from the far side of many years inside, about what the church is actually for, because my atheist picture of the church was as distorted in the positive direction as in the negative, and because the skeptic who has rejected the church has almost always rejected a thing he has never experienced from the inside, a building he has only seen from the street, and I owe him a report from inside the building, not to excuse its faults, which I have already refused to excuse, but to tell him what the thing is actually for, which he cannot know from the street.

From the street, the church looks like an institution, an organization with buildings and budgets and hierarchies and a product to sell, and it is, in part, all of those things, and the parts of it that are those things are the parts most prone to the corruptions I named earlier, because institutions corrupt, all of them, religious and secular alike, and there is nothing

about the church as institution that exempts it from the diseases of institutions, and I watch those diseases operate in it from the inside with a clearer and sadder eye than I ever had from the outside. But the church is not, at its core, an institution, or the institution is the shell of a thing that is not institutional at all, and the thing inside the shell is what I could not see from the street and can see now, which is a gathering of broken people who have been found by the same mercy and who are trying, badly, to become a community that lives by that mercy, and the emphasis is on the badly, because a church is not a museum of the finished but a hospital for the failing, and I keep having to say this because the skeptic's objection, that the church is full of hypocrites and broken people, is not an objection to the church, it is a description of the church, it is what the church is for, it is a hospital, and a hospital full of sick people is not a scandal, it is a hospital doing its job.

What I did not understand from the street is that the church is the place where the thing I have been describing in this whole book, the grace, the being found, the slow remaking, gets carried and transmitted and practiced across generations, that it is not primarily a set of beliefs but a community of practice, a people who gather to remind each other of the thing they are all prone to forget, that they are loved, that they are forgiven, that the reciprocity engine is not the final word, and that human beings cannot hold onto this alone, that the gravity of our nature pulls us constantly back toward earning and despair and self-justification, and that we need each other, need the gathering, need the reminding, need to hear the words said aloud again and again by other broken people who are also forgetting and being reminded, because grace is not a thing you learn once and possess, it is a

thing you have to be re-given continually, and the church is the community that exists to keep re-giving it, to be the place where the word is spoken again this week to people who have spent the week forgetting it.

And I found, inside, a thing I could not have predicted from the outside, which is the specific texture of a community that is honest about its own brokenness, that does not pretend, that gathers precisely on the basis of not being good, and how different this is from every other community I had belonged to, all of which gathered on the basis of some shared excellence or achievement or affinity, and how the church, at its best, and it is not always at its best, is the one community I have found that you enter not by being good enough but by admitting you are not, so that the price of admission is the confession of your unworthiness, which means that the pretense that poisons every other community, the performance of being better than you are, is, in the church at its best, structurally undercut, because the whole thing is founded on the admission that none of us is better than we are, and this produces, when it works, and it does not always work, a strange freedom, the freedom of not having to pretend, the freedom of being known in your failure and loved anyway, and I had never had that anywhere, and I had not known it was possible, and it is the thing I would most want the skeptic to experience, because it cannot be argued, it can only be tasted.

The church is not a museum of the finished. It is a hospital for the failing, and the skeptic's objection that it is full of broken people is not a bug in the church. It is the whole point.

I WILL NOT OVERSELL this, because I have also seen the church fail at exactly this, seen it become a place of pretense and performance and mutual judgment, the opposite of what it is for, and I do not want to hand the skeptic a rosy picture that his own experience of an actual church will immediately contradict, because he may well have experienced the church at its worst, and the church at its worst is genuinely terrible, and I will not defend it. But I want him to know that the terrible thing he may have experienced is the corruption of a thing that is, at its core, unlike anything else on offer, a community founded on the confession of failure and the reception of an unearned love, and that when he sees the church failing to be this, he is seeing not the church but its betrayal, and that the standard by which he judges the betrayal is the church's own standard, handed to him by the church, and that somewhere, imperfectly, in some actual gathering of actual broken people, the thing itself is happening, the mercy is being re-given, the pretense is being dropped, the strangers are becoming a family on the basis of their shared unworthiness, and it is worth finding, and it is worth the trouble of getting past the many counterfeits to find the real thing, because the real thing is, I can tell you from the

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inside, unlike anything the street lets you see.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Argument I Never Made, and Why

THERE IS AN ARGUMENT for God that I never made as an atheist and that I have never leaned on as a believer, and I want to write about it, because the fact that I do not lean on it tells you something about the kind of belief I have and the kind I do not, and because the skeptic needs to know which arguments I take seriously and which I hold at arm's length, so that he can trust me when I do press an argument, knowing that I am not the kind of believer who presses every argument he can find regardless of its strength.

The argument I never made is the argument from design in its crude form, the argument that looks at the complexity of living things and concludes that they must have been directly assembled by a designer because they are too intricate to have arisen by natural processes. I did not make this argument as an atheist because I understood, correctly, that it was answered by the theory of evolution, that the appearance of design in living things is produced by natural selection acting on variation over deep time, and that this is

one of the most well-established results in all of science, and I have not adopted this argument as a believer, because I still understand that evolution is true, and I have no quarrel with it, and I regard the believers who quarrel with it as doing damage to the faith, handing the skeptic an easy victory, staking the credibility of belief on the falsity of a thing that is not false, and thereby teaching a generation of young people that they must choose between their faith and their biology, which is a false choice and a cruel one, and I will not participate in it.

I say this because I want the skeptic to understand that the God I came to believe in is not the God of the gaps, the God invoked to explain the things science has not yet explained, the God who lives in the shrinking territory of our ignorance and retreats every time the territory shrinks further. That God is a bad idea and a doomed one, and the skeptic is right to reject him, and I reject him too, because a God who is only the name for what we do not yet understand will die the death of a thousand explanations, will be pushed back and back as the gaps close, until there is nowhere left for him to stand, and the atheist writers who spend their energy closing the gaps are, in a sense, doing the believer a favor, killing off a false god that the believer should never have worshipped, clearing the ground of the idol so that the real question can be seen.

Because the real question is not in the gaps. The real question is not what science cannot yet explain but what science, however complete, could never explain, and these are different in kind, and the whole confusion of the design argument is that it locates God in the first when the real case is in the second. Science cannot yet explain many things, and it will explain most of them in time, and a God placed in that

territory is a God with an expiration date. But there are things science could not explain even in principle, even if it explained everything within its domain perfectly, because they are not within its domain, they are the conditions of its domain, and I named some of them earlier, why there is something rather than nothing, why the universe is intelligible at all, why there are laws for things to obey, why there is consciousness, why there is moral obligation, why there is a self that asks these questions, and these are not gaps in our current knowledge that further research will close, they are structural features of the whole situation that no amount of research within the situation could ever account for, because they are prior to the research, the ground on which the research stands.

The God of the gaps has an expiration date, and the skeptic is right to bury him. The real question is not what science has not yet explained but what science, however complete, could never explain, because it is the condition of the explaining.

SO THE BELIEF I hold is not a belief that fills gaps, and it does not compete with science, and it will not be pushed back as the gaps close, because it was never standing in the gaps, it is standing where science does not and cannot go, in the

questions that are prior to and presupposed by the whole scientific enterprise, and this is why the closing of the gaps, which so troubled the God-of-the-gaps believer, does not trouble me at all, why I can read the latest advance in physics or biology with pleasure and not anxiety, because nothing science discovers within the world can touch a God who is the ground of there being a world at all, and the skeptic who thinks he has refuted God by pointing to the success of science has refuted only the idol, only the God who was mistakenly placed in the gaps, and has left entirely untouched the God who was always standing where the science cannot reach, and I would rather the skeptic understood this and rejected the real thing than went on triumphing over an idol that neither of us should have believed in, because a victory over an idol is not a victory over God, it is only the clearing away of a false picture, and behind the false picture the real question stands exactly where it always stood, unaddressed by the whole triumph, waiting.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Slow Erosion of My Certainties

I WANT TO DESCRIBE the actual mechanism of how my unbelief came apart, not the night it broke, which I have described, but the long slow years before the night, the erosion, because it did not come apart all at once, it came apart the way a coastline comes apart, imperceptibly, one grain at a time, so that on any given day nothing seemed to have changed and over years the whole shape was different, and I think this is how most large changes of mind actually happen, not by the sudden overturning of a position but by the slow erosion of the confidence that held it, and I want to trace the erosion because the skeptic who is in the middle of it may not recognize it as it happens, may think, as I thought, that nothing is changing, when in fact everything is.

It began, as far as I can locate a beginning, with a series of small cracks in my certainty, each one individually manageable, none of them sufficient to overturn the position, but cumulatively corrosive in a way I did not track. The first crack was the discovery, which I described, that my moral

outrage was borrowing from a warehouse my atheism could not account for, and this did not make me a believer, it just introduced a small permanent discomfort, a stone in the shoe, a thing I could not fully resolve and learned to walk with. And then there were other stones, the argument from beauty that would not leave me alone, the argument from consciousness that my materialism could not close, the recognition that science had not settled the metaphysical question I thought it had settled, the historical evidence for the resurrection that cost more to explain away than I had assumed, and each of these was a stone, and none of them was a proof, and I could have carried any one of them indefinitely, and what happened was not that any single stone became too heavy but that the stones accumulated, that I found myself walking with more and more of them, and that the cumulative weight of the things my position could not account for slowly began to exceed the weight of the things it could.

This is how it actually works, I think, and it is worth the skeptic knowing, because the popular picture of conversion, and of deconversion too, is of a single decisive argument that overturns everything, and this is almost never how it happens, because a single argument, however good, meets a mind that has many resources for resisting a single argument, and the mind deploys the resources and the argument is neutralized and the position survives. What the position cannot survive is the slow accumulation of many small unresolved difficulties, none of them individually fatal, because the mind cannot deploy its full resources against all of them at once, cannot keep all the plates spinning, and eventually the effort of holding the position against the accumulated weight of everything it cannot account for

becomes greater than the effort of letting it go, and the position falls, not because it was refuted but because it became too expensive to maintain, and this is what happened to me, and it is what I meant when I described the night it broke as a matter of my arms finally failing, because the arms had been failing for years, grain by grain, stone by stone, and the night was only the moment the last of the strength gave out.

And I want to name the thing that made the erosion possible, the thing without which the stones would have made no difference, which was a decision I had made long before, almost the only genuinely virtuous decision in the whole story, the decision to be honest, to follow the truth wherever it led, to not protect my position from evidence that told against it, and this decision was the crack through which everything eventually came, because a man who has decided to be honest cannot, in the end, keep a position that the honesty is eroding, he can only delay, and the delay costs more and more, and the honesty keeps working, keeps letting the stones in, keeps refusing to let him deploy the dishonest resources that would have protected the position, the selective attention, the motivated reasoning, the convenient forgetting, and I had ruled those out, not perfectly, no one rules them out perfectly, but enough, enough that the erosion could proceed, enough that the truth could get in, and this is why I say to the skeptic that the honesty he prides himself on is the most dangerous thing about him, dangerous to his unbelief, because a genuinely honest unbeliever has already, whether he knows it or not, opened the one door through which belief can eventually come, the door of the willingness to be wrong, and a man who is genuinely willing to be wrong about the deepest thing is a man whose position is not safe,

however secure it feels, because he has surrendered in advance the only weapons that could have kept it safe against the truth.

My unbelief did not fall to a single argument. It fell to erosion, one grain at a time, over years, and the thing that let the erosion happen was the one virtue I had, the decision to be honest, which turned out to be the door through which everything came.

I SAY ALL OF this to the skeptic not to alarm him but to reframe his situation, because if he is honest, genuinely honest, and I believe many skeptics are more honest than the believers who condescend to them, then he should know that his honesty is not the guarantee of his unbelief but the greatest threat to it, that a dishonest man can hold any position forever because he can protect it from the evidence, but an honest man holds his position only as long as the evidence permits, and has committed himself in advance to letting it go when the evidence turns, and this is a frightening commitment, and it is the right one, and it is the one that walked me across, and I would not want the skeptic to abandon it, because it is the best thing about him, and it is the thing most likely, in the end, to bring him home, not against his honesty but through it, not by making him less

rigorous but by his rigor at last turning on the position his rigor had been serving, and following the truth all the way, even to the place he had sworn he would never go.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

What I Lost, and Do Not Want Back

I HAVE WRITTEN A great deal about what I gained, and I have written honestly about what belief cost me, and I want now to write about a third thing, the things I lost that I do not want back, because there were real losses in leaving atheism, and I have named the ones I grieve, the clean freedom, the intellectual ease, the approval of my old company, but there were also things I lost that I am glad to be rid of, and naming them completes the honesty, because a man who only mourns what he left behind is as dishonest as a man who only celebrates it, and I left behind some things that were killing me, and I want to say what they were.

The first thing I lost, and do not want back, was the loneliness, and I have to be careful how I say this, because the loneliness of atheism is not the loneliness of having no friends, I had friends, good ones, it is a deeper thing, a metaphysical loneliness, the loneliness of a mind that believes itself to be, at bottom, alone in an indifferent universe, a brief accident of consciousness in a cosmos that

does not know it is there and will not notice when it is gone, and I had made my peace with this loneliness, had even found a bleak dignity in it, the dignity of the man who faces his cosmic solitude without flinching, and I do not want it back, because it was, I can see now from the other side, a kind of slow starvation, a hunger I had learned to stop feeling, and the difference between then and now is not that I have friends now and did not then, I had friends then, it is that the universe is no longer empty of a face turned toward me, that at the bottom of things there is not indifference but attention, not a void but a Someone, and I did not know how heavy the loneliness had been until it lifted, the way you do not know how much you have been carrying until you set it down.

The second thing I lost, and do not want back, was the particular exhaustion I described as the constant low effort of holding a door shut, the muscular labor of the soul that I had performed for so long that I had stopped feeling it as labor, and I did not know it was labor until it stopped, and when it stopped I understood that I had been tired in a way I had no name for, tired all the way down, tired with the specific tiredness of a man who is at war with something and cannot rest because the war never stops, and the war did stop, on the night it broke, when I stopped holding the door, and the rest that came was not the rest of a problem solved but the rest of a fight abandoned, the deep rest of a man who has finally stopped resisting and discovered that the thing he was resisting was not the enemy he had taken it for, and I do not want the exhaustion back, and I did not know how much of my energy it had been consuming until it was returned to me.

And the third thing I lost, and this is the hardest to say and the truest, was a certain kind of pride, the pride I described early in this book, the pride of being the one who saw clearly,

who was not fooled, who had grown up while others remained children, and I want to say that losing this pride was a loss, it was a real diminishment, a stepping down from a height I had enjoyed, and I felt the loss and I have told you I still feel it in certain rooms, but I do not want it back, because I can see now what it was costing me, that it was isolating me, that it was setting me above the people around me in a way that made real love difficult, that it was a barrier between me and everyone I had quietly judged for their credulity, and that the loss of it, painful as it was, was the removal of a wall I had built around myself, and that on the far side of the wall were people I could now love without condescension, could meet as a fellow struggler rather than as a superior, and that the pride had been a kind of prison with a very good view, and that I had mistaken the view for freedom, and that I do not want to go back into the prison no matter how good the view was.

*I lost the loneliness, and the
exhaustion, and the pride, and I
grieved none of them once they were
gone. I had mistaken all three for
virtues, and they were wounds I had
learned to wear as armor.*

THERE IS A STRANGE arithmetic to all of this, and I want to end the chapter on it, because it does not add up the way you would expect. I lost real things in leaving atheism, and I

gained real things, and the losses and the gains are not commensurable, cannot be weighed against each other on a single scale, and I would not want to present the change as a good bargain, a net positive, because that language cheapens it, makes it a transaction, and it was not a transaction, it was more like a death and a birth, the death of a self and the coming into being of another, and you do not evaluate a death and a birth by weighing the losses against the gains, because the self that is born is not the self that died and cannot run the comparison, and the man I am now cannot fully remember what it was to be the man I was, and the man I was could not have imagined what it would be to be the man I am, and between them there is not a bargain but a discontinuity, a before and an after with a gap in the middle that no arithmetic crosses, and all I can say from the after is that I do not want to go back, that the things I lost I do not miss, that the things I mourn I would not trade the gains to recover, and that the whole change, losses and gains together, was not a good deal, it was a resurrection, and you do not ask whether a resurrection was a good deal, you only report that the dead man is somehow alive, and that he does not want to return to the grave, however comfortable the grave had become.

CHAPTER FORTY

The Two Kinds of Doubt

I HAVE WRITTEN ABOUT doubt as one thing, but it is not one thing, it is two, and distinguishing them was one of the most important things I learned on the far side of belief, because I had, as an atheist, run the two kinds together, and running them together had made my unbelief feel more secure than it was, and separating them is a service I can do for the skeptic, who is very likely running them together too, the way I did.

The first kind of doubt is intellectual doubt, the doubt that arises from arguments and evidence, the doubt that says this claim is not sufficiently supported, or this claim is contradicted by that fact, or this position has difficulties it cannot resolve, and this is the doubt that most of this book has addressed, the doubt of the mind examining the case, and it is real and it is honorable and it must be taken seriously, and I have tried to take it seriously throughout, at full strength, without flinching. But there is a second kind of doubt that is not intellectual at all, though it disguises itself as intellectual, and it is the doubt that arises from the will, from the heart, from the parts of us that do not want a thing to be true regardless of the evidence, and this doubt does not come

from arguments, it uses arguments, it reaches for whatever arguments are available to justify a resistance that is prior to and independent of any argument, and this is the more dangerous kind, because it is the kind that cannot be answered by evidence, since it was never actually based on evidence, and it will always find a new argument when the old one is answered, because the argument was never the real ground.

I had both kinds, and I could not tell them apart, and this is the crucial thing, that the second kind wears the mask of the first, that the doubt of the will presents itself to consciousness as the doubt of the mind, so that a resistance rooted in the heart appears to the person as a purely intellectual objection, and he honestly believes he is following the evidence when he is in fact following his resistance and recruiting the evidence to serve it, and this is not lying, he is not consciously deceiving himself, the deception is deeper than consciousness, it is the way the will bends the perception before the perception reaches awareness, so that by the time he examines his objection it has already been shaped to serve a purpose he cannot see. And I did this for years, and I did not know I was doing it, and the way I finally found out was not by introspection, because introspection cannot catch it, the whole point is that it operates below the level introspection can reach, the way I found out was by watching my own behavior, watching what happened when an argument I had relied on was answered, and noticing that I did not feel relief, did not feel the pleasure of a problem solved, but felt instead a flash of threat and immediately went looking for a new argument, and that this pattern, the endless replacement of answered objections with new ones, the moving of the goalposts, is the signature of the doubt of the

will, because a mind genuinely following the evidence is glad when an objection is answered, and a will resisting a conclusion is not glad, it is threatened, and reaches for reinforcements.

The test, then, and it is a test I offer the skeptic to run on himself, is not whether he has objections, because everyone has objections and objections are legitimate, the test is what happens in him when an objection is answered. Does he feel the movement toward truth as a relief, or as a threat. When a difficulty he raised is genuinely addressed, does he update, does the answered objection stay answered, or does he immediately produce another, and then another, in an endless series, never satisfied, never moving, always one more reason why he still cannot believe. Because if the objections are the real ground of his unbelief, then answering them should move him, at least a little, at least eventually, and if answering them never moves him, if there is always another and the position never shifts no matter how many are addressed, then the objections are not the real ground, they are the servants of a resistance that lies deeper, and no amount of answering objections will ever reach it, because it does not live where the objections live, it lives in the will, and it can only be addressed at the level of the will, which is a different and harder and more personal thing than argument.

*The test is not whether you have
objections. Everyone has objections.
The test is what happens in you when
an objection is answered. A relief, or a*

threat, and a reaching for the next one.

AND I WANT TO be scrupulously fair here, because this argument can be abused, and the believers who wield it usually abuse it, turning it into an unanswerable accusation, a way of dismissing every objection as mere resistance of the will, so that the skeptic can never win, because if his objection is answered he updates and if it is not he is just resisting, and this is a trap and a dishonest one and I refuse it. The doubt of the will is real, but so is the doubt of the mind, and the believer who explains away every intellectual objection as heart-resistance is doing exactly what I have accused the skeptic of doing in reverse, protecting his position from evidence by attributing all disagreement to bad faith, and this is contemptible, and I have seen believers do it, and I want no part of it. Both kinds of doubt are real, and the honest person, believer or skeptic, has to attend to both, has to take the intellectual objections seriously as intellectual objections and answer them or admit they cannot be answered, and also has to examine his own will, honestly, for the resistance that may be shaping his perception, and this examination cuts both ways, the believer must ask whether his belief is the doubt of the will in reverse, whether he believes because he wants to and not because the evidence warrants it, and I ask myself this, and I have to keep asking it, because the will bends belief as easily as it bends unbelief, and the only defense against it, on either side, is the relentless honesty that keeps asking, of every conviction, whether it is held because it is true or because it is wanted, and that never lets the question rest, on either side of the divide.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

The Testimony I Cannot Give and the One I Can

THERE IS A KIND of testimony I cannot give, and I want to be clear about its absence, because the skeptic is right to be suspicious of the testimonies believers usually offer, and I do not want to offer him one of those and have him rightly dismiss it and dismiss me with it. I cannot give you the testimony of certainty. I cannot stand before you and say I know God exists the way I know the sun rose this morning, because I do not know it that way, and anyone who says he does is either using the word know in a different sense or is not being honest with you or with himself, and I have committed in this book to not doing that, so I will not do it now, at the end, when it would be most tempting.

I cannot give you the testimony of the miracle you could verify. I have seen things in my years of ministry that I cannot explain, prayers answered in ways that strained coincidence, changes in people that seemed to exceed what ordinary processes should produce, but I hold these quietly and I do not build arguments on them, because I know how testimony

of that kind sounds to the skeptic, I know because I was the skeptic and I heard it and I discounted it, correctly, because a report of a marvel from an interested party who wants it to be true is worth very little as evidence, and I will not insult your intelligence by piling up marvels and asking you to be moved by them, because I would not have been moved by them, and I respect you too much to try on you what would not have worked on me.

And I cannot give you the testimony of a life so transformed that it constitutes a proof, because my life is not so transformed, I am not a saint, I am a struggling and failing man who happens to have been found, and if you looked at my life you would not see a proof of God, you would see a flawed man doing his best and often failing, and the changes I described in the chapter on the slow remaking of a will are real but they are partial and they are the kind of changes that a skeptic could attribute to many causes, to therapy or maturity or the ordinary softening of a hard man over time, and I cannot prove they came from where I say they came from, and I will not pretend I can.

So here is the testimony I can give, the only one, and it is smaller than the ones I cannot give but it is true, and I offer it for whatever it is worth, which may be nothing to you, and I accept that. I can testify that I was an atheist, a real one, a serious one, that I did not want to believe, that I had reasons and I still respect the reasons, that I resisted belief with everything I had, with my pride and my intellect and the whole momentum of my life and the deep wound that armed me against the very idea of a Father, and that belief came anyway, over my resistance, not as the granting of a wish, because I did not wish it, but as the loss of a fight I had been fighting so long I had forgotten I was fighting it. I can testify

that the thing that came did not have the texture of something I made, that it came with a claim on me I would not have designed and told me things about myself I did not want to hear, and that it has stayed, through years of doubt, not as a certainty but as a presence I keep returning to and being met by, and that it has changed me, slowly, in directions I did not choose and could not have manufactured, and that I cannot prove any of this to you, and that I am not trying to.

*I cannot give you certainty, or a
verifiable miracle, or a life so changed
it proves anything. I can only tell you
that I did not want this, fought it, and
was found anyway, and that it has
never let me go.*

THAT IS THE TESTIMONY, and I know exactly how much and how little it is worth. It is worth nothing as a proof, because a single man's report of his inner life proves nothing to anyone but himself, and the skeptic is right to say so, and I say so too. But it may be worth something as a witness, not a proof but a witness, which is a different thing, the report of one who was where you are and is now somewhere else, and who is telling you not that you must follow but only that the road exists, that it is possible to go from where you are to where he is, not by being argued across but by being honest all the way and letting the honesty do its slow work, and that the person you would become on the other side is not the

credulous fool you fear becoming but is, in the ways that matter, more honest than the man you are now, because he has followed the honesty further, all the way to the place it was leading, even the place he swore he would never go. I am not asking you to believe my testimony. I am asking you to consider that it is possible, that a man like you, with reasons like yours and resistance like yours and even a wound like yours, made this crossing, not by betraying his mind but by following it, and that if it happened to him it could happen to you, and that the door you are so sure is a wall may be a door, and that the only way to find out is to keep being honest, which you are already doing, which means you are already, whether you know it or not, on the road.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

The Far Side of the Question

I WANT TO DESCRIBE what it is like to live on the far side of the question that consumed the first half of my life, because there is something the skeptic cannot know from where he stands, which is what happens to the question itself once it is answered, or rather once it is lived rather than debated, and it is not what I expected, and I think it would have surprised the man I was, and it may reframe the whole thing for the man reading this.

When I was an atheist, the question of God was the largest question in my intellectual life, the one under all the others, the one I returned to and argued about and read about and defined myself in relation to, and I assumed that if I ever came to believe, the question would be settled, would move from the foreground to the background, would become a solved thing I could stop thinking about and get on with living. And this is not what happened, and the way it did not happen is instructive. The question did not get settled and recede. It got answered and expanded. It stopped being a

question I was trying to solve and became a relationship I was trying to live, and a relationship is not a solved thing you can stop thinking about, it is an ongoing reality that occupies more of your life the more real it becomes, not less, so that God, far from receding into the background once I believed, moved into the foreground of everything, became the light I saw other things by rather than one more object I saw, and this is a total reorientation and not a mere addition of one new belief to my existing set.

This is the thing I most want the skeptic to understand about what he is considering, that belief in God is not the addition of one item, God, to his existing inventory of beliefs, is not like coming to believe in an additional entity, a large invisible thing that now exists alongside the other things, and I think the skeptic often imagines it this way, imagines that to become a believer would be to add God to his ontology while leaving everything else in place, and that this is why it seems both unnecessary, why add an entity the world does not require, and slightly absurd, like adding a belief in a very large person who happens to be invisible. But that is not what belief is, and the misunderstanding is total, because God, if God is real, is not one more entity in the inventory, is not a thing among things, is the ground of there being an inventory at all, the source and context of everything else, so that coming to believe is not adding an item but changing the frame, reinterpreting the whole of what you already knew in a new light, the way you might reinterpret a whole relationship in the light of a single new fact about the other person, so that nothing in the inventory changes and everything means something different.

And living on the far side of this reframing is like living in a world that has been re-lit, where all the same things are

present, the suffering and the beauty and the moral law and the ordinary business of days, but they are lit differently, they mean differently, they point somewhere they did not point before, so that the beauty that once ached toward nothing now aches toward Someone, and the moral obligation that once floated groundless now rests on a will, and the suffering that once was merely tragic now is tragic and also held, and the ordinary business of days that once was merely what happened now is the theater of a relationship, and none of the facts have changed, the same world is present, but the world has become the front of a house that has a back, the surface of a depth, the visible face of an invisible love, and I did not add a belief, I moved into a re-lit world, and I cannot move back, not because I am forbidden but because I cannot un-see the light once I have seen by it, cannot make the world flat again once it has acquired its depth, and this is why the change is a resurrection and not a conclusion, because you do not conclude your way into a re-lit world, you wake up in it, and the waking cannot be undone by argument, though it can be doubted, and I doubt it, and I keep waking up in it anyway.

*Belief is not adding God to your
inventory of things. It is having the
whole inventory re-lit, so that nothing
changes and everything means
something different, and you cannot
make the world flat again once you*

have seen its depth.

I DO NOT KNOW how to give this to the skeptic, and I have thought about it for years, because it is the thing I would most want to give and it is the thing that cannot be given by argument, because it is not a conclusion but a way of seeing, and ways of seeing cannot be transmitted by proof, only occasioned, invited, waited for. All I can do is describe it, the re-lit world, the depth behind the surface, the ache that found its object and the obligation that found its ground and the suffering that found its companion, and tell the skeptic that this is what is on the other side of the question he is debating, not a solved problem but a re-lit world, not one more belief but a different way of seeing everything he already knows, and that I cannot argue him into it, and that no one argued me into it, that it came when the arguing stopped, when the door I was holding shut finally opened, and that behind the door was not a proposition but a Presence, and not a conclusion but a country, and that the country is where I live now, and that I am writing to him from inside it, across a border I remember crossing, one reluctant former enemy to another, to say only that the country is real, and that the crossing is possible, and that the light, on this side, is very good.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

The Objection That God Is a Projection

I HAVE TOUCHED ON this objection throughout, because it is the one aimed most precisely at me, the fatherless man who came to believe in a Father, but I have not given it a full and direct hearing, and I owe it one, because it is the strongest form of the psychological case against my faith, and it goes back to Feuerbach in the nineteenth century and through Freud, and it is the objection that God is a projection, that human beings create God in the image of their needs, that the divine Father is the wish for a human father written across the sky, and that religion is, in Freud's phrase, the wish-fulfillment of the helpless child in all of us, and I have to face this at full strength, because if it is right, then everything in this book is the elaborate self-deception of a wounded man, and I would rather know that than go on deceived.

Here is the objection in its full force, aimed at me specifically. You were a boy without a father. You carried that wound your whole life. You constructed an unbelief that protected you from the pain of hoping for a father who would

not come. And then, in a moment of exhaustion and loneliness, your defenses failed and your deepest wish, the wish for a father who stays, produced its object, conjured a heavenly Father precisely shaped to your wound, a Father who does not leave, who loves unconditionally, who was there all along, and the very perfection of the fit, the way this God answers your specific pain, is not evidence that he is real but the clearest possible evidence that you made him up, because a real God would not be so exactly tailored to the hole in one particular man, only a projected one would fit so well, and your whole conversion is Exhibit A in Freud's case, the helpless child conjuring the Father he needs, and calling the conjuring a revelation.

I have sat with this for years, and I want to give the honest answer, which begins by conceding everything that can be conceded, because the objection has real force and pretending otherwise would be the dishonesty I have sworn off. Yes, I needed a father. Yes, the Christian God answers that need with terrible precision. Yes, the fit between my wound and my faith is real, and if you wanted to construct a case that my belief is a projection, you could hardly design a better subject than a fatherless man who came to believe in a Father, and I feel the weight of this, and I will not wave it away. The fit is real. The need is real. The vulnerability to exactly this projection is real. I concede it all.

And then I make the two points I have made before, but I want to make them here directly against Feuerbach and Freud, because they are the points on which the objection, for all its force, finally breaks. The first is the point from Lewis about desire, which is that a need is not, in general, evidence against the reality of the thing needed, that hunger is not evidence there is no food, that in every other case a deep and

structural human need corresponds to a real object, and that the projection theory has to claim that this one need, alone among all human needs, is the exception, the hunger that corresponds to nothing, and that this claim requires its own argument and does not follow merely from the existence of the need, so that the fit between my wound and my faith is exactly what you would expect on either theory, on the projection theory because I made the God to fit the wound, and on the theory that the God is real because the wound is the shape of a real absence, a real need for a real Father, and the fit alone cannot distinguish between these two, the fit is equally predicted by both, and so the fit, which the objection treats as its trump card, is not evidence for the projection theory at all, it is neutral between the theories, and the objection has to look elsewhere for its support, and elsewhere it does not find it.

The fit between my wound and my faith is exactly what you would expect if I made God up. It is also exactly what you would expect if the wound was the shape of a real absence. The fit cannot tell you which.

AND THE SECOND POINT is the one the projection theory cannot survive, the point about resistance, and I have made it before but here it is decisive. The projection theory predicts that the fatherless man, driven by his wish for a father, would

be inclined toward belief, would reach for it, would find it easy, because it fulfills his deepest wish, and the whole mechanism of the theory is that the wish generates the belief. But my actual history is the reverse, and this is the fact the theory cannot accommodate. My fatherlessness did not incline me toward belief in a heavenly Father, it armed me against it, made the very idea unbearable, a cruelty, the one hope I could least afford to entertain, because to hope for a Father who stays was to reopen the wound of the father who left and to make myself vulnerable again to the specific devastation that had nearly destroyed the boy, and so I resisted belief in a Father more fiercely than I resisted any other claim, precisely because I had more to lose, and belief came anyway, over that resistance, against that wish-not-to, and a belief that arrives against the wish is not a wish-fulfillment, it is the opposite of a wish-fulfillment, it is a wish-frustration overcome by something stronger than the wish, and Freud's theory has no category for this, for the belief that comes not because you want it but because it defeats your want, and my conversion was exactly that, the defeat of my want by something I did not want, and that is the one thing the projection theory cannot explain, and it is the thing that happened, and so I do not think, having sat with it honestly for years, that the projection theory accounts for me, though I concede it accounts for much, and though I hold my rejection of it, like everything, with the doubt I hold everything, and I could be wrong, and I have decided I am probably not, and here I am.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

The Kindness I Did Not Deserve

I WANT TO WRITE about a specific thing that happened in the years of my slow crossing, because it was not an argument and it was not the pressure I have described and it was not the night it broke, it was a series of small human kindnesses from believers, and I have not given it enough weight in this book, which has been so concerned with arguments and inner experiences, and I want to correct that, because the truth is that the arguments would have found a cold and defended man if the man had not also been, over years, warmed by people who had no obvious reason to be kind to him, and I have come to think the kindness did as much as the arguments, and I owe it a chapter.

I was not an easy man to be kind to, in my atheist years, when it came to believers, because I approached them with a settled condescension, a readiness to catch them in their contradictions, a barely concealed sense that I was cleverer than they were and that their kindness was probably a technique, a softening-up before the pitch, and I want to

confess this condescension plainly because it is ugly and it was real and it is a thing many skeptics do to believers, treat their warmth as a strategy, their friendship as evangelism in disguise, their kindness as a manipulation, and this suspicion is itself a kind of cruelty, a refusal to let the other person simply be kind, an insistence on reading a motive into a gift, and I did it, and I did it to people who did not deserve it, who were simply being kind, and who kept being kind even after I had made my condescension clear, which is the thing that eventually undid the condescension, because a technique stops when it is not working, and their kindness did not stop.

There was a man, a believer, whom I argued with for years, and I argued with him the way I argued with everyone, to win, to expose the weakness in his position, to demonstrate my superiority, and he never once responded to my arguing in kind, never got defensive, never tried to win, never treated me as an opponent to be defeated, and at first I read this as weakness, as the inability to defend his position, and I pressed harder, and he still would not fight, and slowly I began to understand that he was not failing to fight, he was declining to, that he had made a decision not to treat me as an enemy no matter how I treated him, and that this decision was not a technique, because I gave him every reason to abandon it and he did not, and that a kindness that persists through years of condescension and refuses to convert into hostility no matter how it is provoked is a strange thing, an anomalous thing, a thing my model of human motivation did not predict, and I began to wonder where it came from, and he told me, when I finally asked, that he was kind to me because he had been shown a kindness he did not deserve and could not stop passing it on, and that he did not need me to agree with him and did not love me in order to convert me

but simply because he had been loved and it had overflowed, and I did not believe him at the time, but I could not explain him either, and the inability to explain him was itself a small stone in the shoe, one more thing my atheism could not quite account for, the persistence of an unearned kindness that asked nothing back.

I have come to think that this is how most people actually cross, not by arguments, though the arguments matter, but by encountering, in some believer, a quality of love that their model of the world does not predict and cannot explain, a kindness that is not a technique, a warmth that persists through rejection, a refusal to treat them as an enemy, and that this encounter does something the arguments cannot do, it makes the thing plausible at the level of the heart, it shows rather than tells, it lets the skeptic see, in a human face, what the doctrine claims about the divine face, and I saw it, in that man and in others, over years, and it warmed a ground the arguments could then work in, and I do not think the arguments would have taken in a heart that had not first been warmed, and I record this because the church, in its anxiety to have the right arguments, often forgets that it was never primarily the arguments that crossed anyone over, it was the love, the specific unearned persistent love of particular believers who refused to give up on particular skeptics, and that I was crossed over as much by kindness as by evidence, and that the kindness was, in a way I only understood later, itself a form of evidence, the evidence of a life that could only be explained by the thing it claimed.

*A kindness that persists through years
of condescension and refuses to become
hostility no matter how it is provoked
is a strange thing, and I could not
explain it, and the inability to explain
it was one more stone in the shoe.*

AND I TRY, NOW, to be that man, for the skeptics in my life, to be the kindness that does not convert into hostility, that does not treat the argument as a battle to be won, that loves without requiring agreement, that keeps being kind after the condescension has made itself clear, and I fail at this often, because the old combativeness is still in me and I still want to win arguments and I still feel the flash of pride when I catch a skeptic in a contradiction, and I have to keep repenting of it, keep laying it down, keep remembering that no one was ever loved into the kingdom by being defeated, that I was not crossed over by the man who beat me in an argument, I was crossed over by the man who refused to have the argument on those terms, who declined my enmity, who kept the door of his kindness open through years of my trying to slam it, and that if I want to be of any use to the skeptics I love, I must be that door, and not the fortress I was so good at being, and this is harder than any apologetics, and it is the apologetics that actually works, and I am still learning it, and I will be learning it until I die.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

The Long Obedience I Did Not Expect

I WANT TO WRITE about the shape of the life that follows belief, the long stretch of years that the conversion narratives never cover because they end at the conversion, and I want to call it by the phrase that has meant the most to me, a long obedience in the same direction, because that phrase, which is not mine, captures the thing I least expected about the far side of belief, which is that it is long, that it is not an event but a duration, that the crossing I have spent this book describing was the beginning of something that has no natural end short of death, and that the real substance of faith is not the dramatic moment but the long quiet faithfulness that follows it, the showing up, day after day, to a relationship that no longer has the vividness of its beginning but has instead the deeper thing that only duration can produce.

The dramatic moment, the night it broke, was real, and I have described it, and I would not diminish it, but I have come to see that it was, in the economy of a whole life of faith, a small part, the ignition rather than the engine, and that a

faith that lives on the memory of its dramatic beginning is a thin faith, prone to collapse when the vividness fades, as it always fades, and that the mature thing is the faith that survives the fading, that keeps walking in the direction the moment pointed long after the moment itself has become a distant memory, on the strength not of feeling but of fidelity, the way a long marriage lives not on the memory of the wedding but on ten thousand ordinary days of choosing the same person again, most of them unremarkable, none of them dramatic, and yet the accumulation of them constituting a love deeper than any wedding day could contain.

And this is a thing the skeptic cannot see from where he stands, because he is looking at the conversion, at the moment of belief, and he is either skeptical of it as a mere emotional event or attracted to it as a dramatic transformation, and either way he is looking at the wrong thing, because the moment is not where the substance is, the substance is in the years after, in the long obedience, in the showing up to prayer on the mornings when nothing is felt, in the returning to the community after being wounded by it, in the continuing to believe through the seasons of doubt, in the keeping of the commitments made in the vivid moment through the long unvivid stretches when the commitments feel like duty rather than joy, and this long faithfulness is the actual life of faith, and it is invisible to the skeptic, who sees only the dramatic entrance and not the long quiet dwelling, and who therefore misunderstands what he is considering, imagines it to be a matter of achieving a certain experience, when it is a matter of undertaking a certain fidelity, of the same kind and the same difficulty as any other lifelong fidelity a human being undertakes.

I did not expect this, and I want to be honest that I have sometimes resented it, because the vividness was so sweet that its fading felt like a loss, like the withdrawal of something I had been given, and there were seasons when I wondered whether the fading meant the thing had not been real, whether I was left with only the memory of a feeling that had proven temporary, and I had to learn, slowly, that the fading is not the withdrawal of the reality but the maturing of the relationship, that all relationships move from the vividness of their beginning to the deeper and quieter substance of their duration, that the fading of the feeling is the condition for the growth of the fidelity, because a fidelity that depends on the feeling is not fidelity at all, it is just the enjoyment of a feeling, and it is only when the feeling fades that the fidelity can become itself, can become a choosing that is not merely the following of an inclination, and that God, apparently, wants the fidelity more than he wants to keep me in the honeymoon, and so he lets the honeymoon fade, so that the marriage can begin.

*The conversion was the ignition, not
the engine. The substance of faith is not
the dramatic moment but the long
obedience that follows it, most of it
unremarkable, all of it choosing the
same direction again.*

SO I HAVE LEARNED to live the long obedience, and I am in

the middle of it, years in, with years to go if I am granted them, and it is not what I expected and it is better than what I expected, deeper if less vivid, more substantial if less dramatic, and I would tell the skeptic that this is what he is actually considering, not a dramatic experience to be sought but a long fidelity to be undertaken, a direction to be walked in for the rest of his life, and that the walking is the thing, not the moment of setting out, and that the walking is hard, and long, and often unrewarded by feeling, and that it is nonetheless the most substantial thing a human being can do with a life, to walk faithfully in one direction toward the thing he has come to believe is true and good and worth his whole life, through the long stretches when he feels nothing, on the strength of a fidelity that has become deeper than feeling, and that this long obedience, undertaken and continued through everything, is what faith actually is, not the moment of belief but the lifetime of faithfulness, and that I am in the middle of it, and that I do not regret undertaking it, and that I would undertake it again, and that I am undertaking it again, this morning, and tomorrow morning, and every morning, in the same direction, toward the same Presence, for the rest of whatever life I am given, which is the only testimony that finally counts, not the drama of how I began but the length of how I have continued, and I intend to continue, and that intention, held through everything, is the truest thing I can offer you about what is on the far side of the crossing.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

To the Person I Was, One More Time

I HAVE WRITTEN ALREADY a chapter about what I would say to the man I was, but I find I am not done, that there is more, that as I come to the end of this book the man I was stands in front of me again and there are things I did not say to him the first time, and I want to say them now, at the close, because he is, in the end, the reader I am most writing for, and every skeptic reading this is a version of him, and the last words of this book should be, I think, addressed to him.

I would tell him, this time, not to hurry. I made my crossing over many years, and there were long stretches when nothing seemed to be happening, when the arguments had done their work and the pressure was there and nothing moved, and I was impatient, I wanted resolution, I wanted to know, and the wanting to know was itself a kind of obstacle, because it was the demand for certainty that I have said all through this book is the enemy of faith, the insistence on being sure before taking a step, and I would tell the man I was to stop demanding the resolution, to let the question be a

question, to live in it without forcing it, because the forcing does not work, the answer does not come to the man who grabs for it, it comes, if it comes, to the man who has learned to wait, to sit in the silence he has spent his life fleeing, to hold the question open without the anxious need to close it, and the closing, when it came for me, came not because I finally seized the answer but because I finally stopped seizing, and the man I was needed to hear that, and the skeptic needs to hear it, that the crossing is not a thing you achieve by effort, it is a thing you become available for by ceasing to strive, and that the striving to believe is as much an obstacle as the striving not to.

I would tell him that his suffering was not wasted, that the wound he carried, the fatherlessness, the ache, the loneliness he had explained away, was not merely damage to be overcome but was, though he could not see it, the very place where the door was, that the deepest wound was where the light would eventually get in, that the God he did not believe in would meet him not by healing around the wound but by entering it, by coming precisely to the place of the absence, and that the absence he had spent his life managing was the shape of the presence he was made for, and that he did not have to fix himself before he could be found, did not have to resolve the wound before he could believe, because the wound was not the obstacle to the finding, it was the site of it, and I wish someone had told me that when I was armoring myself against the very hope that would eventually save me, that the armor was around the wound and the wound was the door and the armor was keeping out the only thing that could heal it.

I would tell him that the people he condescended to, the believers, were not the fools he took them for, that some of

them were fools, as some of every group are fools, but that many of them had faced the same questions he was facing and had come through them to a place he could not yet imagine, and that his condescension was a wall he had built to keep from having to take them seriously, and that if he could bring himself to lower the wall, to approach even one of them not as an opponent to be defeated but as a possible fellow traveler who might know something he did not, he might find that the thing he was seeking had already been found by people he had dismissed, and that the seeking he thought was so lonely and so advanced was a seeking that a great cloud of others had completed before him, and that he was not the pioneer he imagined, he was a latecomer to a country long inhabited, and that the inhabitants were waiting for him with a patience he did not deserve and would eventually receive.

Stop demanding the resolution. The answer does not come to the man who grabs for it. It comes, if it comes, to the man who has learned to sit in the silence he spent his life fleeing.

AND I WOULD TELL him, last of all, the thing I most want every skeptic to hear, that he was loved, that he had always been loved, through every year of his fury and his brilliance and his refusal, that the love did not wait for him to believe in it before it began, that it was there in the loneliness he

explained away and the beauty that ached toward nothing and the moral outrage that borrowed from a warehouse he could not name and the kindness of the believers he condescended to and the pressure he fought and the silence he misread, that all of it was the love, coming toward him under a hundred disguises, patient, unhurried, refusing to force itself on a man who was fighting it, waiting for the arms to fail, and that when they failed it would not be defeat, though he feared it as defeat, it would be homecoming, the end of a war he had been fighting against the only one who had never stopped loving him, and that he did not have to believe this now, he only had to keep being honest, because the honesty was already, though he could not see it, the love at work in him, walking him home, one grain at a time, over years, toward a door he thought was a wall, behind which was not the void he had built his life to face but a Father, waiting, who had been waiting the whole time, and who would not say, where have you been, or why did you take so long, or how could you have doubted, but would say only the thing the father in the story says, the thing I did not believe could be said to me and that was said to me anyway, welcome home, welcome home, welcome home.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

What Remains

I HAVE TO END, and I do not want to end with resolution, because I promised you at the beginning that I would not, and because resolution would be a lie, and because the truest thing I know about faith is that it does not resolve, it deepens, and a book about it should end the way faith continues, with weight rather than closure, and so I want to end not by tying the threads but by naming what remains, what I still carry, what the crossing did not settle, because that is the honest ending and the only one I am willing to give.

What remains is the suffering. I told you early in this book that faith did not solve the problem of evil, that the child with bone cancer is still dead and I still do not know why, and I have to tell you at the end that this is still true, that all the years of belief have not resolved it, that I stand at the bedsides still and the question is still there, unanswered, and that faith has not made it hurt less, has only given me a companion in the hurt, the God who entered it rather than the God who explains it, and that this is not a solution, it is a presence in the absence of a solution, and I carry it, unresolved, and I will carry it until I die, and I have stopped expecting to set it down on this side of the grave.

What remains is the doubt. I told you that conversion did not end my doubt but moved it, and this is still true, that there are nights when the old skeptic sits at the foot of the bed and makes his case, and makes it well, because I trained him, and that I do not always have the answer, and that I go to sleep with the question open, and that this has not stopped in all the years of belief and I do not expect it to stop, and that I have made my peace not with certainty but with the absence of certainty, with the walking toward what I cannot see on the strength of a fidelity that is not the same as knowledge, and that this is what faith is, and it does not resolve into knowledge, it remains faith, which is to say it remains a trust held in the presence of the doubt and not in its absence, and I carry the doubt, and I will carry it until I die.

And what remains, most of all, is the wound, because I want to be honest at the very end that the fatherlessness is not gone, that faith did not erase it, that I am still, in the deepest layer of myself, a boy who waited at a window for a father who did not come, and that this has not been undone, it has been redeemed, which is a different thing, redeemed meaning not erased but taken up, made the site of a meeting, transformed from a pure loss into the place where I was found, but the loss is still a loss, the father still did not come, the boy still waited in vain for the man he needed, and no theology and no faith and no crossing has made that not have happened, has only made it not be the end of the story, and the difference between not having happened and not being the end of the story is the whole of what faith gave me, and it is everything and it is not the erasure of the wound, and I carry the wound, redeemed but not erased, and I will carry it until I die, and I have five sons who will never carry it because I stayed, and the staying came out of the wound, and so even

the wound has borne fruit, but it is still a wound, and I will not pretend at the end of this book that it is not.

*I do not end with resolution. I end with
what remains. The suffering unsolved,
the doubt unsilenced, the wound
redeemed but not erased. This is what
faith is. It does not close the questions.
It gives you a Presence to carry them
toward.*

SO THIS IS WHERE I leave you, not in the sunlit country of the certain, because there is no such country and the people who advertise it are selling you something, but in the real country, the one I actually live in, where a former atheist carries his unsolved suffering and his unsilenced doubt and his redeemed but unerased wound, and believes anyway, walks anyway, stays anyway, on the strength not of certainty but of a Presence he encountered once when his arms failed and has kept encountering ever since, a Presence he cannot prove to you and would not insult you by pretending to prove, that met him in the place of his deepest absence and has never left, though it has often been silent, and that he trusts through the silence the way you learn to trust a person through the times they are quiet, because he has come to know them well enough to trust them through what he cannot understand. That is the whole of it. That is what I found on

the other side of unbelief, not answers but a Presence, not certainty but a Companion, not the end of the questions but Someone to carry them toward, and it was not what I expected, and it was more than I expected, and it cost me everything I had built myself on, and I would pay it again, and I do, every morning, and I will tell you one last time that it is worth it, and that I cannot prove it, and that you do not have to believe me, and that the door you are so sure is a wall may be a door, and that I was as sure as you are, and that I was wrong, and that being wrong was the best thing that ever happened to me, and that I hope, with everything in me, across whatever distance separates us, that you will one day be wrong too, and find, as I found, that the thing you spent your life refusing was the thing you were made for, and that it had been coming toward you the whole time, patient and unhurried and unrelenting, waiting for your arms to fail, so that it could catch you, and carry you, and bring you, at last, home.